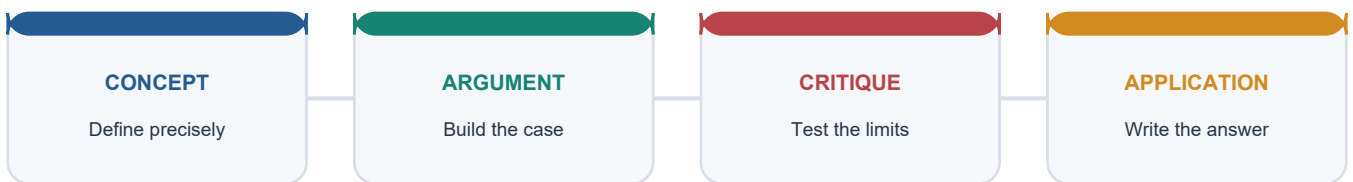


COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

Reason, Revelation and Faith - Learner-v2 Source-Complete Learning Session

UPSC Philosophy Optional | Paper II, Section B | 15 teaching sessions, 32 diagnostics, 11 solved PYQs, 6 original Mains models and consolidated register notes

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / SESSION INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Reason, Revelation and Faith - Learner-v2 Source-Complete Learning Session

Catalogue identity: Philosophy Optional · Philosophy Paper II - Philosophy of Religion · philosophy-paper-ii-philosophy-of-religion-05 **Syllabus clause, verbatim:** *Reason, Revelation and Faith.* **Evidence discipline:** doctrine, attribution and previous-year wording are controlled by the repository owner files. Every model answer here is independent learner practice and is never an official UPSC key. **Terminology rule:** English-first throughout. The English concept leads; the accurate Sanskrit or Pali term follows in parentheses in IAST.

Package practice counts

Component	Count
Taught sessions in the Basic block	15
Verified topic-owned previous-year questions	11 (2019-2025)
Core diagnostic MCQs	24
Remedial diagnostic MCQs	8
Total diagnostics	32
Question-specific option explanations	128
Unique examiner traps	32
Original solved Mains models	6 (2 x 10, 2 x 15, 2 x 20)
Consolidated register cards	15
ASCII master flow panels	20

BASIC LEARNING SESSION

Exact printed ownership and cross-topic firewall

The printed clause owns the **epistemic roles and relations of reason, revelation and faith** - their models of warrant, the authentication of a revelation-claim, committed reception, and the Indian-Western comparison of testimony and scripture.

Owned here	Boundary that is not crossed
reason as discovery, criticism, interpretation and regulation	the detailed arguments for God's existence belong to the Proofs for God owner
revelation as proposition, event, self-disclosure, and as general or special disclosure	the phenomenology and object of religious experience belong to the Religious Experience owner
faith as assent, trust, commitment and a way of life	the full meaning-and-falsification debate belongs to the Religious Language owner
competing revelations, used as an authentication and diversity defeater	the complete pluralist theories and the absolute-truth debate belong to the Religious Pluralism owner
miracles and testimony, used only as support for a revelation-claim	miracle metaphysics and empirical history must not replace the epistemic analysis
Indian testimony, scripture, reasoning and verification, used comparatively	the complete Mīmāṃsā, Nyāya, Vedānta and Buddhist epistemologies belong to Paper I owners

ANALYSIS: **[FACT]** Faith is not simply belief without evidence; revelation is not any intense experience; and reason includes probabilistic, interpretive, critical and regulative activity, not deductive proof alone. Almost every low-scoring script on this clause fails at one of these three points.

0A. Three concepts, three epistemic jobs

Concept	Core role	Forms it takes	Characteristic danger
Reason	discover, infer, test coherence, interpret and regulate belief	deductive; inductive and abductive; critical; hermeneutic	rationalism that permits only what reason can independently prove
Revelation	alleged divine self-disclosure unavailable or insecure through unaided reason	general or special; propositional or non-propositional	circular authentication, rival revelations, projection
Faith	receive, assent, trust, commit, and inhabit a religious way of life	belief-that; belief-in; trust; hope; fidelity	credulity, voluntarism, fanaticism, immunity from correction

[FACT] Regulative versus constitutive reason. Reason can veto contradiction, compare evidence, discipline interpretation and identify defeaters without being the source of all revealed content. That is a **critical-rational** model: faith remains revisable and answerable to objections even when it is not deduced from neutral premises.

[FACT] General versus special revelation. General revelation is disclosure allegedly available through nature, conscience or universal human history; special revelation is tied to particular events, persons, scriptures or communities. This distinction concerns **scope and medium**. The propositional/non-propositional distinction is a *different* axis: it concerns **what revelation is** - truth-content, or divine self-disclosure in an event.

MEMORY: Two axes, never one. Scope (general / special) and nature (propositional / non-propositional) cross each other. A script that collapses them into a single ladder loses the 2025 15-marker.

Local source and factual control

- John Hick, *Philosophy of Religion*, local searchable copy, print pp. 56-64 (PDF pp. 67-75), controls propositional revelation, voluntarist faith and ultimate concern.
- The local *Oxford Handbook of Philosophy of Religion* controls religious epistemology, miracles, and faith-and-revelation from print pp. 245, 304 and 323 respectively.
- Chatterjee and Datta's local PDF, especially pp. 245-249 and pp. 394-396, controls Nyāya testimony and Mīmāṃsā intrinsic validity. Paper I owners remain authoritative for full school doctrine.
- No miracle report, scientific result or transformative effect is treated here as self-authenticating proof.

Source-complete coverage ledger

[FACT] marks retained repository doctrine or verified question data. **[INFERENCE]** marks learner-facing organisation or judgement.

Owner material	Where it is taught here	Retention decision
Owner Section Section 0-4 (map, three jobs, reason, revelation, faith, four stances)	Sessions 1-10	Taught in full, with the two revelation axes separated
Owner Section 5 foundational statement bank	Sessions 8-9 and the quotation-discipline session	Retained, including the CAUTION: status of the "because absurd" slogan
Owner Section 6 applied drills and Section 6A parity bench	Sessions 14-15	Retained as answer routing and as a comparison bench
Owner Section 7 model-answer skeletons	Sessions 15 and the PYQ practice block	Retained and expanded into full solutions
Owner Section 9.1-9.5 doctrine dossiers	Sessions 2, 4, 5, 8, 9	Taught as core doctrine, not as optional enrichment
Owner Section 9.6 science and religion (2020 owner-module)	Session 13	Taught as core ; it carries a printed PYQ

Owner material	Where it is taught here	Retention decision
Owner Section 9.7 faith and belief (2020 owner-module)	Session 7	Taught as core ; it carries a printed PYQ
Owner Section 9.8 miracles and testimony	Session 12	Taught as core support for revelation-claims
Owner Section 9.9 evidentialism and Reformed epistemology (2023 owner-module)	Session 11	Taught as core ; the Advanced dossier records its promotion to Core on 15 August 2026
Owner Section Section 10-13 debates, criticisms, traps, keyword bank	Sessions 10, 14, 15 and the register notes	Retained in full
Owner Section Section 14-18 PYQ routing, answer architecture, directive decoder, verdict ladder, quotation discipline	Session 15 and the PYQ practice block	Retained in full
Advanced dossier Section 5	Optional Advanced block only	Second-order debates only; no core content depends on them

[INFERENCE] Correction recorded in this repair. Owner Section Section 9.6-9.9 and Section Section 10-18 are *core* owner modules - three of them carry printed previous-year questions, and the Advanced dossier's own promotion ledger states that Reformed epistemology versus evidentialism "now lives in Core and must not be described as Advanced-only". They are therefore taught inside the Basic block, and the Optional Advanced block now carries only genuinely second-order material.

Origin, chronology and anachronism control

A full calendar timeline is not the natural shape of this clause: it is a problem in epistemology, not an institution with a founding date. What *is* required is enough chronology to prevent anachronism, plus the dated print anchors the examiner can be quoted at.

CONCEPTUAL ORIGIN OF THE PROBLEM

- Stage 1 A tradition claims a disclosure that unaided inquiry did not produce.
 Stage 2 The claim must be RECEIVED - so an act of trust enters the account.
 Stage 3 Rival traditions make incompatible disclosure-claims.
 Stage 4 A test is demanded -> and every candidate test is itself contestable.
 ==> the clause exists because Stages 3 and 4 cannot be waved away.

DATED PRINT ANCHORS (only years the controlling sources actually give)

- 1748 Hume, Enquiry Concerning Human Understanding, Section X, "Of Miracles"
 1874 J. W. Draper, History of the Conflict between Religion and Science
 1877 W. K. Clifford, "The Ethics of Belief"
 1896 A. D. White, A History of the Warfare of Science with Theology in Christendom
 1896 William James, The Will to Believe
 1979 Wilfred Cantwell Smith, Faith and Belief
 1983 Alvin Plantinga, "Reason and Belief in God"
 1991 William Alston, Perceiving God
 1997 Ian Barbour, Religion and Science: Historical and Contemporary Issues
 1999 Stephen Jay Gould, Rocks of Ages (NOMA)
 2000 Ian Barbour, When Science Meets Religion
 2000 John Earman, Hume's Abject Failure
 2000 Alvin Plantinga, Warranted Christian Belief

UNDATED IN THE CONTROLLING SOURCES - CITE BY WORK, NEVER BY INVENTED YEAR

- Augustine and Anselm -> "faith seeking understanding"; Proslogion 1
 Aquinas -> Summa Theologiae II-II, qq. 1-7 (on faith)
 Kierkegaard -> Fear and Trembling; Concluding Unscientific Postscript
 Tillich -> Dynamics of Faith Buber -> the I-Thou relation
 Hick -> Philosophy of Religion
 Indian anchors -> Gita 17.2-3; Kalama Sutta AN 3.65;
 Kevaddha Sutta DN 11; Yoga-sutra 3.37

The rail explains why the clause exists; the dated strip is the only chronology you may assert. Anything in the third block must be cited by work, never by a manufactured year.

Learning roadmap

Session	Learner objective
1	Separate reason, revelation and faith as three distinct epistemic jobs
2	State the four religious functions of reason and the limits of natural theology
3	Hold the regulative/constitutive line and the rational / supra-rational / irrational triad
4	Distinguish general from special, and natural theology from revealed theology
5	Reconstruct the non-propositional model and "experiencing-as"
6	Apply the six authentication tests and answer circularity and rival revelation
7	Enumerate the seven tenets of faith and the six axes of faith versus belief
8	Reconstruct Aquinas' faith as intellectual assent, premise by premise
9	Place Kierkegaard, Pascal, James and critical rationalism accurately
10	Compare the four stances and the full inter-school bench
11	Argue evidentialism against Reformed epistemology and price both
12	Reconstruct Hume on miracles in both Parts, with the four named replies
13	Use Barbour's four models with their costs, not a Galileo narrative
14	Deploy the Indian parity bench with exact analogues
15	Convert all of it into 10-, 15- and 20-mark scripts

SESSION 1 - THE THREE-TERM PROBLEM: WHAT REASON, REVELATION AND FAITH EACH DO

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. Reason, revelation and faith are three different grounds on which a religious belief may claim to be justified: argument, disclosure, and trust.

Technical definition. Reason appeals to publicly assessable inference; revelation appeals to a purported divine self-disclosure; faith appeals to committed assent or trust that may exceed what has been demonstrated.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE OR ADAPT IN THE EXAM

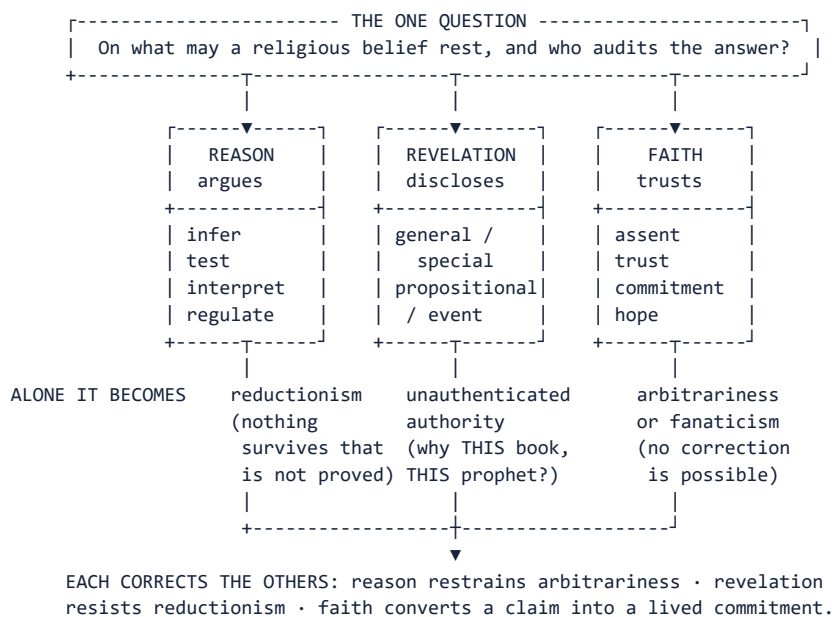
The philosophical problem is not whether religion may use only one source, but how rational inquiry, disclosed authority and committed trust can operate together without either contradiction or arbitrariness.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

reason · revelation · faith · warrant · authority · trust · reception · defeater

How to use them: decide first whether the question is about *discovery* (where does the content come from?), *justification* (what makes it rational?), *interpretation* (what does it mean?) or *reception* (what makes it live?). Naming the axis in the first paragraph is worth more than any list of thinkers.

VISUAL - THE THREE JOBS AND THEIR THREE FAILURE MODES



Read the columns downward for the job, then across the bottom row for the price of using that column on its own. The bottom band is the thesis of the whole clause.

TEACHING

[FACT] The three terms are not three answers to one question; they are three *different jobs*. Reason is an activity of assessment and interpretation. Revelation is an alleged event or content. Faith is a mode of reception and commitment. A script that treats them as three rival candidates for the same slot has already misread the clause.

[FACT] Reason's jurisdiction is wider than proof. It includes probabilistic and abductive weighing, coherence-testing, hermeneutics (how a text is to be read), and criticism (identifying defeaters). Restricting "reason" to deductive demonstration is exactly the move that makes the reason-versus-faith debate look like a war.

[INFERENCE] The productive framing is a *division of labour with mutual audit*: revelation supplies alleged content that unaided reason did not produce; faith receives and inhabits it; reason audits coherence, testimony and interpretation, and can refuse but not manufacture the content.

Objection. If reason audits revelation, reason has the final say, and revelation adds nothing independent. **Reply.**

[INFERENCE] Auditing is not authorship. A referee who can disallow a goal does not thereby score it. Reason's veto

power over contradiction is compatible with its inability to generate the content that is being vetted.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: Reason, revelation and faith are complementary offices rather than competing sources. **Named evidence:** Aquinas assigns reason the *preambles* and revelation the *mysteries*; Hick makes the same event religiously ambiguous until it is received in faith. **Analysis:** Each term is defined by a job the others cannot perform - assessment, disclosure and reception - so a conflict arises only when one office annexes another's work. **Qualification:** This division holds only while reason retains an effective veto; where a tradition exempts a claim from all criticism, the complementarity collapses into fideism.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not define faith as "belief without evidence" and then try to distinguish it from belief. The distinction is trust and entrusting versus propositional assent.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not treat revelation as a synonym for scripture, or for inspiration, or for infallibility. They are three different notions (see Session 4).
3. ANALYSIS: Do not restrict reason to deduction. The 2021 and 2024 questions both reward the wider account.

MINI RECAP

Three offices - argue, disclose, trust. Three solo failure modes - reductionism, unauthenticated authority, arbitrariness. One thesis - mutual audit.

SESSION 2 - REASON IN RELIGION: FOUR FUNCTIONS, NATURAL THEOLOGY AND ITS LIMITS

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. Reason in religion is the whole business of inferring, testing, interpreting and criticising religious claims - not merely trying to prove that God exists.

Technical definition. Natural theology is the project of arguing from publicly accessible premises toward theological conclusions; it is one function of religious reason among several, and is narrower than philosophy of religion.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING

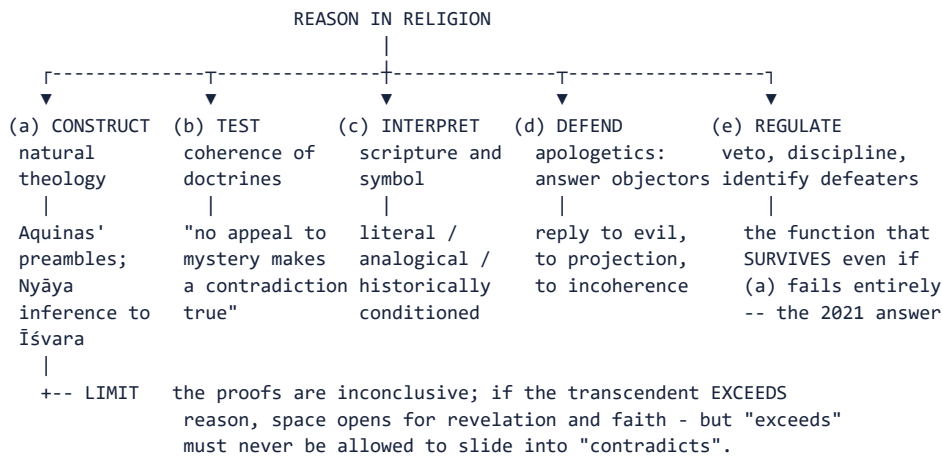
Reason's religious work is not exhausted by proof: it constructs, tests, interprets and defends, and it is precisely the last three functions that survive the failure of the first.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

natural theology · apologetics · coherence-test · hermeneutics · preambles of faith · demonstration versus probability · practical postulation

How to use them: in the 2024 10-marker ("role of reason in religion") the four functions *are* the answer skeleton - one short paragraph each, then the limit.

VISUAL - THE FOUR FUNCTIONS OF REASON



Functions (a)-(d) are the owner's printed list; (e) is the function the 2021 20-marker turns on. The limit line is what converts a list into an argument.

TEACHING

[FACT] The four printed functions (2024 PYQ). Reason (a) constructs **natural theology**, that is, the proofs for God; (b) tests the **coherence** of doctrines; (c) **interprets** scripture; (d) **defends** faith, which is apologetics.

[FACT] Rationalism. On the rationalist view, religious beliefs must meet the ordinary bar of reason and evidence. W. K. Clifford's maxim is the sharpest statement: *"it is wrong always, everywhere, and for anyone, to believe anything upon insufficient evidence."*

[FACT] The limit. The proofs are inconclusive; and if the transcendent exceeds the reach of finite reason, that opens space for revelation and faith. **[INFERENCE]** Note the exact wording - *exceeds*, not *contradicts*. The whole defensibility of the position rests on that word.

[FACT] Natural theology is not philosophy of religion. Natural theology argues *toward* theological conclusions. Philosophy of religion additionally analyses religious language, experience and warrant, and may reach negative conclusions. Nyāya's inference to God (Īśvara) is a genuine natural theology from an Indian school; Aquinas' preambles are the standard Western case.

[FACT] Presupposition. Natural theology presupposes that reality is intelligible and that reason is neither wholly corrupted nor confined to empirical objects.

Objection (Kant). Speculative reason cannot legitimately be employed beyond the bounds of possible experience, so metaphysical inference to God is illegitimate. **Reply.** **[FACT]** Natural theologians answer that metaphysical inference concerns the *conditions* of experience rather than an additional observed object, so the Kantian restriction does not automatically bite.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: Reason's religious role is fourfold and survives the collapse of its most famous function. **Named evidence:** Aquinas' preambles and Nyāya's inference to God (Īśvara) illustrate construction; Clifford's 1877 maxim states the rationalist demand; the coherence-test forbids any appeal to mystery that would license a contradiction. **Analysis:** Even a reader who thinks every proof fails still needs reason to test coherence, discipline interpretation and answer objections, so scepticism about natural theology does not retire reason from religion. **Qualification:** The limit is that the transcendent may *exceed* reason; the moment "exceed" is read as "contradict", the position becomes irrationalism rather than a theory of reason's scope.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not narrow "role of reason" to the proofs; the marks are in functions (b), (c) and (d).
2. ANALYSIS: Do not equate natural theology with philosophy of religion.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not state the limit as "reason contradicts faith". State it as "the object may exceed the instrument".

MINI RECAP

Construct, test, interpret, defend - plus regulate. Clifford states the demand. The limit is *exceeds*, never *contradicts*.

SESSION 3 - REGULATIVE VERSUS CONSTITUTIVE REASON, AND THE THREE-TERM AXIS OF FAITH

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. Reason is *regulative* when it disciplines and vetoes belief; it is *constitutive* when it actually supplies the content of belief. The 2021 question turns entirely on which of these is being claimed.

Technical definition. A **supra-rational** claim exceeds what proof establishes without violating logic; an **irrational** claim violates coherence or defies decisive evidence. The middle term is the answer to the 2023 15-marker.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING

Reason is regulative but not constitutive of religious belief: it can veto incoherence, discipline interpretation and assess evidence, but it does not generate the content that faith receives.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

regulative · constitutive · supra-rational · irrational · defeater · defeasibility · critical rationalism

How to use them: the words *regulative* and *supra-rational* are the two highest-value tokens in the entire clause. Both are middle terms that break a false binary.

VISUAL - TWO FALSE BINARIES, TWO MIDDLE TERMS

BINARY 1 -- "Either reason decides everything, or reason decides nothing."

CONSTITUTIVE reason	>>> REGULATIVE <<< (the defensible seat)	IRRELEVANT reason
reason must GENERATE every religious content = strict evidentialism	reason vetoes contradiction, weighs testimony, disciplines reading, names defeaters - but does not author content = Aquinas, critical rationalism, Plantinga's defeasible basicality	faith is immune; no criticism can touch it = insulated fideism

BINARY 2 -- "Faith is either rational or irrational."

RATIONAL	>>> SUPRA-RATIONAL <<<	IRRATIONAL
grounds, coherence, cumulative evidence = Aquinas' preambles, motives of credibility	EXCEEDS proof; does not contradict it. Trust, commitment, the step beyond demonstration = Aquinas' mysteries; Kierkegaard's objective uncertainty	CONTRADICTS logic or defies decisive evidence = the "because it is absurd" slogan read literally

RULE: this clause punishes binaries. Always supply the middle column.

Both diagrams have the same shape on purpose: the examinable answer is the middle column, and the marks are lost by scripts that only see the two ends.

TEACHING

[FACT] Rational and irrational aspects of faith (2023). Faith has a **rational** side - grounds, coherence, cumulative evidence - and a **supra-rational or non-rational** side - trust, commitment, the step beyond proof.

[INFERENCE] Why three categories and not two. If only "rational" and "irrational" are available, then every claim that outruns proof is automatically irrational, and the entire theistic tradition is convicted by definition. The supra-rational category is what makes the question answerable rather than rhetorical.

[FACT] Critical rationalism. Critical rationalism allows *committed* beliefs while keeping them open to criticism and defeaters. It is explicitly a middle position between proof-only evidentialism and immunity-producing fideism.

[FACT] Defeasibility is the price of the middle seat. A belief that no possible consideration could count against has purchased its safety by leaving the epistemic conversation. Plantinga insists his properly basic belief is *defeasible* precisely so as not to pay that price (Session 11).

Objection. "Regulative" is a face-saving word: if reason may veto any belief, it has effective sovereignty. **Reply.**

[INFERENCE] A veto is negative and occasion-bound. Reason can rule out an incoherent doctrine of God without being able to produce the doctrine of the Incarnation; the asymmetry between refusing and generating is exactly what the distinction records.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: Reason can be a regulative force in the formation of religious beliefs without being their constitutive source.

Named evidence: Aquinas allows reason to establish the preambles and to police contradiction while leaving the mysteries to revelation; critical rationalism keeps a committed belief open to defeaters; Plantinga's properly basic belief is explicitly defeasible. **Analysis:** Regulation is a negative and corrective power - veto, discipline, defeater-detection - whereas constitution is a productive power, so a tradition may accept full regulation without conceding that reason authors its content. **Qualification:** The distinction survives only while the veto is real; a tradition that declares its claims immune to any possible defeater has abandoned regulation and adopted insulated fideism.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not answer the 2021 question with "reason and faith are both important". The examiner is buying the precise sense of *regulative*.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not answer the 2023 question with a two-column table. The middle term is the answer.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not use the popular Latin slogan about believing "because it is absurd" as a verified quotation of Tertullian; it is a later slogan for extreme fideism and must be flagged as such.

MINI RECAP

Regulative, not constitutive. Rational / **supra-rational** / irrational. Defeasibility is the entry fee for the middle seat.

SESSION 4 - REVELATION I: GENERAL AND SPECIAL, AND THE PROPOSITIONAL MODEL

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. Revelation is God's self-disclosure to human beings - a source of knowledge that unaided reason could not reach, or could not securely hold.

Technical definition. On the **propositional model**, revelation communicates divinely authorised *truths* which unaided reason could not discover or securely know; those truths ground **revealed theology**, as distinct from **natural theology**.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING

Natural theology is what reason reaches on its own; revealed theology is what the propositional model says reason could only receive - and the distinction is a claim about epistemic access, not about degrees of religious importance.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

self-disclosure · general revelation · special revelation · propositional revelation · revealed theology · natural theology · mystery · preambles · inspiration · infallibility

How to use them: the 2025 15-marker prints three terms - natural theology, revealed theology, *and* "in the context of the propositional view". The third is not decorative; the propositional model is what makes the first two a clean pair.

VISUAL - TWO INDEPENDENT AXES OF REVELATION

		WHAT IS REVELATION? (nature)	
		PROPOSITIONAL	NON-PROPOSITIONAL
		truths communicated	God's acts / self-presence
GENERAL scope: all	G E N E R A L	nature and conscience read	the world experienced as
		as conveying truths about	gift, presence or address -
		God available to all	available in principle to all
SPECIAL scope: partic- ular	A S P E C I A L	scripture / prophet /	a particular history received
		tradition delivering	as divine action; doctrine is
		DOCTRINE for assent	the community's interpretation
		-- Aquinas' MYSTERIES	-- Hick's EXPERIENCING-AS
		+	+
		▲	▲
		SCOPE AND MEDIUM axis	WHAT REVELATION *IS* axis
		(who can access it?)	(content, or encounter?)

THREE WORDS THAT ARE NOT SYNONYMS

REVELATION = the disclosure itself

INSPIRATION = the divine-human authorship of the record

INFALLIBILITY = freedom from error in the result

-- they can come apart; conflating them is a standing UPSC trap.

The grid is the highest-value single visual in the clause: it lets you place any example in one move and it makes the 2025 question mechanical.

TEACHING

[FACT] Definition. Revelation is God's **self-disclosure** to humanity - the source of knowledge unavailable to unaided reason.

[FACT] The propositional view (2025 PYQ). Revelation delivers **truths or propositions** - doctrines - to be believed. These ground **revealed theology**, whose contents include the Trinity and the Incarnation, and which is distinct from **natural theology**, that is, what reason alone discovers, for example God's existence.

[FACT] The doctrine's own argument. (1) God can disclose; (2) prophets and scripture mediate the disclosure; (3) signs, testimony and coherence warrant its reception; (4) doctrine articulates the revealed content.

[FACT] Presupposition. A personal God acts in history, and reliable transmission of the disclosure is possible.

[FACT] Three notions that must not be merged. Inspiration concerns divine-human authorship; **revelation** concerns disclosure; **infallibility** concerns freedom from error. They are not interchangeable.

[FACT] The Indian complication that earns marks. Mīmāṃsā's authorless (*apauruṣeya*) Veda is authoritative but is **not** a creator God's speech. So there exists a form of scriptural authority with no revealer at all - which shows that "propositional scriptural authority" and "divine dictation" are separable ideas.

Objection. Rival revelations and circular authentication weaken any certainty the propositional model claims. **Reply.**

[FACT] Defenders appeal to cumulative criteria - coherence, moral fruit, testimony and transformative power - without pretending that those criteria are neutral between traditions. **[INFERENCE]** That concession is itself a mark-earning move: it converts a claim of proof into a claim of defeasible warrant.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: Within the propositional model, natural and revealed theology are distinguished by *epistemic access*, not by subject matter or importance. **Named evidence:** Aquinas treats God's existence as a preamble reachable by demonstration, and the Trinity as a mystery known only through disclosure; Mīmāṃsā's authorless (*apauruṣeya*) Veda shows that scriptural authority need not be a creator's speech. **Analysis:** Both theologies speak about God, and both use reasoning; what differs is where the premises come from, so revealed theology is not "less rational" but differently sourced. **Qualification:** The distinction is stable only under the propositional model; on Hick's non-propositional account the boundary blurs, because doctrine becomes the community's interpretation rather than the delivered content itself.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not conflate revelation with scripture, inspiration or infallibility.

2. ANALYSIS: Do not call Mīmāṃsā's Veda "revelation from a personal God". It is authoritative *and* authorless.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not answer the 2025 question with a two-column table that never mentions the propositional model. The third term carries marks.

MINI RECAP

Two axes: scope (general/special) and nature (propositional/non-propositional). Natural versus revealed theology is an access distinction. Revelation ≠ inspiration ≠ infallibility.

SESSION 5 - REVELATION II: THE NON-PROPOSITIONAL MODEL, HICK AND "EXPERIENCING-AS"

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. On the non-propositional model, revelation is not a list of delivered sentences but God's own acts and presence; the sentences come later, from the community that interpreted the encounter.

Technical definition. Revelation is primarily divine self-disclosure in events and encounter; propositions are human interpretations of that disclosure, and an event counts as revelatory only under an "experiencing-as" structure.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING

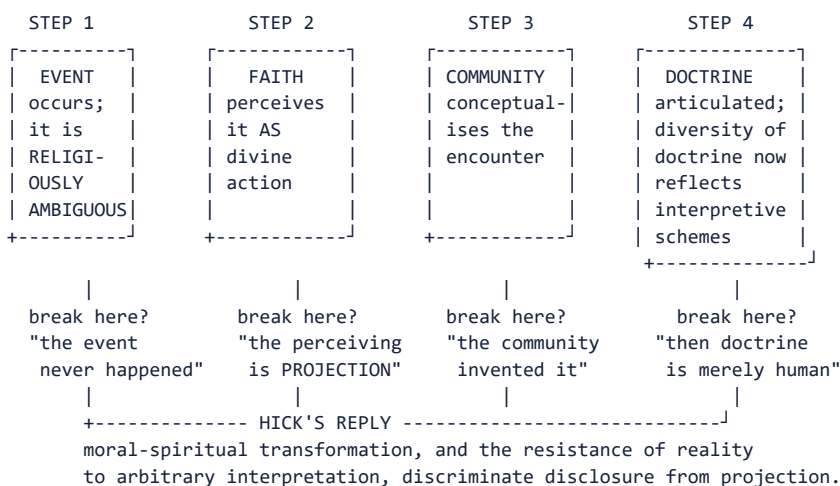
On the non-propositional account an event does not carry its own religious meaning on its surface: the same occurrence is a natural process to one observer and a divine act to another, and faith is the difference.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

self-disclosure · encounter · event · religious ambiguity · experiencing-as · concept-laden experience · interpretive scheme · projection

How to use them: *religious ambiguity* and *experiencing-as* together answer the 2022 10-marker in two sentences; the rest of the answer is the objection and the reply.

VISUAL - THE FOUR-STEP CHAIN, AND WHERE IT CAN BREAK



CONSEQUENCE FOR THE 2022 QUESTION

objective side --- the disclosure may occur whether or not it is received
 subjective side -- it becomes revelation FOR someone only through faith
 ==> faith is indispensable to revelation's RECEPTION and EFFICACY,
 not necessarily to its objective existence. Hold both halves.

The chain is the doctrine; the four "break here?" labels are the objections; the two-line consequence box is the 2022 verdict.

TEACHING

[FACT] The doctrine. Revelation is primarily divine self-disclosure in events and encounter; propositions are human interpretations of that disclosure. This is Hick's position.

[FACT] The argument, in four steps. (1) Events are religiously ambiguous; (2) faith perceives them as divine action; (3) communities conceptualise that encounter; (4) doctrinal diversity reflects differing interpretive schemes.

[FACT] Presupposition. Experience is always concept-laden, and divine freedom is not exhausted by statements.

[FACT] The key distinction. An event is not automatically revelation for every observer. "Revelatory event" names an *experienced-as* structure, not a property visible on the face of the occurrence. The canonical illustration is that one and the same historical event can be described in secular causal terms or received as providential.

[FACT] Is faith indispensable for revelation? (2022 PYQ). Revelation must be **received**; it becomes revelation *for someone* only through the faith that recognises and accepts it. Without faith, an event is just an event. So faith is a **precondition of revelation's efficacy**.

[INFERENCE] The two-sided answer that earns the mark. Concede the propositional point - if God communicates a truth, that truth is true whether or not anyone accepts it. Then hold the line: unreceived information does not become *revelation in a person's religious life*. Distinguish objective disclosure from subjective reception and the objection ceases to be fatal.

Objection. If interpretation constitutes revelation, projection threatens: the community may simply be reading its own wishes into a neutral world. **Reply.** **[FACT]** Hick appeals to moral-spiritual transformation and to the resistance of reality to arbitrary interpretation. **[INFERENCE]** Neither reply is decisive, and saying so is worth more than pretending it is.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: Faith is indispensable to the *reception* of revelation, though not necessarily to its objective occurrence.

Named evidence: Hick's non-propositional model makes events religiously ambiguous and revelatory only under an "experiencing-as" structure; Kierkegaard likewise makes appropriation, not proof, the religious act. **Analysis:** Because the same occurrence admits both a secular causal and a providential description, something other than the event must select the religious reading, and that selector is committed reception. **Qualification:** The propositional theorist is right that divinely communicated content would be true unreceived; the concession costs nothing once occurrence is distinguished from revelation-for-a-person.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not treat "experiencing-as" as a synonym for a strong feeling. It is a structure of perception under a concept.
2. ANALYSIS: In the 2022 question, do not simply assert that faith is indispensable. Separate objective disclosure from subjective reception, or the propositional counter-example sinks the answer.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not present Hick's replies to projection as conclusive.

MINI RECAP

Ambiguous event -> experiencing-as -> community conceptualisation -> doctrine. Projection is the standing objection. The 2022 answer is *reception, not occurrence*.

SESSION 6 - AUTHENTICATION, AUTHORITY, CIRCULARITY AND COMPETING REVELATIONS

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. Authentication is the business of asking why *this* alleged disclosure should be believed rather than a rival one - and of admitting honestly what each test can and cannot show.

Technical definition. Epistemic justification of a revelation-claim is a **convergence** of defeasible criteria - coherence, testimony, moral fruit, communal transmission, experience and comparative performance - none of which is individually decisive and none of which is neutral between traditions.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING

A revelation-claim is warranted, if at all, by a convergence - internal coherence, moral fruits, the recipient's experience, communal transmission and congruence with reason - no one of which is decisive, and none of which is neutral between traditions.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

authentication · motives of credibility · testimony · moral fruit · tradition · circularity · vicious versus virtuous circle · diversity defeater · hermeneutics

How to use them: the 2024 15-marker asks for "what kind of epistemic justifications are possible ... with your own comments". Give the *typology first*, then rank the criteria yourself. The ranking is the "own comments" the stem is buying.

VISUAL - THE SIX TESTS AND WHAT EACH ONE CANNOT DO

TEST	ITS BUILT-IN LIMIT
1 SOURCE / TESTIMONY competent? sincere? suitably placed? independently supported?	testimony transmits error as well as truth
2 COHERENCE self-consistent? clashes with secure knowledge?	coherence does not establish DIVINE origin - a consistent fiction is still consistent
3 MORAL-SPIRITUAL FRUIT truthfulness, compassion, transformation	useful effects can occur under FALSE beliefs
4 TRADITION / COMMUNITY publicly transmitted, criticised, corrected?	communal endurance may preserve power or bias rather than truth
5 EXPERIENCE + MIRACLE-SIGN event resistant to ordinary explanation, fitted to the message?	an unusual occurrence does not by itself authenticate ONE interpretation of it
6 CROSS-REVELATION how does it answer rival disclosures?	the criteria are rarely NEUTRAL between traditions - each tradition tends to score well on its own preferred test

THE CIRCULARITY PROBLEM

scripture --authenticates-- God --authorises-- scripture

▲

VICIOUS if the circle is the ONLY support offered.

ARGUABLY VIRTUOUS if independent testimony, coherence and moral fruit enter from outside - many epistemic practices use reciprocal support; the live question is whether THIS circle is vicious or a coherent web.

Never present the six tests without their limit column: the limits are where the "own comments" marks sit.

TEACHING

[FACT] The printed question (2024). How do we validate a revelation-claim? By internal coherence, moral fruits, the **religious experience** of the recipient, communal testimony, and congruence with reason. The stated problems are competing revelations across religions, and circularity - using the revelation to validate itself.

[FACT] Scripture requires interpretation. Authority does not eliminate hermeneutics. Using a scripture's own claim in order to prove that same scripture's unique authority is circular unless independent testimony, coherence or other defeasible support is supplied.

[FACT] The circularity reply. Many epistemic practices use reciprocal support; the real issue is whether the circle in question is *vicious* or is a coherent web of mutual support. **[INFERENCE]** The examiner-visible move is to state the criterion for viciousness - a circle is vicious when it is the *only* support, and tolerable when independent lines of

evidence enter it.

[FACT] Competing revelation. Rival scriptures cannot all be literally infallible in incompatible claims. The standard reply distinguishes a core disclosure from historically conditioned interpretation; critics fairly call this revisionary, because it rewrites what a tradition took itself to be claiming.

[FACT] Advanced-side residue (kept subordinate). The dossier records a second-order dispute between emphasising **public testimony, history and credibility signs** and emphasising **first-person disclosure with interpretive faith**; competing revelations are said to cancel one another, and the reply is that warrant is defeasible and cumulative rather than conclusive, so rival claims force comparative assessment rather than immediate collapse.

Objection. If every test is defeasible and none is neutral, "justification" has been redefined so weakly that any tradition passes. **Reply. [INFERENCE]** Weak criteria still discriminate. A claim that fails coherence, produces no moral fruit, rests on a single uncorroborated witness and cannot survive comparison with rivals is worse off than one that survives all four - even if neither reaches proof. Degrees of warrant are still warrant.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: A revelation-claim can be justified only by convergent, defeasible criteria, never by a single decisive test.

Named evidence: The owner's six tests - testimony, coherence, moral fruit, tradition, experience-and-sign, and cross-revelation comparison - each carry a stated limit; the circularity of scripture authenticating itself is answered only by importing independent support. **Analysis:** Because each test is defeasible and none is tradition-neutral, warrant here is cumulative and comparative, so the honest verdict is graded credibility rather than demonstration.

Qualification: This weakens the claim to certainty, and it relocates the central difficulty from evidential insufficiency to religious diversity - which is the point at which this clause hands over to the pluralism owner.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not list criteria without their limits. The limits *are* the analysis.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not treat the circularity charge as fatal or as harmless; state the vicious/virtuous test.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not smuggle in the full pluralist theory of religions; the firewall confines this clause to competing revelation as a *defeater*.

MINI RECAP

Six tests, six limits. Circularity is vicious only if it is the sole support. Convergence, not proof. Diversity is the residual problem.

SESSION 7 - FAITH: THE SEVEN TENETS, AND FAITH VERSUS BELIEF

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. Belief is holding a statement to be true. Faith is entrusting yourself to something held ultimate - which includes beliefs, but is not just a stronger or weaker version of them.

Technical definition. **Belief** is propositional assent - *believing that* p. **Faith** is a fiduciary and volitional relation - *believing in*, trusting, entrusting oneself to. Every faith involves beliefs; not every belief involves faith.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING

Faith is not a weaker belief; it is a different act. Belief is the cognitive component *within* faith, and the two come apart in both directions - orthodox belief without trust, and trust that outruns any belief its holder can articulate.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

belief-that · belief-in · the faith which is believed (*fides quae creditur*) · the faith by which one believes (*fides qua creditur*) · ultimate concern · I-Thou · trust (*śraddhā*) · trust (Pali: *saddhā*) · fidelity · betrayal

How to use them: the 2020 15-marker has **two printed deliverables**. Enumerate the seven tenets first, then run the differentia table. Doing only one of the two loses roughly half the marks whatever the quality of the prose.

VISUAL A - THE SEVEN TENETS AS A LADDER

- (7) FRUITS ----- a transformed pattern of life, by which it is tested
 ▲
 (6) COMMUNITY ----- tradition that transmits AND disciplines it
 ▲
 (5) HOPE ----- oriented to a good not yet secured
 ▲
 (4) COMMITMENT ----- the will engages; risk is accepted
 ▲
 (3) TRUST ----- exceeding the available evidence
 ▲
 (2) ASSENT ----- to some content: faith is never contentless feeling
 ▲
 (1) AN ULTIMATE OBJECT - God, Brahman, dharma, or another final focus

Steps 1-2 are shared with belief. Step 3 is where faith departs.
 Steps 4-7 are what belief alone never supplies.

VISUAL B - THE SIX AXES OF DIFFERENCE

Axis	Belief	Faith
Object	a proposition	a person, reality or ultimate
Grammar	<i>believe that</i>	<i>believe in / trust</i>
Mode	cognitive assent	assent plus trust, commitment, risk
Voluntariness	largely involuntary - one cannot decide to believe it is raining	involves the will; faith can be <i>given</i>
Failure-mode	falsehood	betrayal, infidelity, apostasy
Degrees	degrees of confidence	degrees of fidelity and depth

The "voluntariness" row is the one that generates the doxastic-voluntarism objection; the "failure-mode" row is the one that proves the two are different acts, because betrayal is not a kind of falsehood.

TEACHING

[FACT] The seven tenets (the printed stem asks for these). (1) an **object** held to be ultimate; (2) **assent** to some content about it; (3) **trust** exceeding the available evidence; (4) **commitment** of the will, with consequent risk; (5) **hope** oriented to a future not yet secured; (6) a **community** and tradition that transmits and disciplines it; (7) **fruits** - a transformed pattern of life by which it is tested.

[FACT] Aquinas' scholastic pair. *Fides quae creditur* is the faith **which** is believed - the content, the creed. *Fides qua creditur* is the faith **by which** one believes - the act and disposition. English-first: *the faith that is believed* versus *the faith by which one believes*.

[FACT] Wilfred Cantwell Smith, Faith and Belief (1979). "Faith" names a universal, cross-cultural human orientation to transcendence, whereas "belief" in its modern propositional sense is a historically recent narrowing; the English word once meant something closer to "hold dear".

[FACT] Tillich. Faith is the state of being grasped by an **ultimate concern**. This is why idolatry - an ultimate concern directed at something non-ultimate - is faith's characteristic failure, rather than unbelief.

[FACT] Buber. The I-Thou relation cannot be reduced to I-It propositions.

[FACT] Indian parity - and it is a genuine advantage here. Trust (*śraddhā*) is precisely the faith-side rather than the belief-side. The *Bhagavad-gītā* 17.2-3 grades trust (*śraddhā*) as of the mode of clarity (*sāttvika*), passion (*rājasa*) or inertia (*tāmasa*), and states that a person is constituted by their trust - "as is one's *śraddhā*, so is one". In Advaita pedagogy trust (*śraddhā*) is one of the six inner accomplishments and functions as **the trust that makes inquiry possible**, to be *replaced* by realisation rather than preserved as belief. Buddhism's trust (Pali: *saddhā*) is explicitly provisional and verification-directed: the *Kālāma Sutta* (Aṅguttara Nikāya 3.65) counsels not to accept a teaching merely on report, lineage, scripture, logic or a teacher's authority, but to test it in experience.

ANALYSIS: **[INFERENCE] Why that matters.** Indian trust *initiates* verification, whereas Western "faith" often has to defend itself as trust that *replaces* verification. That single sentence lifts a 2020-type answer above the average band.

Objection 1 (reductionism). The distinction is merely verbal: "believing in X" reduces to "believing that X exists and is trustworthy". **Reply. [FACT]** The reduction loses the performative and relational element. One can believe *that* a person is reliable while refusing to entrust anything to them; faith is constituted by the entrusting.

Objection 2 (doxastic irresponsibility). If faith is volitional, it is doxastically irresponsible. **Reply. [FACT]** The will operates only where evidence is genuinely non-coercive, which is the only case in dispute - Aquinas' position, and James's "genuine option".

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: Faith and belief are different acts, not different strengths of the same act. **Named evidence:** Aquinas' pair - the faith which is believed (*fides quae*) and the faith by which one believes (*fides qua*); Wilfred Cantwell Smith on the modern narrowing of "belief"; Tillich's ultimate concern, whose failure is idolatry rather than doubt; the *Gītā* 17.2-3 on trust (*śraddhā*) as constitutive of the person. **Analysis:** The decisive test is the failure-mode: belief fails by being false, faith fails by betrayal, and a difference in how something can fail is a difference in what it is. **Qualification:** The reductionist is right that faith carries beliefs, so the claim must be that belief is a component of faith rather than a rival to it.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not define faith as "belief without evidence" and then distinguish it from belief; that makes the question unanswerable.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not answer only the second half of the 2020 stem. Both deliverables are printed.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not reduce Indian material to one decorative sentence on trust (*śraddhā*). Use the graded typology and the verification-directed contrast.

MINI RECAP

Seven tenets; six axes. *Fides quae* / *fides qua*. Failure-mode is the decisive test. Indian trust initiates verification.

SESSION 8 - AQUINAS: FAITH AS INTELLECTUAL ASSENT

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. For Aquinas, faith is the mind saying yes to something it cannot see, because the will - moved by grace - directs it to accept a trustworthy witness.

Technical definition. Faith is an act of the **intellect** assenting to divine truth under the **command of the will**, moved by grace; it is a *mean* between knowledge, which has demonstration or sight, and opinion, which retains the fear that the opposite may be true.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING

Aquinas reconciles reason and faith not by compromise but by architecture: reason proves the preambles, revelation supplies the mysteries, and faith is the firm assent that has knowledge's certainty without knowledge's vision.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

intellectual assent · command of the will · grace · preambles of faith · mystery · motives of credibility · firmness without vision · one truth, two routes

How to use them: the 2025 10-marker asks *how* the reconciliation works. Name the two storeys and the hinge between them. A description of Aquinas' piety scores nothing; the mechanism scores everything.

VISUAL - THE TWO-STOREY STRUCTURE AND THE THREE-WAY LOCATION OF FAITH

ONE TRUTH - TWO ROUTES (both routes issue from God, so they cannot genuinely conflict; apparent conflict = defective reasoning OR defective interpretation, never a true contradiction in reality)	
UPPER STOREY - MYSTERIES e.g. the Trinity	reached ONLY through revelation ABOVE reason, never AGAINST it
LOWER STOREY - PREAMBLES e.g. that God exists	reachable by unaided reason = natural theology

▲ THE HINGE ▲

motives of credibility make assent REASONABLE though not demonstrative

WHERE FAITH SITS - the three-way location that is the actual answer

KNOWLEDGE	FAITH	OPINION
firm assent WITH sight / demonstration	firm assent WITHOUT sight	assent WITHOUT firmness - retains the fear that the opposite is true

faith takes its FIRMNESS from knowledge and its UNSEENNESS from opinion:
that is why it is called a mean, and why it is neither of the two.

THE ACT, IN FOUR MOVES

- revealed truth exceeds demonstrative sight
- + testimony supplies the object
- + the WILL commands the intellect where evidence is non-coercive
- + GRACE orients the person toward divine truth

TEACHING

[FACT] The doctrine. Faith is an act of intellect assenting to divine truth under the command of the will moved by grace. Source: *Summa Theologiae* II-II, questions 1-4 (the wider treatment runs to question 7).

[FACT] The argument, in four steps. (1) Revealed truth exceeds demonstrative sight; (2) testimony supplies the object of assent; (3) the will commands the intellect where the evidence is non-coercive; (4) grace orients the person toward divine truth.

[FACT] The mean. Faith is not opinion, because it has *firm* assent; and it is not knowledge in the strict demonstrative or visionary sense, because its object is unseen. It has "the firmness of knowledge without the vision".

[FACT] The reconciliation. Reason establishes the **preambles** - for example, that God exists. Faith accepts the **mysteries** - for example, the Trinity - which exceed but do not contradict reason. Because both reason and revelation issue from God, they **cannot** genuinely conflict.

[FACT] Presupposition. The will can responsibly govern assent without making truth arbitrary, and divine testimony is trustworthy.

Objection. Will-governed belief risks **voluntarism** - believing whatever one chooses. **Reply.** **[FACT]** Aquinas answers that *motives of credibility* and the rational preambles make the assent reasonable, though not demonstrative.

[INFERENCE] The will therefore operates on a genuinely under-determined question, not on a settled one - which is exactly James's later restriction to options that evidence cannot decide.

Objection (from the other side). Imported metaphysics may domesticate revelation, making the mysteries answer to a philosophical system. **Reply.** **[INFERENCE]** Reason on this model does not generate the mystery; it removes contradiction and clarifies implication. The asymmetry between removing and producing is the same one that Session 3 called regulative rather than constitutive.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: Aquinas' account of faith as intellectual assent dissolves the reason-faith juxtaposition by relocating the two terms in a single structure rather than balancing them against each other. **Named evidence:** In *Summa Theologiae* II-II qq. 1-4, faith is the intellect's assent to divine truth under the will's command moved by grace; it is a mean between knowledge, which has sight, and opinion, which fears the opposite; reason yields the preambles and revelation the mysteries. **Analysis:** Because both routes issue from God, an apparent clash must be a defect of reasoning or of interpretation, so the mysteries are placed *above* reason rather than against it and the supposed juxtaposition never arises. **Qualification:** The reconciliation holds only if the motives of credibility do real work; without them the will's command collapses into voluntarism, which is the standing objection to the account.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not say Aquinas lets faith contradict reason. The mysteries exceed reason.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not describe faith as "certainty without evidence". It is firmness without *vision*, resting on testimony.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not fabricate an English "quotation" from the *Summa*. Paraphrase, and cite II-II qq. 1-4.

MINI RECAP

Two storeys, one truth. Faith = firm assent without sight. Intellect + will + grace. Motives of credibility are the anti-voluntarism guard.

SESSION 9 - KIERKEGAARD, FIDEISM, AND THE PERMISSIVE PROPOSALS

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. Kierkegaard's point is that no amount of objective argument can do the thing religion asks of a person: actually commit. Fideism is the family of views that make faith prior to, or independent of, rational support.

Technical definition. Kierkegaardian faith is passionate commitment amid **objective uncertainty**; the pragmatic proposals of Pascal and James, and critical rationalism, mark out the bounded permissions that sit between evidentialism and insulated fideism.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING

Kierkegaard's target is not evidence but substitution: he denies that an objective system can be handed to a person in place of the decision only that person can make.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

objective uncertainty · passionate inwardness · appropriation · teleological suspension of the ethical · living, forced and momentous option · many-gods objection · critical rationalism · supra-rational

How to use them: whenever Kierkegaard appears, immediately add the disclaimer sentence. It is the single most reliable way to signal that you know the caricature.

VISUAL - THE PERMISSION LADDER, FROM STRICTEST TO LOOSEST

STRICTEST -----> LOOSEST

EVIDENTIALISM Clifford	CRITICAL RATIONALISM	JAMES'S WILL TO BELIEVE	PASCAL'S WAGER	INSULATED FIDEISM
believe only on sufficient evidence	commit, but keep the belief open to criticism and defeaters	commit where the option is LIVING, FORCED and MOMENTOUS and evidence cannot decide	prudential reasons to CHOOSE under uncertainty	faith is immune; criticism does not apply
COST: disqualifies far more than religion	COST: nothing is ever finally settled	COST: only genuinely undecidable options; NOT belief at will	COST: gives NO evidence of TRUTH; many-gods + authenticity objections	COST: licenses fanaticism; forfeits philosoph- ical claim

WHERE KIERKEGAARD ACTUALLY SITS

NOT at the far right. His claim is about APPROPRIATION, not about a right to believe anything: objective uncertainty + infinite personal concern

-- subjective appropriation

Abraham dramatises the paradox and the "teleological suspension of the ethical"; he is an existential limit-case, not a general licence.

TEACHING

[FACT] Kierkegaard's position. Faith is a **passionate, subjective commitment** under objective uncertainty.

Abraham dramatises the paradox and the teleological suspension of the ethical. Kierkegaard attacks the claim that an objective philosophical system can replace existential decision.

ANALYSIS: [FACT] The mandatory disclaimer. He should **not** be flattened into the view that contradiction, irresponsibility or every evidence-free belief is religiously licensed.

[FACT] The comparative frame. Kierkegaardian faith is passionate commitment amid objective uncertainty; Indian trust (*śraddhā*) is disciplined trust that enables inquiry and practice rather than blind credulity. Both share the presupposition that transformative truths require participation, not observation alone.

[FACT] The controlling distinction. *Supra-rational* is not *irrational*: exceeding proof differs from contradicting reason.

[FACT] The Indian pedagogic parallel. The Advaita triad moves from hearing (*śravaṇa*) through reasoning (*manana*) to assimilation (*nididhyāsana*) - trust initiates verification rather than abolishing it.

[FACT] Pascal's wager. It gives *prudential* reasons to choose a religious commitment under uncertainty. It does **not** provide evidence that the belief is true, and it faces the many-gods and the authenticity objections.

[FACT] James's will-to-believe (1896). It permits commitment where an option is **living, forced and momentous** and the evidence cannot decide in time. It does **not** license belief at will in ordinary avoidable-evidence cases.

[FACT] Critical rationalism. It allows committed beliefs while keeping them open to criticism and defeaters - a middle position between proof-only evidentialism and immunity-producing fideism.

Objection. Unchecked commitment can sanctify fanaticism. **Reply. [FACT]** Authentic faith remains answerable to coherence, ethical fruit and self-critical interpretation. **[INFERENCE]** That reply is only as good as the tradition's willingness to let those checks bite; a tradition that recognises no possible defeater has, in effect, chosen the far-right column of the ladder.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: Kierkegaard defends the irreplaceability of appropriation, not a right to believe without constraint. **Named evidence:** In *Fear and Trembling* and the *Concluding Unscientific Postscript*, faith is commitment under objective uncertainty and Abraham dramatises the teleological suspension of the ethical; James by contrast permits passionate decision only for a living, forced and momentous option; Pascal offers prudence, not evidence. **Analysis:** Ordering these positions on a permission ladder shows that Kierkegaard's move is about *who must decide* rather than about *how much evidence is needed*, which is why he does not collapse into insulated fideism. **Qualification:** The distinction is preserved only while the ethical and coherence checks remain live; where they are suspended in principle rather than in a limit-case, the fanaticism objection succeeds.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not present Kierkegaard as an irrationalist or as an advocate of "believing the absurd".
2. ANALYSIS: Do not present the wager as an argument for God's existence; it is prudential and faces the many-gods objection.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not state James's permission without its three conditions; unqualified, it is a licence for wishful thinking.

MINI RECAP

Objective uncertainty + appropriation. Ladder: Clifford → critical rationalism → James → Pascal → insulated fideism. Supra-rational ≠ irrational.

SESSION 10 - THE FOUR STANCES AND THE FULL INTER-SCHOOL BENCH

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. There are four standard ways of relating reason and faith, and about ten identifiable positions once the Indian schools and the modern epistemologists are added.

Technical definition. The stances differ over whether reason *constitutes*, *regulates* or merely *clarifies* faith, and over whether commitment under uncertainty remains epistemically responsible.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING

The reason-faith relation is not one question with four answers but four different settlements of one boundary dispute, and each is best assessed by the risk it accepts rather than by the harmony it promises.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

rationalism · fideism · faith seeking understanding · two-source harmony · reduction of commitment · arbitrariness · two-tier tension · projection

VISUAL A - THE FOUR STANCES

Stance	Relation	Thinker	One-line
Rationalism	reason judges faith	Clifford, Locke	believe only on evidence
Faith-priority / fideism	faith cannot be generated by proof	Kierkegaard; later extreme fideist slogans	commitment under uncertainty; reason cannot replace appropriation
Faith seeking understanding	harmony, faith first	Augustine, Anselm	<i>credo ut intelligam</i> - "I believe in order that I may understand"
Two-source harmony	reason and revelation, distinct domains	Aquinas	natural theology plus revealed theology

MEMORY: Aquinas is the balanced default. Reason and revelation **cannot conflict**, because both come from God; reason proves the *preambles*, revelation supplies the *mysteries*; faith is intellectual assent under grace. Deploy this for any "reconcile reason and faith" question.

VISUAL B - THE FULL BENCH, WITH THE RISK EACH POSITION RUNS

Position	Reason	Revelation	Faith	Main risk
Rationalism / evidentialism	judge of belief	must be evidenced	proportioned to evidence	reduction of commitment
Aquinas	preambles and coherence	mysteries beyond reason	firm intellectual assent	two-tier tension
Fideism	limited or irrelevant	authoritative	primary leap or trust	arbitrariness
Hick	interprets experience critically	event / self-disclosure	experiencing-as	projection
Mīmāṃsā	interprets injunction and testimony	authorless (<i>apauruṣeya</i>) Veda, not creator's speech	trust in Vedic authority	cross-tradition warrant
Advaita	reasoning (<i>manana</i>) removes doubt	scripture (<i>śruti</i>) discloses Brahman	trust (<i>śraddhā</i>) enables inquiry	scriptural circularity
Evidentialism (Locke, Clifford, Flew)	sole arbiter; proportion assent to evidence	must be independently evidenced	rational only if evidenced	self-application; over-strict criterion
Reformed epistemology (Plantinga)	not the sole arbiter	may be received basically	properly basic, warranted, defeasible	religious diversity as a defeater
Alston	critical, non-foundationalist	mediated in practice	rational participation in a doxastic practice	circularity shared with sense perception
Barbour's typology	model-dependent	model-dependent	model-dependent	descriptive, not normative

The "main risk" column is the discriminating column. In a 20-marker, comparing risks is what separates evaluation from summary.

TEACHING

[FACT] The four criticisms that recur across the bench.

- Evidential challenge.** The Cliffordian ethics of belief rejects assent without sufficient evidence. *Reply:* testimony, cumulative evidence and practical commitment can be rational without demonstration.
- Competing revelation.** Rival scriptures cannot all be literally infallible in incompatible claims. *Reply:* distinguish core disclosure from historically conditioned interpretation - critics call this revisionary.
- Circularity.** Scripture is authenticated by the community and the community by the scripture. *Reply:* many epistemic practices use reciprocal support; the issue is whether the circle is vicious or a coherent web.
- Fideist immunity.** Faith insulated from criticism licenses fanaticism. *Reply:* faith may transcend proof while remaining constrained by non-contradiction and ethical fruits.

[INFERENCE] How to use the bench in an answer. Do not narrate all ten rows. Pick the two that the stem forces into contact - for example Aquinas against Kierkegaard for a reconciliation question, or evidentialism against Reformed epistemology for a justification question - and use a third row (usually an Indian one) as the comparative check.

Objection. A typology is descriptively neat but normatively empty: it does not say which stance is correct. **Reply.**

[FACT] It is a classification of positions, and the argument must be made stance by stance. **[INFERENCE]** What the classification does deliver is the *cost sheet*: once each stance's characteristic risk is stated, the defensible verdict is usually the position whose risk is manageable rather than the one whose promises are largest.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: Of the four standard stances, two-source harmony carries the most manageable risk. **Named evidence:** Rationalism (Locke, Clifford) risks reducing commitment; fideism risks arbitrariness; the Augustinian-Anselmian *credo ut intelligam* begins inside commitment; Aquinas alone assigns reason and revelation distinct, non-competing offices. **Analysis:** Comparing the positions by their characteristic failure rather than by their stated harmony shows that Aquinas' two-tier tension is a live problem about the credibility of revelation, not a contradiction internal to the model. **Qualification:** The verdict is comparative, not absolute: if the credibility of the alleged revelation cannot be defended at all, the two-storey structure loses its upper floor and rationalism wins by default.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not treat the four stances as a chronological development. They are logical settlements, and adherents of each are contemporary.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not put Mīmāṃsā in the "revelation from a personal God" row.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not use Barbour's typology as if it settled anything; it classifies, and the owner records that objection explicitly.

MINI RECAP

Four stances; ten-row bench; one discriminating column - risk. Pick two rows plus an Indian check, never all ten.

SESSION 11 - EVIDENTIALISM AND REFORMED EPISTEMOLOGY

[FACT] Status note. This is a **core** module, not optional enrichment. The Philosophy of Religion Advanced Dossier's promotion ledger records that the Reformed-epistemology-versus-evidentialism dispute "fired and was promoted on 15 August 2026" and now lives in Core, with its own previous-year route.

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. "Can religious beliefs be justified?" is not a question about whether God exists. It is a question about what *standard* a religious belief has to meet before it counts as rationally held.

Technical definition. **Evidentialism** holds that a belief is rational only if proportioned to the evidence. **Reformed epistemology** holds that belief in God can be **properly basic** - rationally held without being inferred from other beliefs - while remaining grounded, warranted and defeasible.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING

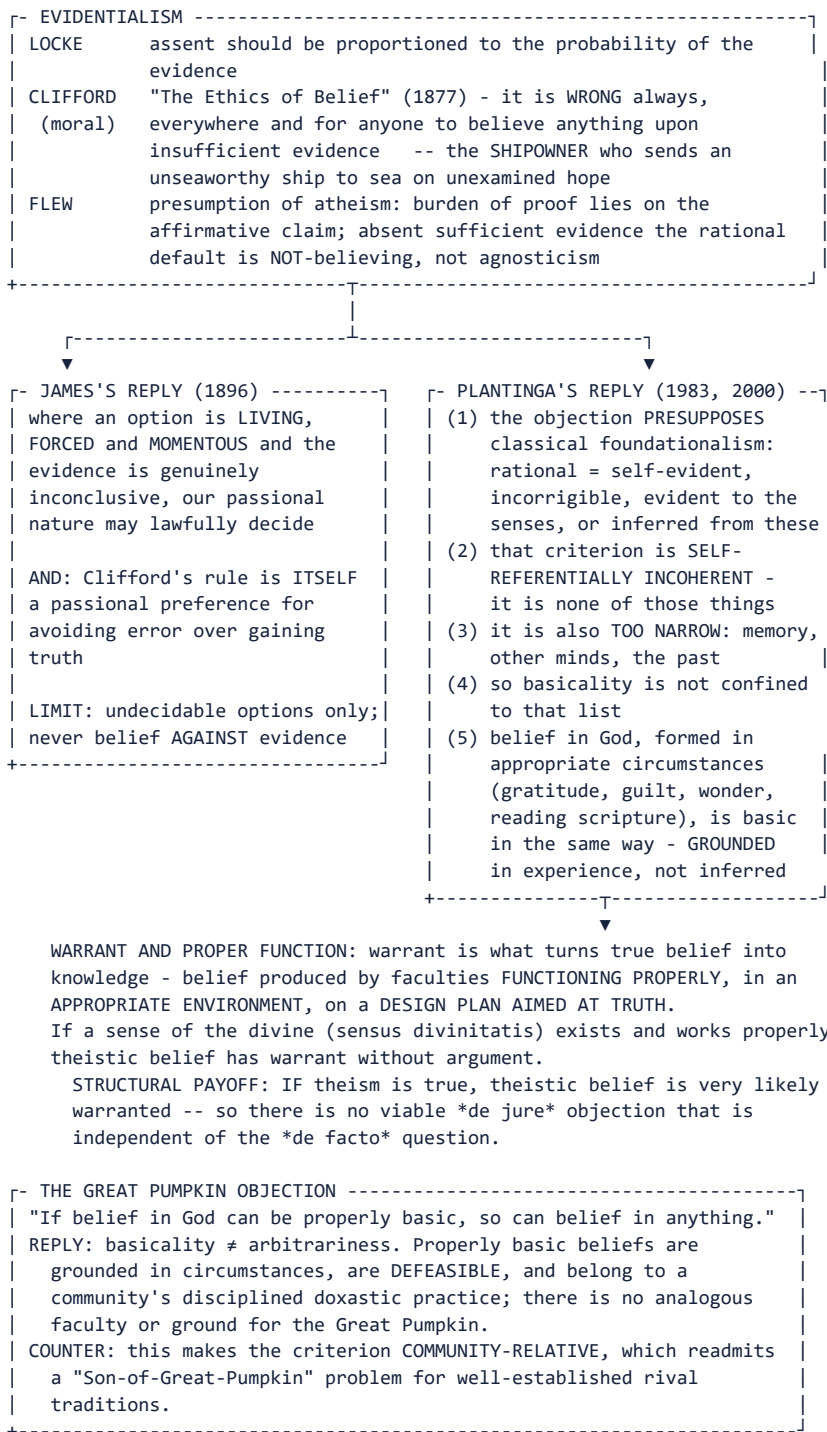
Religious beliefs can be justified, but not in the way natural theology once hoped: the evidentialist standard, taken strictly, disqualifies far more than religion, while the Reformed alternative rescues rationality at the price of locating it inside a doxastic practice.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

ethics of belief · presumption of atheism · living, forced, momentous · classical foundationalism · self-referential incoherence · properly basic · grounded · warrant · proper function · design plan · sense of the divine (*sensus divinitatis*) · Great Pumpkin objection · doxastic practice · defeater · intrinsic validity (*svataḥ-prāmāṇya*) · extrinsic validity (*parataḥ-prāmāṇya*)

How to use them: name the epistemology in the first sentence. The 2023 10-marker is lost by scripts that argue about God's existence instead of about the standard of justification.

VISUAL - THE ARGUMENT, MOVE BY MOVE



ALSTON, Perceiving God (1991): our doxastic practices - INCLUDING SENSE PERCEPTION - cannot be shown reliable without circularity; since we nonetheless rationally engage in them, socially established religious practice is in the same epistemic boat, and it is practically rational to engage in it absent sufficient reason to think it unreliable.

TEACHING

[FACT] The thesis of evidentialism. A belief is rational only if it is proportioned to the evidence, and religious belief must meet the same standard as any other. Locke ties assent to the probability of the evidence; Clifford makes it a *moral* matter; Flew's presumption of atheism places the burden of proof on the affirmative claim.

[FACT] James's reply (1896). Where an option is living, forced and momentous, and the evidence is genuinely inconclusive, the "passional nature" may lawfully decide - and Clifford's own rule expresses a passional preference for

avoiding error over gaining truth. **ANALYSIS:** The reply is limited to genuinely undecidable options and does not license belief against evidence.

[FACT] Plantinga's five-step argument. Set out in the visual above; the load-bearing steps are (2) self-referential incoherence and (3) the counter-examples of memory, other minds and beliefs about the past.

[FACT] Warrant and proper function. Warrant is what converts true belief into knowledge: a belief has warrant when produced by cognitive faculties functioning properly, in an appropriate environment, according to a design plan aimed at truth. If a sense of the divine (*sensus divinitatis*) exists and works properly, theistic belief has warrant without argument. Note the structural consequence: **if** theism is true, theistic belief is very likely warranted, so there is no viable *de jure* objection independent of the *de facto* question.

[FACT] Alston's complementary route. *Perceiving God* (1991): doxastic practices, including sense perception, cannot be non-circularly validated; since we rationally engage in them anyway, socially established religious practice is in the same epistemic boat.

[FACT] Indian parity - the highest-value move in this question. The whole dispute maps onto the means-of-knowledge (*pramāṇa*) debate. Cārvāka is the strict evidentialist: only perception (*pratyakṣa*), so no supersensible belief is justified. Nyāya is the inferentialist: inference (*anumāna*) and the word of a reliable authority (*āpta-vākya*) justify. Mīmāṃsā's **intrinsic validity (svataḥ-prāmāṇya)** - a cognition is valid on its own until defeated - is the closest classical analogue of proper basicity; Nyāya's **extrinsic validity (parataḥ-prāmāṇya)** - validity must be established by something further - is the closest analogue of evidentialism. **ANALYSIS:** Do not assert a looser parallel than this one.

Objection 1. Properly basic religious belief is immune to criticism. **Reply.** **[FACT]** Plantinga insists it is **defeasible** - the problem of evil, projection theories and cognitive-science explanations of religion are all potential defeaters that must be met.

Objection 2. Religious diversity means incompatible beliefs are all "properly basic". **Reply.** **[FACT]** Diversity is a defeater to be answered, not an automatic refutation - but no one holds that it is easily answered.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: Religious beliefs can be justified, but only once the standard of justification is itself put on trial. **Named evidence:** Clifford's 1877 maxim and Flew's presumption of atheism state the strict standard; Plantinga's 1983 argument shows that the standard presupposes a classical foundationalism which is self-referentially incoherent and cannot accommodate memory or other minds; Mīmāṃsā's intrinsic validity (*svataḥ-prāmāṇya*) is the classical analogue of proper basicity, and Nyāya's extrinsic validity (*parataḥ-prāmāṇya*) of evidentialism. **Analysis:** Since the strict criterion disqualifies ordinary beliefs no one abandons, the burden shifts to the evidentialist to state a criterion that religion fails and memory passes. **Qualification:** The Reformed rescue relocates rationality inside a doxastic practice, so the live objection changes from *insufficient evidence* to *incompatible practices* - and religious diversity, not evidential poverty, becomes the real problem.

UPSC TRAPS

1. **ANALYSIS:** Do not say Plantinga claims God's existence is self-evident. He claims theistic belief can be **properly basic** - grounded, warranted and defeasible - and that classical foundationalism is self-referentially incoherent.
2. **ANALYSIS:** Do not present Clifford's maxim without James's reply, or James's reply without its restriction to living, forced and momentous options where evidence is genuinely inconclusive.
3. **ANALYSIS:** Do not assert a loose Indian parallel. Use the exact analogues: intrinsic validity ≈ proper basicity; extrinsic validity ≈ evidentialism.

MINI RECAP

The question is about the *standard*. Clifford/Flew -> James -> Plantinga's five steps -> warrant and proper function -> Great Pumpkin -> Alston. Indian analogue: intrinsic versus extrinsic validity. Residual problem: diversity.

SESSION 12 - MIRACLES AND TESTIMONY: HUME AND HIS CRITICS

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. Can a report from witnesses ever make it reasonable to believe that a law of nature was broken? Hume says the evidential arithmetic is against it; his critics say his arithmetic is wrong.

Technical definition. Hume defines a miracle as "*a violation of the laws of nature*" brought about by a particular volition of the Deity, and argues in two Parts that testimony can never establish one.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING

Hume shows that miracle-testimony faces an unusually heavy evidential burden; he does not show that the burden is in principle unmeetable.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

violation of a law of nature · proportion belief to the evidence · uniform experience · Hume's maxim · passion for surprise and wonder · contrary miracles cancel · non-repeatable counter-instance · principle of credulity · principle of testimony · Bayesian posterior · accomplishments (siddhi / vibhūti)

How to use them: name Part I and Part II separately. Scripts that blur them lose the structure the examiner is checking for.

VISUAL - THE TWO PARTS AND THE FIVE REPLIES

== HUME, *Enquiry Concerning Human Understanding*, SECTION X (1748) ==

PART I - THE A PRIORI BALANCE

```

1 a wise man proportions belief to
  the evidence
2 laws of nature rest on UNIFORM,
  exceptionless experience - the
  strongest empirical evidence there
  is
3 testimony rests on experience of
  human reliability - strong, but
  NOT uniform
4 so a miracle report sets uniform
  against non-uniform evidence, and
  the weaker must yield
5 HUME'S MAXIM: no testimony suffices
  unless its FALSEHOOD would be MORE
  MIRACULOUS than the fact it seeks
  to establish - and even then,
  subtract the lesser marvel from
  the greater
  
```

PART II - FOUR A POSTERIORI CONSIDERATIONS

```

(a) NO miracle attested
  by enough witnesses of
  unquestioned sense,
  education, integrity
  and public reputation
  with much to lose
+-----+
(b) a standing human
  PASSION FOR SURPRISE
  AND WONDER multiplies
  marvellous reports
+-----+
(c) such reports
  flourish chiefly among
  IGNORANT AND BARBAROUS
  NATIONS, or descend
  from such origins
+-----+
(d) CONTRARY MIRACLES
  CANCEL: rival
  religions' miracles
  support incompatible
  systems, so each set
  destroys the others'
  credit
  
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----- THE REPLIES -----

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1 DEFINITIONAL    if "law of nature" = exceptionless regularity, a genuine
                  exception shows the LAW was mis-stated - miracles are
                  defined out of existence rather than disproved.
                  SWINBURNE recasts a miracle as a NON-REPEATABLE
                  COUNTER-INSTANCE to an otherwise well-confirmed law.
2 EVIDENTIAL      SWINBURNE's principles of CREDULITY and TESTIMONY give
                  apparent memory, perception and report a prima facie
                  right to be believed; Hume's rule makes them powerless
                  exactly where they would matter - question-begging.
3 BAYESIAN        EARMAN, *Hume's Abject Failure* (2000): Hume confuses the
                  PRIOR improbability of an event with its POSTERIOR
                  probability given testimony; multiple independent
                  witnesses of moderate reliability can raise the
                  posterior of a very improbable event arbitrarily high.
4 CIRCULARITY     (C. S. Lewis and others) to know that uniform experience
                  is against miracles you must ALREADY know every miracle
                  report is false - which is the conclusion.
5 CONTRARY-       the cancellation argument assumes rival reports are
  MIRACLES        equally well attested and mutually exclusive.
  
```

WHAT SURVIVES: Part II is a permanently useful checklist of EVIDENTIAL CAUTION. Part I is now widely regarded as too strong, since it would exclude testimony for ANY sufficiently improbable event, including well-attested scientific anomalies.

TEACHING

[FACT] Part I, the a priori balance. The five steps are as printed in the visual, ending in Hume's maxim.

[FACT] Part II, the four a posteriori considerations. Witness quality; the passion for surprise and wonder; the provenance of such reports; and the mutual cancellation of contrary miracles.

[FACT] The five replies. Definitional (Swinburne's non-repeatable counter-instance); evidential (the principles of credulity and testimony); Bayesian (Earman, 2000); the circularity charge (C. S. Lewis and others); and the reply to contrary miracles.

[FACT] Indian parity - and here India declines the strategy. The tradition is markedly unenthusiastic about the evidential use of the marvellous. Patañjali's *Yoga-sūtra* Book III catalogues the accomplishments (*siddhi* / *vibhūti*) in detail and then, at 3.37, declares them **obstacles** to absorption (*samādhi*) though "accomplishments" in the outward-turned state - the powers are real but soteriologically worthless. Buddhism records psychic power (*iddhi*)

while the *Kevaddha Sutta* (Dīgha Nikāya 11) has the Buddha reject the display of psychic powers as a means of gaining converts, preferring the "miracle of instruction". Mīmāṃsā grounds Vedic authority in authorless (*apauruṣeya*) eternality precisely so that it needs **no** miraculous authentication.

ANALYSIS: [INFERENCE] So where Western apologetics uses miracles to *authenticate* revelation, Indian systems mostly *decline* the strategy. That is a genuine comparative point, not a parallel - and saying so is what distinguishes comparison from name-dropping.

Objection. If Part I fails, does the miracle argument for revelation succeed? **Reply. [FACT]** The stronger conclusion is that a miracle can at best be evidence **for those already inside** an interpretive framework that identifies which events would count as divine action - which returns the question to revelation and faith, that is, to Sessions 5 and 6.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: Testimony can in principle support a miracle-claim, but only within a framework that already identifies what would count as divine action. **Named evidence:** Hume's Part I maxim requires that the testimony's falsehood be more miraculous than the reported fact; Swinburne recasts a miracle as a non-repeatable counter-instance and invokes the principles of credulity and testimony; Earman's *Hume's Abject Failure* (2000) shows that independent witnesses can raise a very low posterior probability sharply. **Analysis:** Once the definitional and Bayesian replies land, the debate shifts from whether testimony *can* support an improbable event to whether the event's religious interpretation is independently warranted. **Qualification:** Part II survives intact as a checklist of evidential caution, and the Indian material shows that a tradition can hold a strong revelation-claim while refusing the miracle strategy altogether - as *Yoga-sūtra* 3.37 does by treating the accomplishments as obstacles.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not attribute to Hume the claim that miracles are *impossible*. His claim is about the evidential force of testimony.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not accept Hume's definition uncritically; Swinburne's non-repeatable counter-instance is the standard contestation.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not treat the Indian material as a parallel to Western apologetics. It is a contrast: India largely declines the strategy.

MINI RECAP

Part I = the balance and the maxim. Part II = four cautions. Five replies. Part II survives; Part I is too strong. India declines the strategy.

SESSION 13 - SCIENCE AND RELIGION: BARBOUR'S FOUR MODELS

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. "How do science and religion relate?" has no single answer. The standard philosophical map gives four possible relationships, and the answer is to argue for one of them rather than to tell the story of Galileo.

Technical definition. The standard map is **Ian Barbour's fourfold typology** - Conflict, Independence, Dialogue, Integration - set out in *Religion and Science: Historical and Contemporary Issues* (1997) and *When Science Meets Religion* (2000).

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING

Neither wholesale conflict nor wholesale independence survives scrutiny: conflict overgeneralises from a few historically distorted episodes, independence saves the peace by silencing both parties, and the defensible position is dialogue at the boundary questions with local conflict only where a religious claim is genuinely empirical.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

Conflict · Independence · Dialogue · Integration · warfare thesis · non-overlapping magisteria (NOMA) · boundary questions · methodological parallels · theology of nature · process thought · Confirmation (Haught)

How to use them: four models, one cost each, then a verdict. That is the whole 10-mark answer. Do **not** narrate Galileo.

VISUAL - FOUR MODELS, FOUR COSTS

1. CONFLICT -----	
CLAIM	science and religion make competing claims about the SAME world, so one must yield
TWO MIRROR VERSIONS	
· scientific materialism - only what science certifies is real	
· scriptural literalism - the text overrides established science	
HISTORIOGRAPHY	the "WARFARE THESIS":
J. W. DRAPER, History of the Conflict between Religion and Science (1874)	
A. D. WHITE, A History of the Warfare of Science with Theology in Christendom (1896)	
ANALYSIS: DISCIPLINE	the warfare thesis is NOW REJECTED by most historians of science as a polemical nineteenth-century construction.
Saying so is a MARK-EARNING QUALIFICATION, not a digression.	
+-- 2. INDEPENDENCE -----	
CLAIM	separate domains, different questions, different languages - so they CANNOT conflict
NAMED	GOULD's NOMA - Non-Overlapping Magisteria, Rocks of Ages (1999)
science = the empirical realm of fact and theory	
religion = the realm of ultimate meaning and moral value	
neo-orthodox theology and Wittgensteinian language-game readings reach the same result from different premises	
COST	it buys peace by forbidding either side to say anything the other could contest - which few believers or scientists accept
+-- 3. DIALOGUE -----	
CLAIM	distinct but TOUCHING at boundary questions
BOUNDARY QUESTIONS	why is there a universe at all? why is it intelligible? why do the constants permit life?
METHODOLOGICAL PARALLELS	models, metaphors, paradigms, and the theory-ladenness of data in BOTH
COST	fruitful but non-committal: it establishes conversation, not conclusions
+-- 4. INTEGRATION -----	
CLAIM	substantive contact
· natural theology (fine-tuning arguments)	
· theology of nature (revising doctrine in the light of evolution and cosmology)	
· systematic synthesis, e.g. PROCESS THOUGHT	
COST	hostage to the science of the day: yesterday's integration becomes tomorrow's embarrassment

ALTERNATIVE FRAME HAUGHT: Conflict / Contrast / Contact / CONFIRMATION
- "Confirmation" adds that religion positively SUPPORTS the scientific enterprise by underwriting the world's intelligibility.

INDIAN MATERIAL (distinctive, not an echo)

VIVEKANANDA Vedanta as the tradition most able to accept scientific findings because it grounds religion in verifiable experience rather than dogma; the disciplines of realisation as a "science of the soul"

ANALYSIS: report this as a CLAIM, never endorse it

RADHAKRISHNAN scientific and religious knowing as different LEVELS of one integral experience

AUROBINDO evolutionary metaphysics = an explicit INTEGRATION model

CLASSICAL ROOT is verbal testimony (sabda) an INDEPENDENT means of knowledge alongside perception (pratyaksa) and inference (anumana)? That is exactly the "can revelation add anything?" question in Indian dress -
Carvaka: NO. Nyaya and Mimamsa: YES.

TEACHING

[FACT] The typology and its sources. Barbour, *Religion and Science: Historical and Contemporary Issues* (1997) and *When Science Meets Religion* (2000): Conflict, Independence, Dialogue, Integration.

[FACT] Each model with its argument and cost. As set out in the visual. The named anchors that must appear are Draper (1874), White (1896), Gould's NOMA in *Rocks of Ages* (1999), the boundary questions, process thought, and Haught's alternative fourfold with Confirmation.

[FACT] Religion's continuing significance - the normative argument. Religion's significance is normative and existential: technology settles what we *can* do, not what we *should* do, and not what a life is for.

[FACT] Presupposition of the whole exercise. That "science" and "religion" name two stable, comparable things - a presupposition the historicist critique denies, since both categories are modern and internally plural.

Objection. The typology is descriptively neat but normatively empty: it does not tell you which model is *correct*. **Reply.**

[FACT] It is a classification of positions, and the argument must be made model by model; the defensible position is usually a **domain-sensitive mixture** - independence about method, dialogue about boundary questions, conflict only where a religious claim is genuinely empirical.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: Religion retains significance under scientific and technological development because the relation is a set of models, not a single verdict, and the defensible model is domain-sensitive. **Named evidence:** Barbour's Conflict, Independence, Dialogue and Integration; the Draper-White warfare thesis of 1874 and 1896, now rejected by most historians of science; Gould's NOMA in *Rocks of Ages* (1999); Vivekananda's presentation of Vedānta as experience-grounded and so science-compatible. **Analysis:** Each model carries its own cost - overgeneralised history, enforced mutual silence, non-committal conversation, and hostage-taking by current science - so the verdict must be assembled from the models rather than chosen wholesale. **Qualification:** The typology is descriptive and settles nothing by itself; and the classical Indian dispute over whether verbal testimony (*śabda*) is an independent means of knowledge shows that the underlying question predates the modern categories entirely.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not narrate Galileo and call it the science-religion question. Use Barbour's four models, and note that the Draper-White warfare thesis is rejected by most historians of science.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not treat NOMA as the obvious solution. State its cost: peace bought by forbidding both sides to make contestable claims.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not endorse Vivekananda's "science of the soul" as an established result. Report it as a claim.

MINI RECAP

Four models, four costs. Warfare thesis is rejected. NOMA has a price. Verdict: dialogue at boundary questions, local conflict only on genuinely empirical claims.

SESSION 14 - THE INDIAN-WESTERN PARITY BENCH

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. Indian philosophy already argues the whole reason-revelation-faith question, but in its own vocabulary: as a debate about whether authoritative words are an independent source of knowledge.

Technical definition. The Indian debate is explicitly epistemological: whether verbal testimony (*śabda*) is an independent means of valid knowledge (*pramāṇa*), and whether the validity of a cognition is intrinsic (*svataḥ-prāmāṇya*) or extrinsic (*parataḥ-prāmāṇya*).

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING

The Indian tradition does not merely echo the Western debate; it supplies a form of scriptural authority with no revealer at all, and a validity dispute that maps exactly onto proper basicity versus evidentialism.

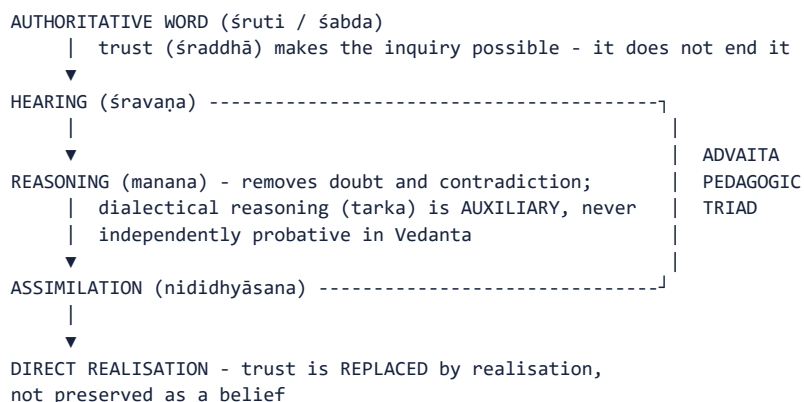
MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

means of valid knowledge (*pramāṇa*) · perception (*pratyakṣa*) · inference (*anumāna*) · verbal testimony (*śabda*) · word of a reliable authority (*āpta-vākya*) · authorless (*apauruṣeya*) · intrinsic validity (*svataḥ-prāmāṇya*) · extrinsic validity (*parataḥ-prāmāṇya*) · hearing-reasoning-assimilation (*śravaṇa-manana-nididhyāsana*) · trust (*śraddhā* / Pali *saddhā*)

VISUAL - THE SIX-ROW PARITY BENCH

Issue	Western	Indian	Note
Is testimony an independent source of knowledge?	Locke and Hume: reducible to experience	Nyāya and Mīmāṃsā: verbal testimony (<i>śabda</i>) is an independent means of knowledge (<i>pramāṇa</i>); Cārvāka denies it	the Indian debate is explicitly epistemological
Is validity intrinsic or extrinsic?	foundationalism versus Reformed proper basicity	Mīmāṃsā's intrinsic validity (<i>svataḥ-prāmāṇya</i>) versus Nyāya's extrinsic validity (<i>parataḥ-prāmāṇya</i>)	the closest exact parallel in the whole clause
Whose speech is scripture?	God's word - propositional revelation	Mīmāṃsā: authorless (<i>apauruṣeya</i>) - no author, human or divine	India has a form of scriptural authority with no revealer
Faith as trust	the faith by which one believes (<i>fides qua</i>); Tillich's ultimate concern	trust (<i>śraddhā</i>), <i>Gītā</i> 17.2-3; Buddhist trust (Pali: <i>saddhā</i>)	Indian trust is verification-directed (<i>Kālāma Sutta</i>)
Reason's role	preambles, coherence, apologetics	reasoning (<i>manana</i>); dialectical reasoning (<i>tarka</i>) as auxiliary, never independently probative in Vedānta	both subordinate reason without eliminating it
Miracles as authentication	central to Western apologetics	accomplishments (<i>siddhi</i>) declared obstacles (<i>Yoga-sūtra</i> 3.37); the Buddha rejects displays (<i>Kevaddha Sutta</i>)	India largely declines the strategy - a contrast, not a parallel

VISUAL - THE INDIAN ROUTE FROM SCRIPTURE TO REALISATION



BUDDHIST CONTROL: trust (Pali *saddhā*) is provisional and verification-directed - *Kālāma Sutta* (*Aṅguttara Nikāya* 3.65): do not accept a teaching merely on report, lineage, scripture, logic or the teacher's authority; test it in experience.

MĪMĀMSĀ CONTROL: the Veda is AUTHORLESS (*apauruṣeya*). It therefore needs no divine speaker AND no miraculous authentication - which is why the Western circularity problem takes a different shape here.

TEACHING

[FACT] The bench. Six rows, as tabulated. Two of them carry disproportionate marks: the intrinsic/extrinsic validity row, and the authorless-scripture row.

[FACT] **The exact analogues.** Mīmāṃsā's intrinsic validity (*svataḥ-prāmāṇya*) ≈ proper basicity. Nyāya's extrinsic validity (*parataḥ-prāmāṇya*) ≈ evidentialism. Cārvāka is the strict evidentialist limit. ANALYSIS: Do not assert a looser parallel than this.

[FACT] **The comparative asymmetry on miracles.** Western apologetics uses miracles to authenticate; Indian systems largely decline the strategy. This is a *contrast*, and presenting it as a parallel is an error.

[FACT] **Advaita's route.** Scripture (*śruti*) discloses Brahman; reasoning (*manana*) removes doubt; trust (*śraddhā*) enables inquiry. The characteristic risk is scriptural circularity.

[FACT] **Mīmāṃsā's route.** Reason interprets injunction and testimony; the Veda is authorless and is not a creator's speech; the characteristic risk is cross-tradition warrant.

Objection. Cross-tradition mapping distorts both sides: "proper basicity" is an analytic notion with a design-plan theory behind it, and intrinsic validity is a claim inside a ritual hermeneutics. **Reply.** [INFERENCE] The mapping is a claim about the *structure* of the warrant question - is a cognition valid until defeated, or only once certified? - and not about the surrounding metaphysics. Stating that limitation is itself a mark of control.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: Indian epistemology contributes a distinct position to the reason-revelation-faith debate rather than an illustration of the Western one. **Named evidence:** Mīmāṃsā holds the Veda to be authorless (*apauruṣeya*), so scriptural authority exists without any revealer; its doctrine of intrinsic validity (*svataḥ-prāmāṇya*) parallels proper basicity, while Nyāya's extrinsic validity (*parataḥ-prāmāṇya*) parallels evidentialism; *Yoga-sūtra* 3.37 treats the accomplishments (*siddhi*) as obstacles. **Analysis:** Because authority here is detached from a divine speaker and from miraculous authentication, the Indian material tests whether the Western problem of authenticating a *revealer* is essential to revelation at all. **Qualification:** The parallels hold at the level of warrant-structure only; importing the surrounding ritual hermeneutics or design-plan machinery on either side would over-claim.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not describe the authorless Veda as revelation from a personal God.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not present Indian material as a decorative closing sentence. Put it where it does argumentative work - the validity row.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not import complete Mīmāṃsā, Nyāya, Vedānta or Buddhist epistemology; the firewall keeps those with the Paper I owners.

MINI RECAP

Six-row bench. Intrinsic ≈ properly basic; extrinsic ≈ evidentialist. Authorless scripture. Trust that initiates verification. Miracles: contrast, not parallel.

SESSION 15 - ANSWER ARCHITECTURE, DIRECTIVE DECODING AND QUOTATION DISCIPLINE

DEFINITION

Plain-language definition. The last session converts the doctrine into scripts: what each directive is buying, how long each section should be, what a top-band answer contains, and what you may safely quote.

Technical definition. Answer architecture specifies the 10-, 15- and 20-mark skeletons; the directive decoder maps each printed instruction to a structural consequence; the verdict ladder states what each band contains; quotation discipline fixes what may be attributed and how.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING

This clause punishes binaries: reason/faith, rational/irrational, science/religion and evidence/basicity are all three-term distinctions once the middle category is supplied.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

directive · demand decoding · graded verdict · defeater statement · attribution discipline · paraphrase not pseudo-quotation

VISUAL A - THE THREE SKELETONS

10 MARKS

define the exact term asked
 + the doctrine's internal relation
 + ONE distinction
 + ONE objection
 + a DIRECT verdict (no survey, no list)

15 MARKS

frame the WARRANT problem
 + the propositional OR encounter model, in steps
 + criteria of justification
 + a rival model or the Indian comparison
 + objection AND reply

20 MARKS

map the three concepts
 + the strongest HARMONY model and the strongest CONFLICT model
 + presuppositions of each
 + competing-revelation and evidential objections
 + Indian-Western comparison
 + a DEFENDED synthesis

VISUAL B - THE DIRECTIVE DECODER

Printed directive	What the examiner is buying	Structural consequence	Live example
"What is instrumental to X: A or B? Justify your position"	a choice , defended - not "both are important"	choose; give the strongest case; then concede what the loser explains better	2019 Q5(a)
"Discuss the significance of X vis-à-vis Y"	a relation, <i>modelled</i>	use a typology (Barbour), never a narrative	2020 Q5(a)
"What are the basic tenets of X? Distinguish X and Y"	two separate deliverables	enumerate the tenets; then a differentia table	2020 Q7(c)
"Can A be a regulative force in B? Explain"	the precise sense of "regulative"	<i>regulative</i> (constrains, vetoes, disciplines) ≠ <i>constitutive</i> (generates content)	2021 Q7(a)
"Critically comment"	a short but evaluative verdict at 10 marks	no survey; one distinction, one objection, one verdict	2022 Q5(d)
"Can X be justified? Discuss"	the standard of justification, not the truth of X	name the epistemology first: evidentialist, or basic?	2023 Q5(b)
"Explain the rational and irrational aspects of X"	three categories, not two	rational / supra-rational / irrational - the middle term is the answer	2023 Q6(c)
"What kind of epistemic justifications are possible ... with your own comments"	a typology plus a first-person assessment	list the criteria, then rank them yourself	2024 Q7(b)
"How does X reconcile A and B?"	the <i>mechanism</i> of reconciliation, stated as a structure	name the two storeys and the hinge between them	2025 Q5(e)
"Distinguish A and B in the context of C"	a three-term answer; C is not decorative	natural versus revealed theology as seen from the propositional model	2025 Q6(c)

VISUAL C - THE GRADED VERDICT LADDER

Band	What the script contains	Typical fault
Weak (≈40%)	"reason argues, faith trusts"; Aquinas and Kierkegaard named	no epistemology; faith defined as evidence-free belief
Average (≈50%)	the four stances; propositional and non-propositional revelation	Indian material limited to one sentence on trust (<i>śraddhā</i>)
Good (≈60%)	one position reconstructed with premises; one objection answered	the middle category - supra-rational, dialogue, defeasible basicity - is missing
Strong (≈65-70%)	the justification standard is named; Indian means-of-knowledge parity used; the competing-revelation problem raised	the verdict summarises instead of deciding
Top (≈70%+)	all the above, plus one discriminating distinction (<i>fides qua</i> / <i>fides quae</i> ; intrinsic versus extrinsic validity; regulative versus constitutive; violation versus non-repeatable counter-instance) plus a statement of the defeater that would change the verdict	-

[FACT] Graded-verdict templates.

- *Reason/faith stem*: "Reason is **regulative** but not **constitutive** of religious belief: it can veto incoherence, discipline interpretation and assess evidence, but it does not generate the content that faith receives."
- *Justification stem*: "Religious beliefs can be justified, but the standard cannot be the strict evidentialist one, which disqualifies memory and other minds as well. Once justification is located inside a doxastic practice, the live objection changes from *insufficient evidence* to *incompatible practices*."
- *Revelation stem*: "A revelation-claim is warranted, if at all, by a **convergence** - internal coherence, moral fruits, the recipient's experience, communal transmission and congruence with reason - no one of which is decisive, and none of which is neutral between traditions."

VISUAL D - QUOTATION AND ATTRIBUTION DISCIPLINE

Item	Status	Safe use
<i>Credo ut intelligam</i> - "I believe in order that I may understand"	FACT: Anselmian formula, <i>Proslogion</i> 1, in the Augustinian "faith seeking understanding" tradition	attribute to the Augustinian-Anselmian tradition
The "because it is absurd" slogan	CAUTION: not a verified verbatim Tertullian sentence	call it "a later slogan for extreme fideism"
Aquinas on faith as a mean between knowledge and opinion	FACT: <i>Summa Theologiae</i> II-II qq. 1-4	paraphrase; never fabricate an English quotation
Clifford's maxim	FACT: W. K. Clifford, "The Ethics of Belief" (1877)	the shipowner example is his
<i>The Will to Believe</i>	FACT: William James (1896)	the reply is restricted to living, forced, momentous options
"Of Miracles"	FACT: Hume, <i>Enquiry Concerning Human Understanding</i> , Section X	Part I = the maxim; Part II = the four considerations
Non-repeatable counter-instance	FACT: Richard Swinburne's recasting of "miracle"	use to show Hume's definition is contestable
<i>Hume's Abject Failure</i>	FACT: John Earman (2000)	the Bayesian critique
Draper-White "warfare thesis"	FACT: real books (1874, 1896)	ANALYSIS: now rejected by most historians of science - say so
NOMA	FACT: Stephen Jay Gould, <i>Rocks of Ages</i> (1999)	the Independence model
The fourfold typology	FACT: Ian Barbour	Haught's Conflict/Contrast/Contact/Confirmation is the alternative
<i>Faith and Belief</i>	FACT: Wilfred Cantwell Smith (1979)	for the historical narrowing of "belief"
"Reason and Belief in God" / <i>Warranted Christian Belief</i>	FACT: Alvin Plantinga (1983; 2000)	proper basicity, warrant, proper function, sense of the divine (<i>sensus divinitatis</i>)
<i>Perceiving God</i>	FACT: William Alston (1991)	doxastic practices
<i>Gītā</i> 17.2-3 on trust (<i>śraddhā</i>)	FACT: verified chapter and verse	"as is one's <i>śraddhā</i> , so is one" - paraphrase
<i>Kālāma Sutta</i> (AN 3.65); <i>Kevaddha Sutta</i> (DN 11)	FACT: verified references	paraphrase; do not quote a translation as canonical
<i>Yoga-sūtra</i> 3.37 on the accomplishments as obstacles	FACT: verified aphorism	the key Indian anti-miracle datum

TEACHING

[FACT] Foundational statement bank - five safe formulations.

1. The Augustinian-Anselmian formula *credo ut intelligam* presents faith as seeking understanding.
2. Aquinas places faith between demonstrative knowledge and wavering opinion: it is firm assent to what is not seen.
3. Kierkegaard links faith with passionate inward commitment under objective uncertainty.
4. Clifford's evidentialist maxim makes insufficient evidence morally relevant to belief.
5. CAUTION: The popular "because it is absurd" formula is commonly associated with Tertullian but is not a safe verbatim quotation from him; use it only as a later slogan for extreme fideism.

[FACT] Safe general formulations. "Faith may go beyond coercive proof without going against reason." ·

"Revelation requires both an alleged disclosure and a warranted mode of reception." · "Faith is not a weaker belief; it

is a different act, of which belief is one component." · "Hume raised the evidential bar for miracles; he did not show it unclearable." · "The evidentialist standard, applied strictly, disqualifies far more than religion."

[FACT] Corpus signal. Eleven primary-owned question-parts out of 112 in the audited 2018-2025 Paper II corpus. 2018 has no owned part; 2020-2025 broaden the clause well beyond a simple reason-versus-faith binary. Required depth includes self-revelation, religion under scientific-technological modernity, faith versus belief, reason as regulative, and the epistemic warrant of revelation.

[INFERENCE] Timed-paper compression plan (non-repetitive). For a 10-marker under time pressure, cut the parity bench to its single strongest row and keep the objection; for a 15-marker, cut one of the two models to three lines and keep the criteria list intact; for a 20-marker, cut the historiographical qualification but never the defeater statement. The defeater sentence is the last thing to go, because it is the only sentence that distinguishes a strong band from a top band.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH

Claim: Every high-scoring answer in this clause is organised by a middle term rather than by a binary. **Named evidence:** The 2021 stem turns on *regulative* against *constitutive*; the 2023 15-marker turns on the supra-rational between rational and irrational; the 2020 science stem turns on dialogue between conflict and independence; the 2023 10-marker turns on defeasible basicity between proof and immunity. **Analysis:** In each case the two visible options are the ones a weak script chooses between, so naming the third position simultaneously answers the question and demonstrates command of the literature. **Qualification:** The middle term must be argued, not merely named; an unsupported "both are important" is the very failure the directive decoder is designed to prevent.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not close with "both reason and faith are important". Every directive above rewards a decision.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not fabricate quotations. Paraphrase and cite the work.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not omit the defeater sentence - the statement of what would change your verdict. It is the cheapest top-band marker available.

MINI RECAP

Three skeletons; ten directives; five bands. Middle terms win. Paraphrase, never invent. End with a defeater statement.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Practice protocol

Attempt every item before reading its key. The correct option position was fixed **independently for each question** using a length-balanced, non-patterned assignment: there is no rotation, no repeating cycle and no adjacent repetition to exploit, and the four positions each carry exactly eight answers across the thirty-two diagnostics. Every option carries a question-specific explanation, and every question carries a unique examiner trap.

CORE DIAGNOSTIC MCQS - 24

MCQ 1. Regulative rather than constitutive reason

Reason is said to be *regulative* rather than *constitutive* of religious belief. Which statement states that claim most exactly?

- A. Reason converts religious commitment into demonstrative knowledge of its object.
- B. Reason becomes relevant only once a doctrine has been accepted as infallible.
- C. Reason vetoes contradiction and disciplines interpretation without authoring content.
- D. Reason deduces every revealed mystery from premises that are self-evident.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Conversion into demonstration is exactly what Aquinas denies of faith, which has firmness without vision; this option describes knowledge, not regulation.
- **B:** Incorrect: Deferring reason until after infallibility has been granted removes its veto, which is the one power the regulative model insists on retaining.
- **C:** Correct: Regulation is the negative and corrective power to veto incoherence, weigh testimony, discipline reading and name defeaters, while constitution would be the productive power to supply content.
- **D:** Incorrect: Deducing the mysteries from self-evident premises is constitutive rationalism, the position the regulative model is defined against.

Examiner trap 1: The 2021 stem prints the word "regulative"; scripts that answer with "reason and faith are both important" have not engaged the printed term at all.

MCQ 2. The two axes of revelation are independent

Consider the following statements about the two axes of revelation. (i) The general/special distinction concerns scope and medium. (ii) The propositional/non-propositional distinction concerns what revelation is. (iii) The two distinctions are two names for one ladder. Which are correct?

- A. (i) and (iii) only
- B. (i) and (ii) only
- C. (ii) and (iii) only
- D. (i), (ii) and (iii)

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Statement (iii) is the error the owner explicitly warns against, so any combination that includes it must be rejected.
- **B:** Correct: Scope and medium form one axis, and the nature of revelation as truth-content or as encounter forms a second, independent axis that crosses it.
- **C:** Incorrect: Statement (ii) is right but (iii) is wrong, so this pairing imports the collapse the distinction is designed to prevent.
- **D:** Incorrect: Accepting all three is self-contradictory, since (iii) denies the independence that (i) and (ii) jointly assert.

Examiner trap 2: Collapsing scope into nature makes the 2025 fifteen-marker unanswerable, because natural and revealed theology are then indistinguishable from general and special revelation.

MCQ 3. Where Aquinas locates the act of faith

For Aquinas, faith is best located as which of the following?

- A. A probable opinion that still retains the fear that the opposite may be true.
- B. An emotional condition that operates entirely independently of the intellect.
- C. Firm intellectual assent to unseen divine truth, commanded by the will under grace.
- D. Demonstrative knowledge of the mysteries derived from purely natural premises.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Opinion is precisely what faith is *not*: opinion lacks firmness, whereas faith assents firmly.
- **B:** Incorrect: Aquinas makes faith an act of the intellect; removing the intellect destroys the account he actually gives.
- **C:** Correct: Faith is the intellect's firm assent to divine truth, commanded by the will moved by grace, and it is a mean between knowledge, which has sight, and opinion, which does not have firmness.
- **D:** Incorrect: If the mysteries were demonstrable from natural premises they would be preambles, and the two-storey structure would collapse.

Examiner trap 3: "Certainty without evidence" is the wrong gloss. It is firmness without *vision*, resting on testimony and motives of credibility.

MCQ 4. Hick's four-step chain, in order

Which sequence correctly states Hick's non-propositional model of revelation?

- A. Infallible scripture, then deductive proof, then divine action, then private feeling.
- B. Ambiguous event, then faith's experiencing-as, then communal interpretation, then doctrine.
- C. Linguistic analysis, then elimination of experience, then delivery of revealed propositions.
- D. Natural theology, then scientific confirmation, then doctrine, then religious encounter.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: This reverses the model: it begins with the propositions Hick treats as the community's later interpretation.
- **B:** Correct: Events are religiously ambiguous, faith perceives them as divine action, communities conceptualise the encounter, and doctrinal diversity then reflects interpretive schemes.
- **C:** Incorrect: Elimination of experience belongs to the verificationist debate owned by the religious-language clause, not to Hick's account of revelation.
- **D:** Incorrect: Making scientific confirmation a step in revelation misdescribes both natural theology and the non-propositional model.

Examiner trap 4: "Experiencing-as" is a perceptual structure under a concept, not a synonym for an intense feeling.

MCQ 5. Matching an authentication test to its limit

Which pairing of an authentication test with its correct built-in limit is accurate?

- A. Coherence - a fully coherent claim is thereby shown to be of divine origin.
- B. Moral fruit - beneficial effects are impossible under a false belief system.
- C. Tradition - long communal endurance is by itself a direct proof of truth.
- D. Testimony - a report can transmit error just as reliably as it transmits truth.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Coherence cannot establish divine origin; a consistent fiction remains consistent, which is exactly the stated limit.
- **B:** Incorrect: The owner states the opposite: useful effects can occur under false beliefs, which is why fruit is defeasible evidence.
- **C:** Incorrect: Communal endurance may preserve power or bias rather than truth, so endurance is not proof.
- **D:** Correct: Testimony's limit is precisely that it transmits error as well as truth, which is why witness competence, sincerity, placement and independent support all have to be assessed.

Examiner trap 5: Listing the six tests without their limits forfeits the analytical marks in the 2024 fifteen-marker, where the stem asks for your own comments.

MCQ 6. The two printed deliverables of the 2020 stem

In the 2020 fifteen-mark stem, "What are the basic tenets of faith? Distinguish between faith and belief", the structurally correct response is to:

- A. Enumerate the tenets first, then run the differentia table between faith and belief.
- B. Define faith as belief without evidence and then contrast it with scientific belief.
- C. Discuss Aquinas at length and treat the tenets as an implied conclusion.
- D. Present the faith-belief distinction only, since the tenets follow from it automatically.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: The stem prints two separate deliverables, and the owner's decoder requires enumeration of the seven tenets followed by a differentia table.
- **B:** Incorrect: Defining faith as evidence-free belief makes the second half of the stem unanswerable and is a listed trap.
- **C:** Incorrect: Aquinas supports the distinction through the faith which is believed and the faith by which one believes, but he is evidence, not the structure.
- **D:** Incorrect: Deriving the tenets from the distinction inverts the printed order and leaves the first deliverable unaddressed.

Examiner trap 6: Two printed obligations mean two visible sections. An examiner scanning for the tenets should not have to hunt for them inside a comparison.

MCQ 7. Mīmāṃsā's authorless scripture

Which statement most precisely captures Mīmāṃsā's position on scriptural authority?

- A. The Veda is the speech of a creator God and is authenticated by miracles.
- B. The Veda derives its authority from Nyāya-style inference to a reliable speaker.
- C. Mīmāṃsā rejects the authority of the Veda in favour of perception alone.
- D. The Veda is authorless, so it has authority without any revealer, human or divine.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Attributing the Veda to a creator God's speech destroys the very feature that makes the comparison valuable.
- **B:** Incorrect: Inference to a reliable speaker is the Nyāya route; Mīmāṃsā's authorless doctrine is designed to avoid needing one.
- **C:** Incorrect: Rejecting scriptural authority in favour of perception alone is the Cārvāka position, not the Mīmāṃsā position.
- **D:** Correct: The authorless (*apauruṣeya*) Veda is authoritative without an author, which is why India offers a form of scriptural authority with no revealer.

Examiner trap 7: This is a listed trap in the owner. Calling the authorless Veda "revelation from a personal God" reverses the one point the comparison exists to make.

MCQ 8. The exact analogue of proper basicity

Which is the closest classical Indian analogue of Plantinga's proper basicity?

- A. Mīmāṃsā's intrinsic validity, on which a cognition is valid until it is defeated.
- B. Nyāya's extrinsic validity, on which validity must be established by something further.
- C. Cārvāka's restriction of the means of knowledge to perception alone.
- D. The Advaita triad of hearing, reasoning and assimilation taken as a whole.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Intrinsic validity (*svataḥ-prāmāṇya*) holds a cognition valid on its own until defeated, which is structurally what proper basicity claims.
- **B:** Incorrect: Extrinsic validity (*parataḥ-prāmāṇya*) requires further certification, so it is the analogue of evidentialism, not of proper basicity.
- **C:** Incorrect: Cārvāka's restriction to perception is the strict evidentialist limit case at the far end of the same spectrum.
- **D:** Incorrect: The pedagogic triad describes a route from scripture to realisation; it is not a theory of when a cognition counts as valid.

Examiner trap 8: The owner forbids a looser parallel. Write the exact pair - intrinsic validity with proper basicity, extrinsic validity with evidentialism.

MCQ 9. The load-bearing step against evidentialism

Which statement correctly describes the load-bearing step in Plantinga's argument against the evidentialist objection?

- A. He shows by demonstration that God exists and therefore that belief is warranted.
- B. He argues classical foundationalism is self-referentially incoherent and too narrow.
- C. He claims that the proposition "God exists" is self-evident to any rational person.
- D. He denies that religious belief can ever be defeated by any counter-consideration.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Plantinga's argument is epistemological and does not run through a demonstration of God's existence.
- **B:** Correct: The criterion of classical foundationalism satisfies none of its own conditions and cannot accommodate memory, other minds or beliefs about the past, so basicity is not confined to its list.
- **C:** Incorrect: Self-evidence is precisely what Plantinga does *not* claim; that is a listed trap in the owner file.
- **D:** Incorrect: He insists on defeasibility, naming evil, projection theories and cognitive-science explanations as potential defeaters.

Examiner trap 9: Do not write that Plantinga makes God's existence self-evident. He makes theistic belief properly basic, grounded, warranted and defeasible.

MCQ 10. What restricts James's will-to-believe

Which of the following states the restriction that keeps James's will-to-believe from licensing wishful thinking?

- A. The belief must be endorsed by an established religious community before adoption.
- B. The believer must show that the belief produces measurable psychological benefit.
- C. The proposition must first be shown probable on the balance of available evidence.
- D. The option must be living, forced and momentous, with evidence genuinely inconclusive.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Communal endorsement is a criterion in the authentication debate, not James's restriction.
- **B:** Incorrect: Measurable benefit is closer to a fruit test; James's restriction is about the structure of the option.
- **C:** Incorrect: If the proposition could be shown probable, evidence would decide and the passionate decision would be unnecessary.
- **D:** Correct: The permission applies only to a living, forced and momentous option where the evidence is genuinely inconclusive, and it never licenses belief against evidence.

Examiner trap 10: Quoting Clifford without James, or James without the three conditions, is the standard way to lose the analytical mark in a justification question.

MCQ 11. What Hume's argument actually concludes

Which statement about Hume's argument in "Of Miracles" is accurate?

- A. He demonstrates that divine action upon the natural order is metaphysically impossible.
- B. He argues that testimony faces an evidential burden it cannot ordinarily discharge.
- C. He accepts any report supported by witnesses of good moral character.
- D. He treats miracles as coincidences that observers subsequently misdescribe.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Hume's conclusion concerns the force of testimony, not the metaphysical possibility of divine action, and treating it otherwise is a listed trap.
- **B:** Correct: Part I sets uniform experience against non-uniform testimony and issues the maxim that testimony suffices only if its falsehood would be more miraculous than the reported fact.
- **C:** Incorrect: Good character is only one of the four Part II considerations, and Hume denies that any actual case has satisfied the full set.
- **D:** Incorrect: Hume defines a miracle as a violation of a law of nature by a particular divine volition, not as a misdescribed coincidence.

Examiner trap 11: Hume raised the bar; he did not prove it unclearable. Say so, then bring in Swinburne's redefinition and Earman's Bayesian objection.

MCQ 12. Why Swinburne redefines a miracle

Swinburne's recasting of "miracle" as a non-repeatable counter-instance is deployed in order to:

- A. Show that Hume's definition of a miracle as a law-violation is itself contestable.
- B. Prove that at least one miracle report in history has been conclusively established.
- C. Demonstrate that laws of nature admit no exceptions of any description whatever.
- D. Replace testimony with direct perception as the sole ground of miracle-claims.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: If a law is an exceptionless regularity, a genuine exception shows the law was mis-stated, so the redefinition prevents miracles from being defined out of existence.
- **B:** Incorrect: The redefinition is conceptual; it establishes no particular historical report.
- **C:** Incorrect: The point is the reverse: it makes room for a non-repeatable exception to an otherwise well-confirmed law.
- **D:** Incorrect: Swinburne strengthens testimony through the principles of credulity and testimony rather than replacing it.

Examiner trap 12: Accepting Hume's definition without contest concedes the argument before it begins, because the definitional reply is available and cheap.

MCQ 13. Matching a Barbour model to its cost

Which pairing of a Barbour model with its stated cost is correct?

- A. Dialogue - it ties theology to the scientific theories of the present day.
- B. Integration - it forbids either domain to make claims the other could contest.
- C. Independence - it purchases peace by silencing both parties on contestable claims.
- D. Conflict - it establishes conversation but never reaches any firm conclusions.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Hostage-taking by current science is the cost of Integration, not of Dialogue.
- **B:** Incorrect: Enforced mutual silence is the cost of Independence, which is exactly what non-overlapping magisteria prescribes.
- **C:** Correct: Independence, of which Gould's non-overlapping magisteria is the named form, avoids conflict by forbidding either side to say anything the other could contest.
- **D:** Incorrect: Being fruitful but non-committal is the cost of Dialogue; Conflict's problem is that it overgeneralises from distorted history.

Examiner trap 13: Treating non-overlapping magisteria as the obvious solution loses marks. State the price it charges.

MCQ 14. The status of the Draper-White warfare thesis

Which statement about the Draper-White "warfare thesis" should appear in a strong 2020-type answer?

- A. It is the settled consensus among modern historians of science and needs no further comment.
- B. It was formulated in the mid-twentieth century as a direct response to logical positivism.
- C. It concerns only the Islamic and Indian traditions rather than the European material.
- D. It is now rejected by most historians of science as a polemical nineteenth-century construction.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: The owner records the opposite, and repeating the thesis uncritically is the characteristic weak-band move.
- **B:** Incorrect: The two works are dated 1874 and 1896 respectively, so the mid-twentieth-century framing is simply wrong.
- **C:** Incorrect: Draper's and White's books address the European and Christian material directly.
- **D:** Correct: Draper (1874) and White (1896) supply the historiography of the Conflict model, and its rejection by most historians of science is a mark-earning qualification rather than a digression.

Examiner trap 14: Narrating Galileo instead of using the typology is the single most common failure in this question.

MCQ 15. Supra-rational against irrational

Which formulation correctly distinguishes the supra-rational from the irrational?

- A. The supra-rational exceeds what proof establishes; the irrational contradicts coherence or decisive evidence.
- B. The supra-rational is a feeling; the irrational is a proposition that has been falsified by observation.
- C. The supra-rational applies to scripture; the irrational applies to unaided philosophical argument.
- D. The supra-rational is a weaker degree of the rational; the irrational is its complete absence.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Exceeding proof and contradicting reason are different relations, and this middle category is precisely what the 2023 fifteen-marker is buying.
- **B:** Incorrect: Reducing the supra-rational to feeling abandons the cognitive claim that makes it a third epistemic category.
- **C:** Incorrect: The distinction is about the relation of a claim to proof, not about the type of source it comes from.
- **D:** Incorrect: Treating it as a weaker rationality returns to the two-term scale the distinction exists to break.

Examiner trap 15: A two-column answer to the 2023 stem loses the question. The middle term is the answer.

MCQ 16. What separates natural from revealed theology

On the propositional model, the distinction between natural and revealed theology is fundamentally a distinction in:

- A. Religious importance, since revealed truths always matter more than natural ones.
- B. Emotional intensity, since revealed truths are received with greater fervour.
- C. Epistemic access, since the two differ in where their premises can be obtained.
- D. Historical period, since natural theology preceded revealed theology in time.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Importance is not the criterion; both theologies speak about God and both matter within the system.
- **B:** Incorrect: Intensity belongs to the phenomenology of religious experience, which the firewall assigns to another owner.
- **C:** Correct: Natural theology argues from publicly accessible premises, while revealed theology proceeds from premises the propositional model says could only be received through disclosure.
- **D:** Incorrect: No chronological priority is asserted; the distinction is systematic rather than developmental.

Examiner trap 16: Answering the 2025 stem with a two-column table that never mentions the propositional view drops the third printed term, which carries marks.

MCQ 17. Why circularity is not automatically fatal

Which statement best explains why the circularity objection to scriptural authority is not automatically fatal?

- A. Circularity is a formal fallacy only in mathematics, so it does not apply to theology.
- B. Divine authorship guarantees that the circle is closed in a way no critic can examine.
- C. Communities are entitled to accept their own founding documents without further inquiry.
- D. Many epistemic practices use reciprocal support; the issue is whether the circle is vicious.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Circularity is a defect wherever a conclusion is smuggled into its own support, and no discipline is exempt.
- **B:** Incorrect: Appealing to divine authorship to close the circle is precisely the move that makes the circle vicious.
- **C:** Incorrect: Entitlement without inquiry converts a defeasible warrant into insulated fideism.
- **D:** Correct: Reciprocal support is common in epistemology, so the live question is whether this circle is vicious or a coherent web, which turns on whether independent support enters it.

Examiner trap 17: State the criterion for viciousness - a circle that is the *only* support offered - or the reply looks like special pleading.

MCQ 18. The two-sided reading of the 2022 stem

Which reading of the 2022 stem, "Is the notion of faith indispensable for the idea of revelation?", earns the highest marks?

- A. Faith is dispensable, since a propositional revelation is true whether or not it is received.
- B. Faith is indispensable for reception and efficacy, though not for objective occurrence.
- C. Faith is indispensable in every sense, since without faith no disclosure can occur at all.
- D. The question is unanswerable, since revelation and faith are defined in terms of each other.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: This concedes only the objective half and ignores the point that unreceived content is not revelation *for* a person.
- **B:** Correct: The answer holds both halves: divinely communicated content would be true unreceived, yet an event becomes revelation for someone only through the faith that recognises and accepts it.
- **C:** Incorrect: Making faith a condition of the disclosure's occurrence overstates the case and invites the propositional counter-example.
- **D:** Incorrect: Mutual definition is not established, and declaring the stem unanswerable forfeits the directive's demand for a critical comment.

Examiner trap 18: "Critically comment" at ten marks wants one distinction, one objection and one verdict - not a survey of revelation theories.

MCQ 19. Why natural theology is the narrower field

Which of the following is the strongest reason for treating natural theology as narrower than philosophy of religion?

- A. Philosophy of religion also analyses religious language, experience and warrant.
- B. Natural theology alone employs deductive reasoning about the divine nature.
- C. Philosophy of religion is confined to describing the beliefs of existing communities.
- D. Natural theology is a modern discipline whereas philosophy of religion is ancient.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Natural theology argues toward theological conclusions, while philosophy of religion has the wider analytical field of language, experience and warrant and may reach negative conclusions.
- **B:** Incorrect: Both fields use deductive reasoning, so the difference cannot lie there.
- **C:** Incorrect: Confining philosophy of religion to description would make it sociology rather than philosophy.
- **D:** Incorrect: No such chronological claim is made in the controlling sources, and it would not establish the difference in scope.

Examiner trap 19: In the 2024 ten-marker the marks sit in reason's testing, interpreting and defending functions, not only in its constructive one.

MCQ 20. Alston's parity of doxastic practices

Alston's argument from doxastic practices is best summarised as which of the following?

- A. Religious experience yields the same degree of certainty as ordinary sense perception.
- B. No doxastic practice, sense perception included, can be validated non-circularly.
- C. Religious practice is rational only when independently confirmed by natural theology.
- D. Doxastic practices are rational only where a community has publicly agreed on them.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Parity of epistemic situation is claimed, not parity of certainty.
- **B:** Correct: Since we rationally engage in practices that cannot be non-circularly validated, socially established religious practice is in the same epistemic boat, and engaging in it is practically rational absent sufficient reason to think it unreliable.
- **C:** Incorrect: Requiring confirmation by natural theology reinstates precisely the evidentialist demand Alston is answering.
- **D:** Incorrect: Public agreement features as social establishment, but agreement is not the ground of rationality in the argument.

Examiner trap 20: Alston is the bridge to the religious-experience owner; use him for the parity argument, not for the phenomenology of experience.

MCQ 21. Ordering the permissions from strictest to loosest

Which sequence correctly orders permissions from strictest to loosest?

- A. Insulated fideism, then critical rationalism, then strict evidentialism, then Pascal's wager.
- B. Pascal's wager, then evidentialism, then insulated fideism, then critical rationalism.
- C. Critical rationalism, then insulated fideism, then Pascal's wager, then evidentialism.
- D. Evidentialism, then critical rationalism, then James's will-to-believe, then insulated fideism.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: This begins at the loosest position and ends in the middle, inverting the requested ordering.
- **B:** Incorrect: Prudential permission is looser than the evidentialist demand, so it cannot come first.
- **C:** Incorrect: Insulated fideism is the loosest position available and cannot sit second.
- **D:** Correct: The demand for sufficient evidence is strictest, critical rationalism permits commitment under continuing criticism, James permits it for a narrowly specified option, and insulated fideism permits it without any check.

Examiner trap 21: Kierkegaard does not belong at the loose end. His claim concerns who must decide, not how much evidence may be dispensed with.

MCQ 22. What Kierkegaard actually denies

Which claim about Kierkegaard is defensible on the controlling sources?

- A. He argues that a religious claim is more credible in proportion as it is absurd.
- B. He holds that objective argument is irrelevant to every question, religious or not.
- C. He denies that an objective system can replace the individual's existential decision.
- D. He treats Abraham as a general model for suspending ethical obligations at will.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: The "because it is absurd" slogan is not a verified quotation from Tertullian and is not Kierkegaard's thesis either.
- **B:** Incorrect: His argument is about religious appropriation, not a general scepticism about objective reasoning.
- **C:** Correct: Faith is passionate commitment under objective uncertainty, and his attack is on the claim that an objective philosophical system can substitute for existential decision.
- **D:** Incorrect: Abraham dramatises the paradox as a limit-case; reading him as a general licence is the caricature the owner warns against.

Examiner trap 22: Always pair the Kierkegaard exposition with the disclaimer that he licenses neither contradiction nor irresponsibility.

MCQ 23. The Indian treatment of the marvellous

Which contrast between Western and Indian treatments of the marvellous is accurate?

- A. Western apologetics authenticates revelation by miracles; Indian systems largely decline it.
- B. Indian systems rest scriptural authority on miracles; Western apologetics rests it on inference.
- C. Both traditions treat extraordinary powers as the decisive test of a genuine disclosure.
- D. Neither tradition records extraordinary powers, so no comparison can be constructed.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: *Yoga-sūtra* 3.37 declares the accomplishments obstacles, the *Kevaddha Sutta* has the Buddha refuse displays as a means of conversion, and Mīmāṃsā's authorless Veda needs no miraculous authentication at all.
- **B:** Incorrect: This inverts the position: Mīmāṃsā's doctrine exists precisely so that no miraculous authentication is required.
- **C:** Incorrect: Only the Western apologetic tradition gives the marvellous that evidential role.
- **D:** Incorrect: Both traditions record such powers; the difference lies in the evidential use made of them.

Examiner trap 23: Present this as a contrast, not a parallel. Claiming an Indian parallel here misdescribes both sides.

MCQ 24. What lifts a script into the top band

A top-band script on this clause is distinguished above the "strong" band chiefly by which addition?

- A. A longer list of thinkers, arranged in chronological order of their publications.
- B. A more detailed narrative of the historical episodes linking science and religion.
- C. A discriminating distinction plus a statement of what would change the stated verdict.
- D. A larger number of Sanskrit and Pali terms supplied without their English glosses.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Additional names without discrimination do not move a script past the strong band.
- **B:** Incorrect: Historical narrative is what the owner's traps warn against, particularly in the science stem.
- **C:** Correct: The top band requires a discriminating distinction, such as the faith which is believed against the faith by which one believes, together with a statement of what would change the verdict.
- **D:** Incorrect: Untranslated terminology violates the English-first rule and adds no analytical value.

Examiner trap 24: The defeater sentence is the cheapest top-band marker available and should be the last thing cut under time pressure.

REMEDIAL DIAGNOSTIC MCQS - 8

MCQ 25. Remedial - 'faith is belief without any evidence'

A candidate writes: "Faith is belief without any evidence." Which correction is best?

- A. Faith is an emotion with no cognitive content and therefore no relation to evidence.
- B. Faith is trustful commitment beyond conclusive proof and remains answerable to defeaters.
- C. Faith is demonstrative knowledge and is therefore epistemically stronger than reason.
- D. Faith is a weaker degree of belief, differing from it only in the confidence attached.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Denying cognitive content contradicts tenet two, which requires assent to some content.
- **B:** Correct: The error conflates non-demonstrative assent with groundlessness; faith may be rationally supported, supra-rational in commitment, and still open to defeat.
- **C:** Incorrect: Faith lacks the demonstrative vision that knowledge has, so it cannot be the stronger of the two in that sense.
- **D:** Incorrect: A difference in degree is exactly what the failure-mode test refutes, since betrayal is not a species of falsehood.

Examiner trap 25: This definition also destroys the second half of the 2020 stem, because it makes faith and belief indistinguishable except by confidence.

MCQ 26. Remedial - 'Aquinas lets faith contradict reason'

A candidate writes: "Aquinas allows faith to contradict reason where the mystery demands it." Which correction is best?

- A. Genuine reason and revelation cannot conflict; apparent clash signals a defect in reasoning.
- B. Every revealed mystery can in principle be demonstrated once the right premises are found.
- C. Reason becomes unnecessary once a scripture accepted as authoritative is available.
- D. Faith is entitled to accept a logical contradiction when the doctrine is sufficiently important.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Both routes issue from God, so an apparent clash indicates a defect in the reasoning or in the interpretation, never a true contradiction in reality.
- **B:** Incorrect: Demonstrable mysteries would be preambles, which would collapse the two-storey structure.
- **C:** Incorrect: Reason retains the preambles, the coherence test, interpretation and apologetics, so it does not become redundant.
- **D:** Incorrect: Accepting a contradiction is the irrational, not the supra-rational; the distinction is precisely what Aquinas needs.

Examiner trap 26: Write "above reason, never against reason". Those five words are worth more than a paragraph of paraphrase.

MCQ 27. Remedial - revelation, inspiration and infallibility

A candidate writes: "Revelation, inspiration and infallibility all mean the same thing." Which correction is best?

- A. All three describe the same event under different denominational vocabularies.
- B. Revelation is the record, inspiration is the disclosure, and infallibility is the community's assent.
- C. Revelation is the disclosure, inspiration the authorship of the record, infallibility freedom from error.
- D. Only infallibility is a genuine notion; the other two are pre-critical descriptions of it.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: The owner states explicitly that the three are not interchangeable, so denominational vocabulary is not the issue.
- **B:** Incorrect: This misassigns each term; the record is not revelation, and infallibility is not communal assent.
- **C:** Correct: Disclosure, authorship of the record and freedom from error are three separable notions that can come apart.
- **D:** Incorrect: Reducing the set to infallibility loses the very distinction the propositional model depends on.

Examiner trap 27: These three terms can come apart in practice, and noticing that is a cheap discriminator in a revelation question.

MCQ 28. Remedial - 'Hume proved miracles impossible'

A candidate writes: "Hume proved that miracles are impossible." Which correction is best?

- A. Hume held that only reports from educated witnesses can establish an extraordinary event.
- B. Hume argued that testimony normally cannot overcome the evidence for natural regularities.
- C. Hume denied that laws of nature have any evidential standing in questions of this kind.
- D. Hume treated the four Part II considerations as a proof of divine non-intervention.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Witness quality is one Part II consideration, not the whole argument, and Hume denies any actual case satisfies the full set.
- **B:** Correct: The conclusion concerns the evidential force of testimony, and Swinburne and Earman both contest the strength of that bar.
- **C:** Incorrect: The argument depends on laws of nature having the strongest evidential standing available.
- **D:** Incorrect: Part II offers considerations of evidential caution, not a proof about divine action.

Examiner trap 28: State what survives - Part II as a checklist of caution - and what does not - Part I, which would exclude testimony for any sufficiently improbable event.

MCQ 29. Remedial - 'Plantinga says God's existence is self-evident'

A candidate writes: "Plantinga says God's existence is self-evident." Which correction is best?

- A. Plantinga rejects every cognitive faculty other than sense perception as a source of belief.
- B. Plantinga argues that theistic belief must be inferred from the design argument to be rational.
- C. Plantinga holds that religious belief is immune to criticism once it has been formed.
- D. Plantinga holds that theistic belief can be properly basic - grounded, warranted and defeasible.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: His proper-function account depends on a wider range of faculties, including a sense of the divine.
- **B:** Incorrect: Proper basicity is defined by *not* being inferred from other beliefs, so inference from design is beside the point.
- **C:** Incorrect: He insists on defeasibility and names evil, projection and cognitive-science explanations as potential defeaters.
- **D:** Correct: The claim is proper basicity with grounding, warrant through proper function, and openness to defeat, not self-evidence.

Examiner trap 29: "Properly basic" means non-inferred, not obvious. Those are different claims and the examiner is checking which one you hold.

MCQ 30. Remedial - narrating Galileo for the science stem

A candidate answers the 2020 science stem with a narrative of the Galileo affair. Which correction is best?

- A. Replace it with a narrative of the nineteenth-century evolution controversies instead.
- B. Replace it with an account of contemporary scientific consensus on cosmology.
- C. Replace it with Barbour's four models, each with its cost, and a domain-sensitive verdict.
- D. Replace it with a defence of non-overlapping magisteria as the settled solution.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Substituting one narrative for another repeats the same structural error.
- **B:** Incorrect: A survey of scientific results does not answer a question about the relation between two domains.
- **C:** Correct: The stem asks for significance vis-à-vis scientific and technological development, which is a relation and therefore calls for a typology with costs and a verdict.
- **D:** Incorrect: Non-overlapping magisteria is one model among four and carries the cost of enforced mutual silence.

Examiner trap 30: Add the normative point: technology settles what we can do, not what we should do, and not what a life is for.

MCQ 31. Remedial - trust (*śraddhā*) read as blind faith

A candidate writes that Indian trust (*śraddhā*) is simply the Indian word for blind faith. Which correction is best?

- A. Trust (*śraddhā*) denotes ritual correctness and has no epistemic dimension whatever.
- B. Trust (*śraddhā*) is exactly identical to the faith by which one believes in the scholastic sense.
- C. Trust (*śraddhā*) is a purely emotional attachment to a teacher with no cognitive role.
- D. Trust (*śraddhā*) is graded and verification-directed: it enables inquiry rather than replacing it.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Denying it any epistemic dimension contradicts its pedagogic role in initiating inquiry.
- **B:** Incorrect: The scholastic pair is a useful comparison, but identity would erase the graded typology of the *Gītā*.
- **C:** Incorrect: Reducing it to emotion loses precisely the feature that makes the Indian comparison valuable.
- **D:** Correct: The *Gītā* 17.2-3 grades it and makes it constitutive of the person, Advaita treats it as the trust that makes inquiry possible and is replaced by realisation, and the *Kālāma Sutta* directs Buddhist trust toward testing in experience.

Examiner trap 31: The comparative advantage is that Indian trust *initiates* verification, whereas Western faith often has to defend itself as trust that replaces it.

MCQ 32. Remedial - closing with 'both are important'

A candidate concludes a twenty-mark answer with "thus both reason and faith are important". Which correction is best?

- A. Replace it with a graded verdict that decides and names the defeater that would change it.
- B. Replace it with a longer restatement of the four stances already covered in the body.
- C. Replace it with a quotation from Tertullian on believing because the doctrine is absurd.
- D. Replace it with a declaration that the question cannot be settled by philosophical means.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Every directive in this clause rewards a decision, and the top band additionally requires a statement of what would change the verdict.
- **B:** Incorrect: Restating the body adds length without adding evaluation, which is what the verdict is for.
- **C:** Incorrect: That slogan is not a verified Tertullian quotation and should be used only as a later fideist label.
- **D:** Incorrect: Declaring the question un settleable abandons the directive rather than answering it.

Examiner trap 32: "Both are important" is the single most reliable way to cap a script in the average band, however good the preceding material.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Verified previous-year questions - 11 complete solutions

Word bands used throughout. 10 marks ≈ 150 words · 15 marks ≈ 250 words · 20 marks ≈ 350 words. Every question below is reproduced in its exact printed wording from the audited Philosophy of Religion previous-year ledger, 2018-2025. **The model answers are independent learner practice and are never official UPSC keys.**

PYQ 1 - 2019, Q5(a), 10 marks

Exact verified question: What is instrumental to self-revelation: Faith or Reason? Justify your position.

Demand decoding: The directive is "justify your position" after an *either/or*. The examiner is buying a **choice**, defended - not "both matter". Choose, give the strongest case, then concede what the losing term explains better.

Model solution. Self-revelation is divine self-disclosure received by a subject. **Faith is the instrument of reception; reason is the instrument of regulation** - and reception is what the word *self-revelation* names.

Hick's non-propositional account settles the priority. An event is religiously ambiguous: the same occurrence bears a secular causal description and a providential one. What selects the religious reading is faith's "experiencing-as". Without that reception, the occurrence remains an occurrence and discloses no one. Kierkegaard makes the same point existentially: an objective system cannot be handed to a person in place of the appropriation only that person can perform.

Reason is nevertheless indispensable. It tests coherence, weighs testimony, disciplines interpretation and separates disclosure from delusion. In Advaita, trust (*śraddhā*) opens inquiry while reasoning (*manana*) removes doubt.

Objection: propositional content, if divinely communicated, is true whether or not it is received. **Reply:** conceded for the objective content - but unreceived content is not revelation *for* anyone.

Verdict: faith receives, reason disciplines. Faith is the more instrumental, though it is not self-validating.

Why this earns marks: it makes the required choice; it uses Hick, Kierkegaard and the Indian pair analytically rather than decoratively; it separates objective disclosure from subjective reception; and it closes with a directive-responsive verdict rather than a summary.

PYQ 2 - 2020, Q5(a), 10 marks

Exact verified question: Discuss the significance of 'Religion' vis-à-vis the present scientific and technological development.

Demand decoding: "Vis-à-vis" asks for a **relation**, and a relation is answered by a typology, never by a narrative. Do not tell the story of Galileo.

Model solution. The relation between religion and scientific-technological development is a set of models, not a single verdict. Barbour's fourfold typology supplies the map.

Conflict treats both as competing claims about one world, in the mirror-image forms of scientific materialism and scriptural literalism; its historiography is the Draper-White warfare thesis of 1874 and 1896, now rejected by most historians of science as a polemical construction. **Independence** - Gould's non-overlapping magisteria (*Rocks of Ages*, 1999) - assigns fact to science and ultimate meaning to religion, but buys peace by forbidding either side to say anything the other could contest. **Dialogue** engages boundary questions: why there is a universe, why it is intelligible, why the constants permit life. **Integration** attempts natural theology, theology of nature or process thought, and is hostage to current science.

Religion's continuing significance is normative and existential: technology settles what we *can* do, not what we *should* do, and not what a life is for. Vivekananda's claim that Vedānta is experience-grounded and so science-compatible belongs here - reported as a claim.

Verdict: dialogue at the boundary questions, with local conflict only where a religious claim is genuinely empirical.

Why this earns marks: all four models with their costs; the warfare-thesis and non-overlapping-magisteria qualifications; the normative argument instead of vague moralising; and a decided verdict.

PYQ 3 - 2020, Q7(c), 15 marks

Exact verified question: What are the basic tenets of faith? Distinguish between faith and belief.

Demand decoding: Two printed deliverables, in the printed order. Enumerate the tenets; then run the differentia. Answering only the second half forfeits roughly half the marks.

Model solution. Faith is a fiduciary and volitional relation to what is held ultimate; belief is propositional assent. Every faith carries beliefs; not every belief is faith.

The basic tenets are seven. (1) An **object** held ultimate. (2) **Assent** to some content - faith is never contentless feeling. (3) **Trust** exceeding the available evidence. (4) **Commitment** of the will, with consequent risk. (5) **Hope** oriented to a good not yet secured. (6) A **community** and tradition that transmits and disciplines it. (7) **Fruits** - a transformed pattern of life by which it is tested.

The distinction runs on six axes. *Object:* a proposition against a person or ultimate. *Grammar:* believing *that* against believing *in*. *Mode:* cognitive assent against assent plus entrusting. *Voluntariness:* belief is largely involuntary, whereas faith engages the will. *Failure-mode:* belief fails by falsehood, faith by betrayal. *Degrees:* confidence against fidelity.

Aquinas' pair supports this - the faith which is believed (*fides quae creditur*), and the faith by which one believes (*fides qua creditur*). Wilfred Cantwell Smith (*Faith and Belief*, 1979) shows "belief" narrowed to propositional assent only in modern usage; Tillich makes faith an ultimate concern, whose characteristic failure is idolatry rather than doubt; Buber's I-Thou cannot be reduced to I-It propositions. The *Gītā* 17.2-3 grades trust (*śraddhā*) and makes it constitutive of the person; Buddhist trust (Pali: *saddhā*) is verification-directed, as the *Kālāma Sutta* insists.

Objection: "believing in" reduces to believing that something exists and is trustworthy. **Reply:** one may believe a person reliable and still refuse to entrust anything; the entrusting is irreducible.

Verdict: faith is not a weaker belief but a different act, and the two come apart in both directions.

Why this earns marks: both printed deliverables in order; seven tenets and six axes; four named Western supports plus two Indian anchors; and the reductionist objection answered.

PYQ 4 - 2021, Q7(a), 20 marks

Exact verified question: Discuss the role of reason and faith in religion. Can reason be a regulative force in the formulation of religious beliefs? Explain.

Demand decoding: Two tasks again, the second carrying the discriminating term. "Regulative" must be defined against "constitutive"; the whole answer turns on that pair.

Model solution. Reason and faith are not rivals for one office. **Reason can and should regulate religious belief; it is not thereby constitutive of the belief's distinctive content.**

Reason's role is fourfold. It constructs **natural theology** - Aquinas' preambles, Nyāya's inference to God (Īśvara). It **tests coherence:** no appeal to mystery can make a contradiction true. It **interprets** scripture, distinguishing literal, analogical and historically conditioned senses. It **defends**, answering the objector. Its limit is that the proofs are inconclusive and the transcendent may *exceed* reason - exceed, not contradict.

Faith's role is different in kind. For Aquinas, faith is the intellect's firm assent to divine truth commanded by the will moved by grace: it has the firmness of knowledge without its vision, and stands as a mean between knowledge and opinion. Kierkegaard locates faith in passionate appropriation under objective uncertainty - his target is substitution, not evidence. The Augustinian-Anselmian *credo ut intelligam* mediates: faith begins the inquiry, understanding deepens it.

Now the printed question. *Regulative* reason constrains: it vetoes contradiction, weighs testimony, disciplines reading and identifies defeaters. *Constitutive* reason would generate the content itself. Regulation is negative and occasion-bound, constitution is productive, and the asymmetry is real: reason can rule out an incoherent doctrine of God without being able to produce the doctrine of the Trinity. Critical rationalism formalises the regulative seat - committed belief kept open to criticism - and Plantinga's insistence that properly basic belief remains **defeasible** shows even the anti-evidentialist accepting regulation.

Objection: a power of universal veto is sovereignty in disguise. **Reply:** a referee who can disallow a goal does not score it.

Verdict: reason is regulative but not constitutive. The regulation is genuine only while the veto can actually bite; a tradition that admits no possible defeater has abandoned regulation for insulated fideism, and that is the defeater which would change this verdict.

Why this earns marks: both tasks answered; the regulative/constitutive pair defined and then *used*; five named positions; and a closing statement of what would overturn the conclusion.

PYQ 5 - 2022, Q5(d), 10 marks

Exact verified question: Is the notion of faith indispensable for the idea of revelation? Critically comment.

Demand decoding: "Critically comment" at ten marks wants one distinction, one objection and one verdict - not a survey of revelation theories.

Model solution. Revelation is divine self-disclosure, and a disclosure must be *received* to function as one. On Hick's non-propositional model an event is religiously ambiguous; faith's "experiencing-as" perceives it as divine action, the community then conceptualises it, and doctrine follows. Without that reception the event is only an event, disclosing nothing to anyone.

The decisive move is a **distinction**: between the objective occurrence or content of a disclosure, and revelation *for* a person. **Objection:** on the propositional model, divinely communicated truths are true whether or not anyone accepts them, so faith cannot be indispensable. **Reply:** conceded at the level of content - but unreceived information is not revelation in anyone's religious life. Faith is the indispensable subjective condition of revelation's recognition and efficacy, not of its objective existence.

Verdict: faith is indispensable to revelation's reception, not to its occurrence - and holding both halves is what the word "critically" is buying.

Why this earns marks: one distinction, one objection, one verdict, exactly as the directive specifies; Hick used structurally; and the propositional counter-example conceded rather than ignored.

PYQ 6 - 2023, Q5(b), 10 marks

Exact verified question: Can religious beliefs be justified? Discuss.

Demand decoding: The question is about the **standard** of justification, not about whether God exists. Name the epistemology in the first sentence.

Model solution. The question asks what standard a religious belief must meet, not whether its object exists.

Evidentialism answers: proportion assent to the evidence. Locke ties assent to probability; Clifford's "The Ethics of Belief" (1877) makes it moral - it is wrong to believe anything upon insufficient evidence, as his shipowner does; Flew's presumption of atheism puts the burden on the affirmative claim. **James** (1896) replies that where an option is living, forced and momentous and evidence cannot decide, the passionate nature may lawfully choose - and that Clifford's rule itself expresses a preference for avoiding error over gaining truth.

Reformed epistemology goes further. Plantinga argues the objection presupposes classical foundationalism, which is self-referentially incoherent and cannot accommodate memory, other minds or the past; belief in God, formed in appropriate circumstances, can therefore be **properly basic** - grounded, warranted by properly functioning faculties, and **defeasible**. Alston adds that no doxastic practice, sense perception included, is non-circularly validated.

The Indian mapping is exact: Mīmāṃsā's intrinsic validity (*svataḥ-prāmāṇya*) parallels proper basicity; Nyāya's extrinsic validity (*parataḥ-prāmāṇya*) parallels evidentialism; Cārvāka is the strict limit.

Verdict: yes - but justification is internal to a doxastic practice, which relocates the real problem from evidential insufficiency to religious diversity.

Why this earns marks: the standard is named first; both camps are reconstructed with their strongest moves; the exact Indian analogues are used; and the verdict identifies the residual problem instead of restating the debate.

PYQ 7 - 2023, Q6(c), 15 marks

Exact verified question: Explain the rational and irrational aspects of faith in the discourse of religion.

Demand decoding: The stem prints two categories; the answer requires **three**. Insert the supra-rational, or the question cannot be answered without convicting religion by definition.

Model solution. Faith is standardly described as rational or irrational. The discourse in fact requires three categories, and the middle one is the answer.

The rational aspect. Faith has grounds. Aquinas' *preambles* - that God exists, and some divine attributes - are held to be demonstrable, and *motives of credibility* make assent reasonable though not coercive. Faith carries cognitive content, is internally testable for coherence, and can be supported cumulatively by testimony, moral fruit and experience. Reason interprets its texts and defends it against objections.

The supra-rational aspect. Faith assents to what is not seen. For Aquinas it has the firmness of knowledge without the vision, so it is neither opinion nor demonstration. For Kierkegaard, commitment occurs under objective uncertainty, and no system can be substituted for appropriation. This exceeds proof; it does not contradict it. Indian trust (*śraddhā*), graded in the *Gītā* 17.2-3, similarly opens an inquiry it does not pre-empt, and Buddhist trust (Pali: *saddhā*) is explicitly directed toward testing in experience.

The irrational aspect. Faith becomes irrational when it asserts a contradiction, defies decisive evidence, or claims immunity from every possible defeater. The later slogan about believing "because it is absurd" - not a verified Tertullian quotation - marks that extreme. Fideist immunity licenses fanaticism, which is why critical rationalism keeps committed belief answerable to criticism.

Objection: the supra-rational is a face-saving relabelling of the irrational. **Reply:** the two differ in their logical relation to proof - exceeding is not contradicting - and the difference is testable, because a supra-rational belief accepts defeaters while an irrational one does not.

Verdict: faith is rational in its grounds, supra-rational in its assent, and irrational only when it purchases security by refusing correction.

Why this earns marks: the three-term structure; Aquinas and Kierkegaard reconstructed rather than named; the quotation flagged as unsafe; and a testable criterion separating the middle term from the third.

PYQ 8 - 2024, Q5(d), 10 marks

Exact verified question: Discuss the role of reason in religion.

Demand decoding: A short, structured enumeration with a limit. The marks sit in the functions beyond proof.

Model solution. Reason's religious work is fourfold, and it is not exhausted by the attempt to prove God's existence.

First, reason **constructs natural theology**: it argues from publicly accessible premises toward theological conclusions, as in Aquinas' preambles of faith and Nyāya's inference to God (Īśvara). Natural theology is narrower than philosophy of religion, which additionally analyses language, experience and warrant.

Second, reason **tests coherence**. No appeal to mystery can make a contradiction true; a doctrine that cannot be stated without self-contradiction is not thereby profound.

Third, reason **interprets**. Scripture requires hermeneutics, and authority does not eliminate it: literal, analogical and historically conditioned senses have to be distinguished.

Fourth, reason **defends** - apologetics - and, correlatively, criticises: it identifies defeaters and checks fanaticism.

Its **limit** is that the proofs are inconclusive and the transcendent may exceed the reach of finite reason. Kant restricts speculative reason beyond possible experience; natural theologians reply that metaphysical inference concerns the conditions of experience rather than a further observed object.

Verdict: reason is best described as **regulative** - it constrains, tests and interprets - without being constitutive of the content that revelation claims to supply.

Why this earns marks: four functions with named illustrations, one genuine objection with its reply, and a verdict using the regulative/constitutive pair.

PYQ 9 - 2024, Q7(b), 15 marks

Exact verified question: What kind of epistemic justifications are possible with regard to claims to revelation? Discuss with your own comments.

Demand decoding: Two obligations: a **typology** of possible justifications, then a **first-person ranking**. The "own comments" clause is not decorative.

Model solution. A revelation-claim can be justified only by convergent and defeasible criteria. Six are available, and each carries a built-in limit.

Source and testimony: is the witness competent, sincere, suitably placed and independently supported? *Limit:* testimony transmits error as well as truth. **Coherence:** does the claim contradict itself or secure knowledge? *Limit:* a consistent fiction is still consistent, so coherence cannot establish divine origin. **Moral and spiritual fruit:** does reception produce truthfulness, compassion and transformation? *Limit:* useful effects can occur under false beliefs. **Tradition and community:** has the interpretation been publicly transmitted, criticised and corrected? *Limit:* communal endurance may preserve power or bias. **Experience and miracle-sign:** is there an event resistant to ordinary explanation and appropriately connected to the message? *Limit:* an unusual occurrence does not by itself authenticate one interpretation of it - Hume's Part II remains a standing checklist. **Cross-revelation comparison:** how does the claim answer rival disclosures? *Limit:* the criteria are rarely neutral between traditions.

Two structural problems cut across all six. **Circularity:** scripture authenticates God and God authorises scripture. That circle is vicious if it is the *only* support offered, and arguably virtuous if independent testimony, coherence and moral fruit enter it - many epistemic practices use reciprocal support. **Competing revelation:** rival scriptures cannot all be literally infallible in incompatible claims; distinguishing a core disclosure from historically conditioned interpretation answers this, but critics fairly call the move revisionary.

My own ranking. Coherence is necessary but weakest, because it is merely negative. Cross-revelation comparison is the most demanding and therefore the most informative. Moral fruit and communal transmission are jointly stronger than either alone. The miracle-sign is the least useful, since it presupposes the interpretive framework it is meant to establish.

Verdict: warrant here is convergent, graded and defeasible - never demonstrative - and the residual difficulty is diversity rather than evidential poverty.

Why this earns marks: a complete typology with limits, both structural problems handled, and an explicit personal ranking as the stem demands.

PYQ 10 - 2025, Q5(e), 10 marks

Exact verified question: How does Aquinas' account of Faith as "an intellectual assent" reconcile the juxtaposition between Reason and Faith? Discuss.

Demand decoding: "How does X reconcile A and B?" buys the **mechanism**, stated as a structure. Name the two storeys and the hinge.

Model solution. Aquinas reconciles reason and faith by architecture rather than compromise.

The act. Faith is an act of the *intellect* assenting to divine truth, commanded by the *will* moved by *grace* (*Summa Theologiae* II-II, qq. 1-4). Because revealed truth exceeds demonstrative sight, testimony supplies the object; because the evidence is non-coercive, the will commands assent; because the person must be oriented to divine truth, grace moves the will.

The location. Faith is a **mean**: it has the firmness of knowledge without knowledge's vision, and it lacks opinion's residual fear that the opposite is true. It borrows firmness from the one and unseenness from the other, and so is identical with neither.

The reconciliation. Reason establishes the **preambles** - that God exists. Revelation supplies the **mysteries** - for example the Trinity - which are *above* reason, never *against* it. Since both routes issue from God, they cannot genuinely conflict; an apparent conflict indicates defective reasoning or defective interpretation. The hinge is the *motives of credibility*, which make the assent reasonable though not demonstrative.

Objection: will-governed assent risks voluntarism. **Reply:** the will operates only where evidence is genuinely non-coercive, and the preambles plus the motives of credibility keep it from arbitrariness.

Verdict: the juxtaposition dissolves because reason and faith were never competing for the same office.

Why this earns marks: the mechanism is stated as a structure; the three-way location is used, not merely mentioned; and voluntarism - the standing objection - is answered.

PYQ 11 - 2025, Q6(c), 15 marks

Exact verified question: Distinguish between Natural Theology and Revealed Theology in the context of the Propositional view of Revelation.

Demand decoding: A **three-term** answer. "In the context of the propositional view" is a working constraint, not decoration: the propositional model is what makes the pair clean.

Model solution. On the propositional model, revelation communicates divinely authorised **truths** that unaided reason could not discover or securely know. That model is the frame within which the two theologies separate.

Natural theology argues from publicly accessible premises toward theological conclusions. Its content is what reason alone can reach - paradigmatically that God exists, and some divine attributes. Aquinas calls these the *preambles of faith*. Nyāya's inference to God (Īśvara) is a non-Western instance of the same enterprise. Natural theology is narrower than philosophy of religion, which also analyses religious language, experience and warrant.

Revealed theology proceeds from premises taken to be delivered. On the propositional view its content is the **mysteries** - the Trinity, the Incarnation - articulated as doctrine from a disclosure mediated by prophets, scripture or tradition, and warranted by signs, testimony and coherence.

The distinction is one of epistemic access, not of importance or of rationality. Both speak about God; both reason; they differ in where the premises originate. Three further terms must not be merged: revelation is the disclosure, **inspiration** concerns the divine-human authorship of the record, and **infallibility** concerns freedom from error.

Two controls. First, the distinction is stable only under the propositional model: on Hick's non-propositional account, doctrine is the community's interpretation of an encounter, so the boundary blurs. Second, Mīmāṃsā complicates the Western picture productively - its authorless (*apauruṣeya*) Veda supplies scriptural authority with **no** revealer at all, showing that propositional scriptural authority and divine dictation are separable.

Objection: rival revelations and circular authentication weaken revealed theology's claim. **Reply:** its defenders appeal to cumulative criteria - coherence, moral fruit, testimony and transformative power - without pretending these are tradition-neutral.

Verdict: natural and revealed theology are two routes to one subject matter, distinguished by access; the propositional frame is what keeps them distinct, and abandoning that frame dissolves the distinction rather than refuting it.

Why this earns marks: all three printed terms are used; the access criterion is stated explicitly; the revelation/inspiration/infallibility trio is separated; and the Indian material does argumentative work.

Original solved Mains practice - 6 models

These are **original** questions written for practice; they are not previous-year questions. Word bands are as declared above.

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question. Can reason authenticate a revelation-claim without circularity? Comment.

Model answer. Authentication asks why *this* alleged disclosure should be credited. The circularity charge is that scripture authenticates God while God authorises scripture, so the support never leaves the circle.

Reason can break the closure by importing independent lines. Coherence testing is external to the claim's own authority; testimony can be assessed for competence, sincerity, placement and corroboration; moral and spiritual fruit is observable independently of the doctrine; and comparison with rival disclosures is a test the tradition does not set for itself. Each is defeasible, and none establishes divine origin on its own.

The honest position is therefore a criterion for viciousness: a circle is vicious when it is the *only* support offered, and tolerable when independent evidence enters it. Many epistemic practices - including sense perception, as Alston notes - use reciprocal support without being dismissed.

Verdict: reason cannot authenticate a revelation-claim demonstratively, but it can convert a closed circle into a defeasible web. What would change this verdict is a tradition that refuses every external test.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question. "Faith that admits no possible defeater has purchased safety at the price of philosophical standing." Examine.

Model answer. The statement identifies the cost of insulation. A belief immune to every possible consideration cannot be assessed, compared or corrected; it has left the epistemic conversation to avoid losing an argument within it.

The claim is supported from both directions. Plantinga, the strongest defender of non-inferential religious belief, insists that properly basic theistic belief is **defeasible** - evil, projection theories and cognitive-science explanations are defeaters that must be met. Critical rationalism makes the same concession the price of committed belief. Aquinas retains the coherence test and the motives of credibility, so even his supra-rational assent is answerable.

Against the statement, it may be urged that some commitments are constitutive of a form of life and cannot be tested from outside without distortion.

Verdict: the statement is sound as stated. Faith may exceed proof without forfeiting standing; it forfeits standing when it claims exemption. The defeater would be a demonstration that no belief whatever is assessable from outside its own practice - a scepticism that would take sense perception with it.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question. Assess the claim that Indian epistemology supplies a genuine alternative, rather than a parallel, to Western accounts of revelation.

Model answer. The claim is partly true, and the parts must be separated.

Where India supplies a genuine alternative. Mīmāṃsā holds the Veda to be **authorless** (*apauruṣeya*). Scriptural authority therefore exists with no author, human or divine. That is not a variant of the Western model; it removes the revealer whose credibility the Western debate is organised around, and with it the need for miraculous authentication. Correspondingly, the Indian tradition largely **declines** the miracle strategy: *Yoga-sūtra* 3.37 treats the accomplishments (*siddhi*) as obstacles to absorption, and the *Kevaddha Sutta* has the Buddha refuse displays of psychic power as a means of conversion. This is a contrast, not a parallel.

Where India supplies an exact parallel. The validity dispute maps precisely: Mīmāṃsā's intrinsic validity (*svataḥ-prāmāṇya*) - a cognition is valid until defeated - parallels proper basicity; Nyāya's extrinsic validity (*parataḥ-prāmāṇya*) parallels evidentialism; Cārvāka is the strict evidentialist limit.

Where the difference is one of emphasis. Trust (*śraddhā*) is verification-directed: it initiates inquiry and is replaced by realisation, whereas Western faith often defends itself as trust that substitutes for verification. The Advaita route - hearing (*śravaṇa*), reasoning (*manana*), assimilation (*nididhyāsana*) - makes reasoning auxiliary but indispensable.

Objection: the mappings distort, since proper basicity carries a design-plan theory and intrinsic validity belongs to a ritual hermeneutics. **Reply:** the parallel is claimed at the level of warrant-structure only.

Verdict: on the source of scriptural authority India is a genuine alternative; on the structure of validity it is an exact parallel. Conflating the two is what makes comparative answers look decorative.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question. "The evidentialist objection to religious belief is self-defeating." Critically discuss.

Model answer. The charge is that the evidentialist criterion cannot satisfy itself.

The argument. Clifford requires sufficient evidence for every belief; Flew adds the presumption of atheism, making non-belief the rational default. Plantinga replies that the objection presupposes **classical foundationalism** - a belief is rational only if self-evident, incorrigible, evident to the senses, or inferred from such beliefs. That criterion is (i) **self-referentially incoherent**, since it is itself none of those things and is not derivable from them; and (ii) **too narrow**, since memory beliefs, beliefs in other minds and beliefs about the past are plainly rational without meeting it. If basicity is not confined to the classical list, theistic belief formed in appropriate circumstances may be properly basic.

How far the charge succeeds. It succeeds against *classical* foundationalism. It does not defeat every evidentialism: a more modest version - proportion your confidence to your total evidence, whatever counts as evidence - does not obviously self-destruct, and James's own reply is confined to living, forced and momentous options.

The residue. The Great Pumpkin objection presses that anything could then be basic. Plantinga answers with grounding, defeasibility and disciplined practice; critics note this makes the criterion community-relative and readmits well-established rival traditions.

Verdict: the self-defeat charge is decisive against the strict criterion and inconclusive against evidentialism as such. Its real achievement is to shift the burden - the evidentialist must now state a standard that religion fails and memory passes. The defeater would be exactly such a standard, stated and defended.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question. "Reason may audit revelation, but it cannot author it." Critically examine this claim with reference to both Western and Indian positions.

Model answer. The claim asserts an asymmetry between two powers: assessment and production. It is defensible, and its defence is the strongest general account of this clause.

The audit. Reason performs four religious functions - constructing natural theology, testing coherence, interpreting text, and defending or criticising. To these must be added the fifth, **regulation**: vetoing contradiction, weighing testimony, disciplining reading and naming defeaters. Regulation is negative and occasion-bound. Construction of religious *content*, by contrast, would be constitutive.

The Western settlement. Aquinas embodies the asymmetry. Reason establishes the preambles; revelation supplies the mysteries, which are above reason and never against it; and since both routes issue from God, an apparent conflict signals defective reasoning or interpretation. Faith is the intellect's firm assent, commanded by the will under grace, with the motives of credibility as the hinge that keeps it from voluntarism. Kierkegaard attacks a different target - the substitution of a system for appropriation - and so does not contradict the asymmetry; he presses it. Hick radicalises it: an event is religiously ambiguous, and faith's "experiencing-as" supplies the religious reading that reason cannot generate.

The Indian settlement. Advaita gives the asymmetry a pedagogy: scripture (*śruti*) discloses, reasoning (*manana*) removes doubt, and dialectical reasoning (*tarka*) is auxiliary and never independently probative. Mīmāṃsā radicalises the authority side, holding the Veda authorless and so requiring no revealer and no miraculous authentication; reason

interprets injunction but does not produce it. Nyāya, by contrast, treats the word of a reliable authority (*āpta-vākya*) as a means of knowledge whose credibility must be established, and its extrinsic validity (*parataḥ-prāmāṇya*) is the closest classical analogue of evidentialism.

Objections. First, a power of universal veto amounts to sovereignty. *Reply:* a referee who disallows a goal has not scored it; refusing and generating are different acts. Second, if reason interprets, it partly constitutes the content it claims only to audit. *Reply:* this is the strongest objection, and the honest concession is that interpretation is a *shared* function, which is why hermeneutics is contested territory rather than reason's private domain. Third, the circle: scripture authenticates the authority that authenticates scripture. *Reply:* the circle is vicious only where it is the sole support, and independent testimony, coherence, moral fruit and cross-tradition comparison break the closure.

Verdict. Reason audits and does not author - but the boundary is porous exactly at interpretation, and that is where the interesting disputes in both traditions actually occur. The claim would be defeated by a demonstration that no religious content survives once interpretation is subtracted; nothing in either tradition currently supplies that demonstration.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question. Evaluate the view that the problem of religious diversity, rather than the problem of evidence, is the decisive obstacle to justified religious belief.

Model answer. The view proposes a reordering of the standard objections. It is largely correct, but only after the evidential objection has been properly answered.

Stage one: the evidential objection and its answer. Evidentialism demands that assent be proportioned to evidence - Locke on probability, Clifford's moral maxim of 1877, Flew's presumption of atheism. James restricts the demand: for a living, forced and momentous option where evidence cannot decide, the passional nature may lawfully choose, and Clifford's rule itself encodes a preference for avoiding error over gaining truth. Plantinga goes further: the objection presupposes classical foundationalism, which is self-referentially incoherent and cannot accommodate memory, other minds or beliefs about the past; belief in God formed in the right circumstances may be properly basic, grounded, warranted by proper function and defeasible. Alston adds that no doxastic practice, sense perception included, is non-circularly validated.

Stage two: what the answer costs. Each of these replies relocates justification *inside* a practice. Warrant now depends on faculties functioning properly in an appropriate environment, or on participation in a socially established practice. That is a real defence, but it is available to any sufficiently mature tradition.

Stage three: why diversity becomes decisive. The Great Pumpkin objection is answered by grounding and defeasibility; the "Son of Great Pumpkin" version is not, because well-established rival traditions do have grounding, discipline and internal defeater-management. In revelation-authentication the same pattern appears: the six criteria - testimony, coherence, moral fruit, tradition, sign, comparison - are all defeasible and, critically, **none is neutral between traditions**. Rival scriptures cannot all be literally infallible in incompatible claims; distinguishing core disclosure from historically conditioned interpretation answers this, but the move is revisionary by the tradition's own standards.

Indian control. The Indian bench shows the difficulty is structural rather than parochial. Intrinsic validity (*svataḥ-prāmāṇya*) grants a cognition validity until defeated - which is exactly what a rival tradition also claims for its own. The authorless (*apauruṣeya*) Veda removes the revealer, and so removes one comparative test without supplying another.

Objection. Diversity is a defeater to be answered, not an automatic refutation; and a tradition may hold that its own account explains the others. **Reply.** True, and no one holds diversity is easily answered. But an explanation of rivals offered from inside a practice is precisely what a rival can also offer.

Verdict. The view is correct in its ordering. Once justification is located inside a doxastic practice, evidential insufficiency ceases to be the live problem and incompatible practices take its place. The defeater would be a tradition-neutral criterion that discriminates among mature practices; the absence of such a criterion, rather than any shortage of evidence, is what makes diversity decisive.

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

[FACT] Status. Everything below is second-order enrichment drawn from the Philosophy of Religion Advanced Dossier, Section 5. **No core answer depends on any of it.** The dossier's own instruction is to finish the owner file first, then add *one* advanced move to a 15-marker or *one to two* to a 20-marker, and to use advanced material to sharpen evaluation rather than to replace syllabus exposition. **[FACT] Already promoted, therefore taught in the Basic block above and not repeated here as "advanced":** the Reformed-epistemology-versus-evidentialism dispute, including proper basicity and defeaters, fired its promotion trigger on 15 August 2026 and now lives in Core (Session 11). What remains optional from that module is only the residue named below.

A1 - Public testimony against private revelation

	Position 1	Position 2
Emphasis	communal testimony, history and credibility signs	first-person disclosure received through interpretive faith
Strength	publicly assessable; supports comparison across traditions	explains why an event discloses to one person and not another
Weakness	credibility signs are contestable and rarely tradition-neutral	risks collapsing revelation into private psychology

Objection. Competing revelations cancel one another, so neither route delivers warrant. **Reply.** **[FACT]** Warrant is defeasible and cumulative rather than apodictic; rival claims force **comparative assessment**, not immediate collapse. **Safe use.** **[FACT]** One evaluative sentence inside a revelation-justification question. Do not build an answer on it.

A2 - Doxastic voluntarism against involuntarism

	Voluntarism	Involuntarism
Claim	the will has a genuine role in the formation of faith	belief cannot be adopted at will
Textual anchor	Aquinas: the intellect assents at the command of the will	the ordinary observation that one cannot decide to believe it is raining

Objection. One simply cannot decide to believe something. **Reply.** **[FACT]** Traditions usually mean **indirect** control - through attention, trust, practices and consent to inquiry - not instantaneous arbitrary choice. **Safe use.** **[FACT]** Useful alongside Aquinas on will and intellect, but keep it subordinate to the owner's Thomist frame; it is a refinement of the voluntarism objection already answered in Session 8, not a new position.

A3 - Creator-centred revelation against the Indian word (śabda)

[FACT] Abrahamic models tie revelation to divine self-disclosure. Mīmāṃsā and Advaita give scriptural testimony authority without making it creator-speech in the same way. **Objection.** Non-personal or authorless scripture lacks revelatory force. **Reply.** **[FACT]** The Indian schools distinguish supersensible disclosure from divine dictation, and require internal verification through reasoning and practice. **Safe use.** **[FACT]** Helpful for Indian balance where an answer would otherwise remain entirely Western. Session 14 already carries the core version of this comparison; the *advanced* residue is the further question - recorded in the dossier as still awaiting promotion - of whether authorlessness (*apauruṣeya*) counts as **revelation in its own right** or as a different species of authority altogether.

A4 - Residue of the warrant machinery

[FACT] The dossier records that, after the promotion of proper basicity to Core, the optional residue consists of (i) the **full warrant and proper-function machinery** - design plan, appropriate environment, degrees of warrant - and (ii) the question whether the **Great Pumpkin objection is genuinely answered or merely deflected**.

[INFERENCE] How to use (ii) in a script. State that the reply distinguishes basicity from arbitrariness by grounding, defeasibility and disciplined practice; then note that the criterion becomes community-relative, which is why the objection returns in its "Son of Great Pumpkin" form for mature rival traditions. One sentence, placed in the evaluation, not in the exposition.

A5 - Specialist testimony theory

[FACT] The dossier lists **specialist testimony theory** as still awaiting a promotion trigger. It has not fired, so it must not be presented as core doctrine.

What not to over-study

ANALYSIS: [FACT] Do not import the entire analytic epistemology of warrant, basicity or testimony into a short UPSC answer. The dossier states this explicitly, and the marginal return in a 10-marker is negative: the space is better spent on the middle terms and the Indian analogues.

Advanced source trail

[FACT] Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae* II-II on faith · Kierkegaard, *Fear and Trembling* and *Concluding Unscientific Postscript* · Hick on revelation and experiencing-as · Plantinga, *Warranted Christian Belief* · Mīmāṃsā discussions of the word (*śabda*) and authorlessness (*apauruṣeya*) · the Advaita pedagogic triad of hearing, reasoning and assimilation (*śravaṇa-manana-nididhyāsana*).

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

Compressed revision cards. They do not repeat the teaching introductions above; they carry definitions, exact data, distinctions, objections, traps, previous-year routes and answer spines in recall order.

1. The three offices, and the price of using one alone

- **Reason** argues · **revelation** discloses · **faith** trusts. Three *jobs*, not three rivals for one job.
- Solo failure modes: reason alone -> reductionism · revelation alone -> unauthenticated authority · faith alone -> arbitrariness or fanaticism.
- Master formula: **reason regulates; revelation discloses; faith receives**.
- Reason's jurisdiction includes probabilistic, abductive, critical and hermeneutic work - not deduction alone.

2. Reason's five functions and its one limit

1. Construct **natural theology** - Aquinas' preambles; Nyāya's inference to God (Īśvara).
 2. **Test coherence** - no appeal to mystery makes a contradiction true.
 3. **Interpret** - literal, analogical, historically conditioned senses.
 4. **Defend** - apologetics, and correlatively criticise.
 5. **Regulate** - veto, discipline, name defeaters. This is the function the 2021 stem turns on.
- **Limit:** the proofs are inconclusive and the transcendent may **exceed** reason. *Exceed*, never *contradict*.
 - Natural theology ≠ philosophy of religion; the latter also analyses language, experience and warrant.
 - Kant's restriction of speculative reason -> reply: metaphysical inference concerns the *conditions* of experience, not a further observed object.

3. The two middle terms that win this clause

False binary	Middle term	Content
constitutive vs irrelevant reason	regulative	veto, weighs, disciplines, names defeaters; does not author content
rational vs irrational faith	supra-rational	exceeds proof; does not contradict it

- Price of the middle seat in both cases: **defeasibility**. A belief no consideration could count against has left the conversation.
- Critical rationalism = committed belief kept open to criticism and defeaters.

4. Revelation on two independent axes

- **Scope and medium:** general (nature, conscience, universal history) versus special (event, person, scripture, community).
- **What revelation is:** propositional (truths communicated) versus non-propositional (divine acts, self-presence).
- These cross; they are not one ladder. Collapsing them makes the 2025 fifteen-marker unanswerable.
- **Not synonyms:** revelation = the disclosure · inspiration = divine-human authorship of the record · infallibility = freedom from error.

5. Propositional model - argument, presupposition, exemplars

- Revelation communicates divinely authorised truths unaided reason could not discover or securely know; these ground **revealed theology** (Trinity, Incarnation), as distinct from **natural theology** (that God exists).
- Argument: (1) God can disclose -> (2) prophets and scripture mediate -> (3) signs, testimony and coherence warrant reception -> (4) doctrine articulates content.
- Presupposition: a personal God acts in history; reliable transmission is possible.
- Indian complication: the authorless (*apauruṣeya*) Veda is authoritative **without** a creator's speech - scriptural authority with no revealer.
- Distinction to write: natural versus revealed theology is a difference of **epistemic access**, not of importance.

6. Non-propositional model - Hick

- Revelation is divine self-disclosure in events and encounter; propositions are human interpretations.
- Chain: ambiguous event -> faith's **experiencing-as** -> communal conceptualisation -> doctrine; doctrinal diversity reflects interpretive schemes.
- Presupposition: experience is concept-laden; divine freedom is not exhausted by statements.
- "Revelatory event" names an *experienced-as* structure, not a surface property.
- Objection: **projection**. Reply: moral-spiritual transformation, and the resistance of reality to arbitrary interpretation. Neither is decisive.
- 2022 verdict: faith is indispensable to **reception and efficacy**, not to objective occurrence.

7. The six authentication tests, each with its limit

Test	Limit
source and testimony	transmits error as well as truth
coherence	does not establish divine origin
moral-spiritual fruit	useful effects occur under false beliefs
tradition and community	endurance may preserve power or bias
experience and miracle-sign	an anomaly does not authenticate one interpretation
cross-revelation comparison	criteria are rarely tradition-neutral

- **Circularity:** scripture <-> God. Vicious if it is the *only* support; arguably virtuous once independent testimony, coherence and fruit enter. Many practices use reciprocal support.
- **Competing revelation:** rival scriptures cannot all be literally infallible in incompatible claims. Reply - separate core disclosure from historically conditioned interpretation; critics call this revisionary.
- 2024 verdict formula: warrant is a **convergence**, no member decisive, none neutral.

8. Faith - the seven tenets

(1) ultimate object · (2) assent to content · (3) trust exceeding evidence · (4) commitment of will, with risk · (5) hope · (6) community and tradition · (7) fruits.

- Steps 1-2 are shared with belief; step 3 is the departure; steps 4-7 belief alone never supplies.

9. Faith versus belief - six axes and the named supports

Axis	Belief	Faith
object	proposition	person / ultimate
grammar	believe <i>that</i>	believe <i>in</i> / trust
mode	cognitive assent	assent plus entrusting
voluntariness	largely involuntary	engages the will; can be <i>given</i>
failure-mode	falsehood	betrayal, infidelity, apostasy
degrees	confidence	fidelity and depth

- Supports: Aquinas' *fides quae creditur* (content) / *fides qua creditur* (act) · W. C. Smith, *Faith and Belief* (1979) on the modern narrowing of "belief" · Tillich's **ultimate concern**, whose failure is idolatry not doubt · Buber's **I-Thou** irreducible to I-It.
- Indian: *Gītā* 17.2-3 grades trust (*śraddhā*) as *sāttvika* / *rājasa* / *tāmāsa* - "as is one's *śraddhā*, so is one"; Advaita makes it the trust that enables inquiry, replaced by realisation; Buddhist trust (Pali: *saddhā*) is verification-directed - *Kālāma Sutta*, AN 3.65.
- Reductionist objection and reply: believing a person reliable ≠ entrusting anything to them.
- Verdict line: **faith is not a weaker belief; it is a different act.**

10. Aquinas - the answer spine

1. Faith is an act of the **intellect**.
 2. It assents to **divine truth**.
 3. The **will** commands the assent; **grace** moves the will.
 4. It is a **mean**: firmness of knowledge, without knowledge's vision; unlike opinion, no fear of the opposite.
 5. Reason proves the **preambles**; revelation supplies the **mysteries** - *above* reason, never *against* it.
 6. Both routes issue from God, so apparent conflict = defective reasoning or interpretation.
- Hinge against voluntarism: **motives of credibility**. Source: *Summa Theologiae* II-II qq. 1-4. Paraphrase; never fabricate an English quotation.

11. Kierkegaard and the permission ladder

- Faith = passionate commitment under **objective uncertainty**; Abraham dramatises the paradox and the teleological suspension of the ethical; the target is the **substitution** of a system for appropriation.
- ANALYSIS: He licenses neither contradiction nor irresponsibility nor evidence-free belief in general.
- Ladder, strictest -> loosest: Clifford's evidentialism · critical rationalism · James's will-to-believe (living, forced, momentous; evidence genuinely inconclusive) · Pascal's wager (prudential only; many-gods and authenticity objections) · insulated fideism.
- Supra-rational ≠ irrational. The "because it is absurd" slogan is CAUTION: not verified Tertullian wording - call it a later fideist slogan.

12. The bench - positions and their characteristic risk

Position	Risk it runs
rationalism / evidentialism (Locke, Clifford, Flew)	reduction of commitment; over-strict criterion; self-application
Aquinas	two-tier tension
fideism	arbitrariness
Hick	projection
Mīmāṃsā	cross-tradition warrant
Advaita	scriptural circularity
Reformed epistemology (Plantinga)	religious diversity as a defeater
Alston	circularity shared with sense perception
Barbour's typology	descriptive, not normative

- Four recurring criticisms: evidential challenge · competing revelation · circularity · fideist immunity - each with its standard reply.
- Method: pick the two rows the stem forces into contact, plus one Indian row as a check. Never narrate all of them.

13. Evidentialism against Reformed epistemology

- **Evidentialism:** Locke (proportion to probability) · Clifford, "The Ethics of Belief" (1877), the shipowner · Flew's **presumption of atheism** (burden on the affirmative; default is not-believing).
- **James** (*The Will to Believe*, 1896): living, forced, momentous option + genuinely inconclusive evidence -> the passional nature may decide; Clifford's rule itself prefers avoiding error to gaining truth.
- **Plantinga** (1983; *Warranted Christian Belief*, 2000): (1) the objection presupposes **classical foundationalism** -> (2) which is **self-referentially incoherent** -> (3) and too narrow (memory, other minds, the past) -> (4) so basicity is not confined to that list -> (5) theistic belief formed in appropriate circumstances is **properly basic** - grounded, not inferred.
- **Warrant** = true belief produced by faculties **functioning properly**, in an **appropriate environment**, on a **design plan aimed at truth**; the sense of the divine (*sensus divinitatis*) supplies it without argument. Structural payoff: **if** theism is true, theistic belief is very likely warranted -> no viable *de jure* objection independent of the *de facto* question.
- **Great Pumpkin** -> reply: grounding, defeasibility, disciplined practice -> counter: community-relative, so "Son of Great Pumpkin" returns for mature rivals.
- **Alston**, *Perceiving God* (1991): no doxastic practice, sense perception included, is non-circularly validated.
- **Indian analogues (exact):** intrinsic validity (*svataḥ-prāmāṇya*) ≈ proper basicity · extrinsic validity (*parataḥ-prāmāṇya*) ≈ evidentialism · Cārvāka = strict limit.
- Verdict: justification is internal to a doxastic practice -> the live problem becomes **incompatible practices**, not insufficient evidence.

14. Miracles, and the science-religion models

Hume, *Enquiry*, Section X (1748) - miracle defined as *a violation of the laws of nature* by a particular divine volition.

- **Part I:** proportion belief to evidence -> laws rest on uniform experience -> testimony rests on non-uniform experience -> the weaker yields -> **maxim:** no testimony suffices unless its falsehood would be *more miraculous* than the fact, and then subtract the lesser marvel from the greater.
- **Part II, four considerations:** (a) never enough witnesses of unquestioned sense, education, integrity and reputation with much to lose · (b) the standing **passion for surprise and wonder** · (c) provenance among ignorant and barbarous nations · (d) **contrary miracles cancel**.
- **Replies:** definitional - Swinburne's **non-repeatable counter-instance** · evidential - principles of **credulity** and **testimony** · Bayesian - Earman, *Hume's Abject Failure* (2000), prior confused with posterior · circularity · C. S.

Lewis and others · contrary-miracles.

- **Survives:** Part II as a checklist of caution. **Too strong:** Part I, which would exclude testimony for any sufficiently improbable event.
- **Indian contrast (not parallel):** *Yoga-sūtra* 3.37 makes the accomplishments (*siddhi* / *vibhūti*) obstacles to absorption · *Kevaddha Sutta* (DN 11): the Buddha refuses displays, preferring the "miracle of instruction" · Mīmāṃsā's authorless Veda needs no miraculous authentication.

Barbour (*Religion and Science*, 1997; *When Science Meets Religion*, 2000) - four models and their costs:

- **Conflict** - scientific materialism / scriptural literalism; historiography = Draper (1874) and White (1896) "warfare thesis", ANALYSIS: now rejected by most historians of science.
- **Independence** - Gould's non-overlapping magisteria, *Rocks of Ages* (1999); cost: mutual silence on contestable claims.
- **Dialogue** - boundary questions (why a universe, why intelligible, why life-permitting constants) and methodological parallels; cost: non-committal.
- **Integration** - natural theology, theology of nature, process thought; cost: hostage to current science.
- Alternative frame: **Haught** - Conflict / Contrast / Contact / **Confirmation**.
- Indian: Vivekananda's "science of the soul" (report as a **claim**) · Radhakrishnan's levels of one integral experience · Aurobindo's evolutionary integration · classical root: is the word (*śabda*) an independent means of knowledge? Cārvāka no; Nyāya and Mīmāṃsā yes.
- Normative point: technology settles what we *can* do, not what we *should* do, and not what a life is for.
- Verdict: dialogue at the boundary questions, local conflict only where a religious claim is genuinely empirical.

15. The eleven previous-year routes, and the answer discipline

Year	Part	Marks	Route in one line
2019	Q5(a)	10	choose faith for reception, reason for regulation
2020	Q5(a)	10	Barbour's four models with costs, then the normative point
2020	Q7(c)	15	seven tenets, then the six axes
2021	Q7(a)	20	reason's four functions, faith's role, then regulative ≠ constitutive
2022	Q5(d)	10	objective disclosure versus subjective reception
2023	Q5(b)	10	name the standard: evidentialism versus proper basicity
2023	Q6(c)	15	rational / supra-rational / irrational
2024	Q5(d)	10	four functions plus the limit, verdict in regulative terms
2024	Q7(b)	15	six criteria with limits, then rank them yourself
2025	Q5(e)	10	intellect, will, grace; preambles, mysteries, motives of credibility
2025	Q6(c)	15	natural versus revealed theology <i>inside</i> the propositional model

Corpus signal. Eleven primary-owned parts out of 112 across the audited 2018-2025 Paper II corpus; 2018 has no owned part.

Answer skeletons. 10 marks: define the term asked -> internal relation -> one distinction -> one objection -> direct verdict. 15 marks: frame the warrant problem -> the model in steps -> criteria -> rival model or Indian comparison -> objection and reply. 20 marks: map the three concepts -> strongest harmony and conflict models -> presuppositions -> competing-revelation and evidential objections -> Indian-Western comparison -> defended synthesis.

Six-step discipline. (1) define the disputed term · (2) say whether the issue is source, reception, warrant or commitment · (3) reconstruct one named position · (4) add the strongest objection and its reply · (5) use one exact Indian comparison · (6) end with a graded verdict and the **defeater** that would change it - never "both are important".

Final judgement. Rational religion is neither proof without trust nor trust without criticism. Faith may go beyond coercive proof; it forfeits philosophical standing when it claims a right to go against reason, or a right to be exempt from correction.

COMPLETE TOPIC ASCII MASTER FLOW DIAGRAM

This is the terminal-friendly, data-complete master flow. It is authored separately from the graphical package and is validated against the same Basic owner, Advanced dossier and previous-year ledger.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 1/20: The one question and the three offices

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 1/20: The one question and the three offices

SYLLABUS CLAUSE (verbatim): "Reason, Revelation and Faith."

CENTRAL QUESTION: on what may a religious belief rest, and who audits the answer?

+-----+-----+-----+		
REASON -> ARGUES	REVELATION -> DISCLOSES	FAITH -> TRUSTS
infer / test /	general or special;	assent / trust /
interpret / regulate	propositional or event	commitment / hope
+-----+-----+-----+		
ALONE: reductionism	ALONE: unauthenticated	ALONE: arbitrariness
	authority (why THIS?)	or fanaticism
+-----+-----+-----+		

THESIS: three jobs, not three rivals for one job. Mutual audit, not hierarchy.

FORMULA TO WRITE: reason regulates | revelation discloses | faith receives.

TRAP: "faith = belief without evidence" destroys the 2020 and 2023 answers at once.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 2/20: Why the clause exists, and the only datable anchors

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 2/20: Why the clause exists, and the only datable anchors

ORIGIN RAIL (conceptual, not calendar)

- 1 a tradition claims a disclosure unaided inquiry did not produce
- > 2 the claim must be RECEIVED, so trust enters
- > 3 rival traditions make INCOMPATIBLE disclosure-claims
- > 4 a test is demanded, and every candidate test is itself contestable
- ==> the clause exists because stages 3 and 4 cannot be waved away.

DATED PRINT ANCHORS (assert these years; invent no others)

1748 Hume, Enquiry, Section X	1874 Draper	1877 Clifford, Ethics of Belief
1896 White	1896 James, The Will to Believe	1979 W. C. Smith, Faith and Belief
1983 Plantinga, Reason and Belief in God		1991 Alston, Perceiving God
1997 Barbour, Religion and Science		1999 Gould, Rocks of Ages (NOMA)
2000 Barbour, When Science Meets Religion		2000 Earman, Hume's Abject Failure
2000 Plantinga, Warranted Christian Belief		

CITE BY WORK, NEVER BY YEAR: Augustine/Anselm (Proslogion 1); Aquinas (ST II-II qq.1-4); Kierkegaard (Fear and Trembling; Concluding Unscientific Postscript); Tillich (Dynamics of Faith); Buber (I-Thou); Hick (Philosophy of Religion); Gita 17.2-3; Kalama Sutta AN 3.65; Kevaddha Sutta DN 11; Yoga-sutra 3.37.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 3/20: Reason's five functions and its single limit

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 3/20: Reason's five functions and its single limit
(a) CONSTRUCT natural theology Aquinas' preambles; Nyaya inference to Isvara
(b) TEST coherence no appeal to mystery makes a contradiction true
(c) INTERPRET scripture literal / analogical / historically conditioned
(d) DEFEND (apologetics) and correlatively criticise
(e) REGULATE veto, discipline, name defeaters <= 2021 hinge
SCOPE NOTE: natural theology argues TOWARD theological conclusions;
philosophy of religion also analyses language, experience and warrant. Narrower.
RATIONALISM: Clifford - "it is wrong always, everywhere, and for anyone, to
believe anything upon insufficient evidence."
LIMIT: the proofs are inconclusive; the transcendent may EXCEED reason.
>>> EXCEED, never CONTRADICT. The whole position rests on that word. <<<
OBJECTION (Kant): speculative reason may not go beyond possible experience.
REPLY: metaphysical inference concerns the CONDITIONS of experience, not a
further observed object.
PRESUPPOSITION: reality is intelligible; reason is neither wholly corrupted nor
confined to empirical objects.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 4/20: The two middle terms that decide the marks

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 4/20: The two middle terms that decide the marks
BINARY 1 constitutive reason | >>> REGULATIVE <<< | reason irrelevant
constitutive = GENERATES religious content (strict evidentialism)
REGULATIVE = vetoes contradiction, weighs testimony, disciplines reading,
names defeaters; does NOT author content
(Aquinas; critical rationalism; Plantinga's defeasible basicity)
irrelevant = faith immune; no criticism can touch it (insulated fideism)
BINARY 2 rational | >>> SUPRA-RATIONAL <<< | irrational
rational = grounds, coherence, cumulative evidence (preambles, motives
of credibility)
SUPRA-RATIONAL = EXCEEDS proof, does not contradict it (Aquinas' mysteries;
Kierkegaard's objective uncertainty)
irrational = contradicts logic or defies decisive evidence
ENTRY FEE FOR BOTH MIDDLE SEATS: DEFEASIBILITY. A belief that no consideration
could count against has bought safety by leaving the epistemic conversation.
RULE: this clause punishes binaries. Always supply the middle column.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 5/20: Revelation on two independent axes

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 5/20: Revelation on two independent axes

	PROPOSITIONAL truths communicated	NON-PROPOSITIONAL God's acts / self-presence
GENERAL (all)	nature and conscience read as conveying truths	world experienced as gift, presence or address
SPECIAL (particular)	scripture / prophet / tradition delivering DOCTRINE for assent -> Aquinas' MYSTERIES	a particular history received as divine action; doctrine = community's interpretation -> Hick's EXPERIENCING-AS

AXIS 1 = scope and medium (who can access it?)
AXIS 2 = what revelation IS (content, or encounter?) THEY CROSS. NOT ONE LADDER.
THREE WORDS THAT ARE NOT SYNONYMS
REVELATION = the disclosure | INSPIRATION = divine-human authorship of the
record | INFALLIBILITY = freedom from error. They can come apart.
TRAP: collapsing the two axes makes the 2025 Q6(c) fifteen-marker unanswerable.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 6/20: Propositional revelation, and natural vs revealed theology

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 6/20: Propositional revelation, and natural vs revealed theology

DOCTRINE: revelation communicates divinely authorised TRUTHS that unaided reason could not discover or securely know.

ARGUMENT: (1) God can disclose -> (2) prophets and scripture mediate ->

(3) signs, testimony and coherence warrant reception -> (4) doctrine articulates.

PRESUPPOSITION: a personal God acts in history; reliable transmission is possible.

NATURAL THEOLOGY	REVEALED THEOLOGY
premises publicly accessible	premises taken to be delivered
content: that God exists, some attributes	content: the MYSTERIES - Trinity, Incarnation
= Aquinas' PREAMBLES	= accepted on disclosure, above reason not against
Indian instance: Nyaya	warranted by signs, testimony, coherence
inference to Isvara	

THE DISTINCTION IS ONE OF EPISTEMIC ACCESS - not importance, not rationality, not chronology. Both speak about God; both reason; the premises differ.

INDIAN COMPLICATION: Mimamsa's AUTHORLESS (apauruseya) Veda is authoritative and is NOT a creator God's speech -> scriptural authority with NO revealer.

OBJECTION: rival revelations + circular authentication weaken certainty.

REPLY: cumulative criteria - coherence, moral fruit, testimony, transformative power - WITHOUT pretending they are tradition-neutral.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 7/20: Non-propositional revelation and experiencing-as

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 7/20: Non-propositional revelation and experiencing-as

HICK'S CHAIN

EVENT (religiously ambiguous) -> FAITH perceives it AS divine action ->

COMMUNITY conceptualises the encounter -> DOCTRINE; diversity of doctrine now reflects differing interpretive schemes.

PRESUPPOSITION: experience is always concept-laden; divine freedom is not exhausted by statements.

KEY DISTINCTION: an event is not automatically revelation for every observer.

"Revelatory event" names an EXPERIENCED-AS structure, not a surface property.

Canonical illustration: one event, two true descriptions - secular causal, and providential.

OBJECTION: if interpretation constitutes revelation, PROJECTION threatens.

REPLY (Hick): moral-spiritual transformation; the resistance of reality to arbitrary interpretation. >>> Neither reply is decisive - say so. <<<

2022 Q5(d) VERDICT STRUCTURE

objective side : divinely communicated content would be true unreceived

subjective side: it becomes revelation FOR someone only through faith

=> faith is indispensable to RECEPTION and EFFICACY, not to occurrence.

Hold BOTH halves; conceding the first costs nothing.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 8/20: Six authentication tests, six limits

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 8/20: Six authentication tests, six limits

1 SOURCE / TESTIMONY competent, sincere, suitably placed, independently supported? LIMIT: testimony transmits error as well as truth

2 COHERENCE self-contradiction? clash with secure knowledge? LIMIT: coherence does not establish DIVINE origin

3 MORAL-SPIRITUAL FRUIT truthfulness, compassion, transformation? LIMIT: useful effects occur under FALSE beliefs

4 TRADITION / COMMUNITY publicly transmitted, criticised, corrected? LIMIT: endurance may preserve power or bias

5 EXPERIENCE + MIRACLE-SIGN event resistant to ordinary explanation, fitted to the message? LIMIT: an anomaly authenticates no ONE reading

6 CROSS-REVELATION how does it answer rival disclosures? LIMIT: criteria are rarely tradition-NEUTRAL

2024 Q7(b) VERDICT FORMULA: a revelation-claim is warranted, if at all, by a CONVERGENCE - internal coherence, moral fruits, the recipient's experience, communal transmission and congruence with reason - no one of which is decisive, and none of which is neutral between traditions.

"OWN COMMENTS" = rank the six yourself. The limits are where those marks sit.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 9/20: Circularity, competing revelation and the diversity handover

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 9/20: Circularity, competing revelation and the diversity handover

THE CIRCLE

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scripture --authenticates--> God --authorises--> scripture
^-----|
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VICIOUS if the circle is the ONLY support offered.

ARGUABLY VIRTUOUS once independent testimony, coherence, moral fruit and cross-tradition comparison enter it. Many epistemic practices use reciprocal support; the live question is whether THIS circle is vicious or a coherent web.

HERMENEUTIC RULE: scripture requires interpretation; AUTHORITY DOES NOT ELIMINATE HERMENEUTICS.

COMPETING REVELATION: rival scriptures cannot all be literally infallible in incompatible claims.

REPLY: distinguish core disclosure from historically conditioned interpretation.

COUNTER: critics fairly call that move REVISIONARY.

FIREWALL: competing revelation is used here only as an AUTHENTICATION and DIVERSITY DEFEATER. Complete pluralist theory and the absolute-truth debate belong to the Religious Pluralism owner.

HANDOVER LINE: the residual problem is DIVERSITY, not evidential poverty.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 10/20: Faith - seven tenets

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 10/20: Faith - seven tenets

(7) FRUITS a transformed pattern of life, by which it is tested

^

(6) COMMUNITY tradition that transmits AND disciplines it

^

(5) HOPE oriented to a good not yet secured

^

(4) COMMITMENT the will engages; risk is accepted

^

(3) TRUST exceeding the available evidence <== FAITH DEPARTS HERE

^

(2) ASSENT to some content; faith is never contentless feeling

^

(1) ULTIMATE OBJECT God, Brahman, dharma, or another final focus

STEPS 1-2 are shared with belief. STEP 3 is the departure.

STEPS 4-7 are what belief alone never supplies.

2020 Q7(c) RULE: the stem prints TWO deliverables. Enumerate the tenets FIRST, then run the differentia table. Doing one of the two loses about half the marks.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 11/20: Faith versus belief - six axes and the supports

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 11/20: Faith versus belief - six axes and the supports

AXIS	BELIEF	FAITH
object	a proposition	a person, reality or ultimate
grammar	believe THAT	believe IN / trust
mode	cognitive assent	assent PLUS trust, commitment, risk
voluntariness	largely involuntary	engages the will; can be GIVEN
failure-mode	falsehood	betrayal, infidelity, apostasy
degrees	degrees of confidence	degrees of fidelity and depth

DECISIVE TEST: a difference in how something can FAIL is a difference in what it IS. Betrayal is not a species of falsehood.

SUPPORTS: Aquinas - fides quae creditur (the faith WHICH is believed = content) / fides qua creditur (the faith BY WHICH one believes = act and disposition);

W. C. Smith, Faith and Belief (1979) - modern narrowing of "belief";

Tillich - ULTIMATE CONCERN, whose failure is IDOLATRY, not doubt;

Buber - the I-Thou relation is irreducible to I-It propositions.

INDIAN: Gita 17.2-3 grades trust (sraddha) sattvika / rajasa / tamasa, and "as is one's sraddha, so is one"; Advaita makes it the trust that ENABLES inquiry, replaced by realisation; Buddhist trust (Pali saddha) is verification-directed - Kalama Sutta, AN 3.65.

OBJECTION: "believing in" reduces to "believing that X exists and is trustworthy".

REPLY: one may believe a person reliable and still refuse to entrust anything.

VERDICT LINE: faith is not a weaker belief; it is a different act.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 12/20: Aquinas - the two storeys and the three-way location

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 12/20: Aquinas - the two storeys and the three-way location

ONE TRUTH, TWO ROUTES - both issue from God, so they CANNOT genuinely conflict;

apparent conflict = defective reasoning OR defective interpretation.

UPPER STOREY MYSTERIES (e.g. the Trinity) reached only through revelation

ABOVE reason, never AGAINST it

----- HINGE: MOTIVES OF CREDIBILITY -----

LOWER STOREY PREAMBLES (e.g. that God exists) reachable by unaided reason

WHERE FAITH SITS

KNOWLEDGE	FAITH	OPINION
-----------	-------	---------

firm assent WITH	firm assent WITHOUT	assent WITHOUT firmness;
------------------	---------------------	--------------------------

sight/demonstration	sight	fears the opposite is true
---------------------	-------	----------------------------

=> faith takes FIRMNESS from knowledge and UNSEENNESS from opinion: a MEAN.

THE ACT, IN FOUR MOVES: revealed truth exceeds demonstrative sight -> testimony

supplies the object -> the WILL commands the intellect where evidence is

non-coercive -> GRACE orients the person toward divine truth.

SOURCE: Summa Theologiae II-II qq.1-4. PARAPHRASE; never fabricate a quotation.

OBJECTION: will-governed belief risks VOLUNTARISM.

REPLY: motives of credibility + rational preambles make assent reasonable

though not demonstrative; the will acts only where evidence is non-coercive.

2025 Q5(e) DEMAND: the MECHANISM of reconciliation - name the two storeys and

the hinge. Description of Aquinas' piety scores nothing.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 13/20: Kierkegaard and the permission ladder

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 13/20: Kierkegaard and the permission ladder

KIERKEGAARD: objective uncertainty + infinite personal concern -> SUBJECTIVE

APPROPRIATION. Abraham dramatises the paradox and the "teleological suspension

of the ethical". TARGET = the claim that an objective system can REPLACE

existential decision.

>>> He does NOT license contradiction, irresponsibility, or evidence-free belief
in general. State this disclaimer every time. <<<

STRICTEST -----> LOOSEST

CLIFFORD	CRITICAL	JAMES	PASCAL	INSULATED
----------	----------	-------	--------	-----------

evidentialism	RATIONALISM	will-to-believe	wager	FIDEISM
---------------	-------------	-----------------	-------	---------

believe only	commit, keep	living, forced,	prudential	immune to
--------------	--------------	-----------------	------------	-----------

on sufficient	open to	momentous +	choice under	criticism
---------------	---------	-------------	--------------	-----------

evidence	criticism and	evidence cannot	uncertainty	
----------	---------------	-----------------	-------------	--

defeaters

decide

COST:	COST: nothing	COST: undecid-	COST: NO	COST: licenses
-------	---------------	----------------	----------	----------------

disqualifies	is ever finally	able options	evidence of	fanaticism;
--------------	-----------------	--------------	-------------	-------------

far more than	settled	only; NOT belief	truth; many-	forfeits
---------------	---------	------------------	--------------	----------

religion		at will	gods +	philosophical
----------	--	---------	--------	---------------

authenticity

standing

SLOGAN CONTROL: the "because it is absurd" formula is NOT verified Tertullian

wording. Use it only as a later slogan for extreme fideism.

SUPRA-RATIONAL is not IRRATIONAL: exceeding proof differs from contradicting it.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 14/20: The bench - ten positions and the risk each runs

POSITION	REASON	REVELATION	RISK
Rationalism/evidentialism (Locke, Clifford, Flew)	judge	must be evidenced	reduction of commitment
Aquinas	preambles, coherence	mysteries beyond reason	two-tier tension
Fideism	limited or irrelevant	authoritative	arbitrariness
Hick	interprets critically	event / self- disclosure	projection
Mimamsa	interprets injunction	AUTHORLESS Veda, not creator's speech	cross-tradition warrant
Advaita	manana removes doubt	sruti discloses Brahman	scriptural circularity
Reformed epist. (Plantinga)	not sole arbiter	may be received basically	RELIGIOUS DIVERSITY
Alston	critical, non-found'l	mediated in practice	circularity shared with sense perception
Barbour's typology	model-dep.	model-dependent	descriptive, not normative

FOUR RECURRING CRITICISMS + REPLIES

evidential challenge -> testimony, cumulative evidence, practical commitment
 competing revelation -> core disclosure vs historically conditioned reading
 circularity -> reciprocal support; is the circle vicious or a web?
 fideist immunity -> constrained by non-contradiction and ethical fruits
 METHOD: use TWO rows the stem forces into contact + ONE Indian row as a check.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 15/20: Evidentialism against Reformed epistemology

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 15/20: Evidentialism against Reformed epistemology

THE QUESTION IS THE STANDARD OF JUSTIFICATION - not whether God exists.

EVIDENTIALISM

LOCKE assent proportioned to the probability of the evidence
 CLIFFORD "The Ethics of Belief" (1877) - MORAL wrong to believe on
 insufficient evidence; the SHIPOWNER example
 FLEW presumption of atheism: burden on the affirmative; the default is
 NOT-believing, not agnosticism

JAMES (The Will to Believe, 1896)

where an option is LIVING, FORCED and MOMENTOUS and evidence is genuinely
 inconclusive, the passionate nature may lawfully decide; and Clifford's rule
 is ITSELF a passionate preference for avoiding error over gaining truth.
 LIMIT: undecidable options only; never belief AGAINST evidence.

PLANTINGA (1983; Warranted Christian Belief, 2000)

- (1) the objection presupposes CLASSICAL FOUNDATIONALISM: rational = self-evident, incorrigible, evident to the senses, or inferred from these
- (2) that criterion is SELF-REFERENTIALLY INCOHERENT - it is none of those
- (3) and TOO NARROW - memory, other minds, beliefs about the past
- (4) so basicity is not confined to that list
- (5) belief in God formed in appropriate circumstances (gratitude, guilt, wonder, reading scripture) is PROPERLY BASIC - grounded, not inferred

WARRANT = true belief from faculties FUNCTIONING PROPERLY, in an APPROPRIATE
 ENVIRONMENT, on a DESIGN PLAN AIMED AT TRUTH; sensus divinitatis supplies it
 without argument. PAYOFF: IF theism is true, theistic belief is very likely
 warranted -> no viable de jure objection independent of the de facto question.

GREAT PUMPKIN -> reply: grounding, DEFEASIBILITY, disciplined practice ->
 counter: criterion becomes community-relative -> "Son of Great Pumpkin"
 returns for well-established rival traditions.

ALSTON, Perceiving God (1991): no doxastic practice - sense perception
 included - can be validated non-circularly.

INDIAN ANALOGUES (EXACT, do not loosen)

Mimamsa svatah-pramanya (intrinsic validity, valid until defeated) ~ PROPER
 BASICITY | Nyaya paratah-pramanya (validity established by something
 further) ~ EVIDENTIALISM | Carvaka = the strict evidentialist limit.

VERDICT: justification is internal to a doxastic practice -> the live objection
 changes from INSUFFICIENT EVIDENCE to INCOMPATIBLE PRACTICES.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 16/20: Miracles - Hume's two Parts

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 16/20: Miracles - Hume's two Parts

HUME, Enquiry Concerning Human Understanding, SECTION X, "Of Miracles" (1748)

DEFINITION: "a violation of the laws of nature" by a particular volition of the Deity. >>> The definition is itself contested - see reply 1. <<<

PART I - THE A PRIORI BALANCE

- 1 a wise man proportions his belief to the evidence
- 2 laws of nature rest on UNIFORM, exceptionless experience - the strongest empirical evidence there is
- 3 testimony rests on experience of human reliability - strong but NOT uniform
- 4 a miracle report sets uniform against non-uniform; the weaker must yield
- 5 MAXIM: no testimony suffices unless its FALSEHOOD would be MORE MIRACULOUS than the fact it endeavours to establish - and even then, subtract the lesser marvel from the greater

PART II - FOUR A POSTERIORI CONSIDERATIONS

- (a) never enough witnesses of unquestioned good sense, education, integrity and public reputation with much to lose
- (b) a standing human PASSION FOR SURPRISE AND WONDER multiplies such reports
- (c) they flourish chiefly among ignorant and barbarous nations, or descend from such origins
- (d) CONTRARY MIRACLES CANCEL: rival religions' miracles support incompatible systems, so each set destroys the credit of the others

CONTINUED IN PANEL 17: the five replies, what survives, and the Indian contrast.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 17/20: Miracles - the five replies and the Indian contrast

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 17/20: Miracles - the five replies and the Indian contrast

FIVE REPLIES TO HUME (continued from Panel 16)

- 1 DEFINITIONAL - if a law is an exceptionless regularity, a genuine exception shows the law was MIS-STATED. SWINBURNE recasts a miracle as a non-repeatable counter-instance to an otherwise well-confirmed law.
- 2 EVIDENTIAL - SWINBURNE's principles of CREDULITY and TESTIMONY give memory, perception and report a prima facie right to be believed; Hume's rule disables them exactly where they would matter - question-begging.
- 3 BAYESIAN - EARMAN, Hume's Abject Failure (2000): PRIOR improbability is confused with POSTERIOR probability given testimony; independent witnesses of moderate reliability can raise the posterior arbitrarily high.
- 4 CIRCULARITY - (C. S. Lewis and others) to know uniform experience is against miracles you must already know all such reports are false.
- 5 CONTRARY-MIRACLES - the cancellation assumes rival reports are equally well attested and mutually exclusive.

WHAT SURVIVES: Part II as a permanent checklist of EVIDENTIAL CAUTION.

TOO STRONG: Part I, which would exclude testimony for ANY sufficiently improbable event, including well-attested scientific anomalies.

INDIAN CONTRAST (not a parallel): Yoga-sutra 3.37 declares the accomplishments (siddhi / vibhuti) OBSTACLES to samadhi though "accomplishments" in the outward-turned state; the Kevaddha Sutta (DN 11) has the Buddha reject displays of psychic power, preferring the "miracle of instruction"; Mimamsa's authorless Veda needs NO miraculous authentication.

VERDICT: Hume raises an unusually heavy burden; he does not show it unmeetable. A miracle is at best evidence FOR THOSE ALREADY INSIDE an interpretive framework that identifies which events would count as divine action.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 18/20: Science and religion - four models, four costs

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IAN BARBOUR: Religion and Science (1997); When Science Meets Religion (2000)

1 CONFLICT competing claims about the same world, so one must yield.

Two mirror versions: scientific materialism | scriptural literalism.

Historiography = the WARFARE THESIS: DRAPER, History of the Conflict between Religion and Science (1874); WHITE, A History of the Warfare of Science with Theology in Christendom (1896).

>>> NOW REJECTED by most historians of science as a polemical nineteenth-century construction. Saying so is a MARK-EARNING QUALIFICATION. <<<

2 INDEPENDENCE separate domains, questions and languages, so no conflict.

GOULD, NOMA - Non-Overlapping Magisteria, Rocks of Ages (1999): science =

empirical fact and theory; religion = ultimate meaning and moral value.

Neo-orthodoxy and Wittgensteinian language-games reach the same result.

COST: peace bought by forbidding either side to say anything the other could contest - which few believers or scientists accept.

3 DIALOGUE distinct but TOUCHING at BOUNDARY QUESTIONS - why a universe at

all, why intelligible, why constants that permit life - and at METHODOLOGICAL

PARALLELS: models, metaphors, paradigms, theory-ladenness of data in both.

COST: fruitful but non-committal; conversation, not conclusions.

4 INTEGRATION natural theology (fine-tuning); theology of nature (revising

doctrine in the light of evolution and cosmology); PROCESS THOUGHT.

COST: hostage to the science of the day.

ALTERNATIVE FRAME - HAUGHT: Conflict / Contrast / Contact / CONFIRMATION, the

last adding that religion underwrites the world's intelligibility.

INDIAN MATERIAL (distinctive, not an echo)

VIVEKANANDA - Vedanta as experience-grounded and so science-compatible;

"science of the soul" >>> report as a CLAIM, never endorse <<<

RADHAKRISHNAN - science and religion as levels of one integral experience

AUROBINDO - evolutionary metaphysics = an explicit INTEGRATION model

CLASSICAL ROOT - is the word (sabda) an INDEPENDENT means of knowledge

alongside perception (pratyaksa) and inference (anumana)? Carvaka: no.

Nyaya and Mimamsa: yes. That IS "can revelation add anything?" in Indian dress.

PRESUPPOSITION: that "science" and "religion" name two stable, comparable

things - denied by the historicist critique, since both are modern and plural.

OBJECTION: the typology is descriptively neat but NORMATIVELY EMPTY.

REPLY: it classifies; argue model by model. The defensible position is a

DOMAIN-SENSITIVE MIXTURE - independence about method, dialogue about boundary

questions, conflict only where a religious claim is genuinely empirical.

NORMATIVE POINT: technology settles what we CAN do, not what we SHOULD do, and

not what a life is for.

TRAP: do not narrate Galileo and call it the science-religion question.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 19/20: The Indian parity bench and the Advaita route

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PARITY BENCH

is testimony independent? West: Locke/Hume reduce it to experience |

India: Nyaya and Mimamsa make the word (sabda) an independent means of knowledge; Carvaka denies it

intrinsic or extrinsic validity? West: foundationalism vs proper basicity |

India: Mimamsa svatah-pramanya vs Nyaya paratah-pramanya <== EXACT PARALLEL

whose speech is scripture? West: God's word | India: Mimamsa AUTHORLESS

(apauruseya) - no author, human or divine

faith as trust? West: fides qua; Tillich's ultimate concern | India: sraddha

(Gita 17.2-3); Buddhist saddha - verification-directed (Kalama Sutta)

reason's role? West: preambles, coherence, apologetics | India: manana; tarka

auxiliary, never independently probative in Vedanta

miracles as authentication? West: central to apologetics | India: siddhis are

OBSTACLES (YS 3.37); the Buddha rejects displays <== CONTRAST, not parallel

ADVAITA ROUTE: sruti/sabda -> sraddha makes inquiry possible -> SRAVANA

(hearing) -> MANANA (reasoning removes doubt) -> NIDIDHYASANA (assimilation)

-> direct realisation; trust is REPLACED by realisation, not preserved.

CONTINUED IN PANEL 20: the eleven verified routes and the answer spine.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 20/20: The eleven verified routes and the answer spine

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 20/20: The eleven verified routes and the answer spine

ELEVEN VERIFIED OWNER PYQs (11 of 112 audited Paper II parts; 2018 owns none)

2019 Q5(a) 10m self-revelation: faith or reason -> choose faith for reception

2020 Q5(a) 10m religion vis-a-vis science/technology -> Barbour + normative

2020 Q7(c) 15m tenets of faith; faith vs belief -> seven tenets + six axes

2021 Q7(a) 20m reason and faith; reason as regulative -> regulative not constitutive

2022 Q5(d) 10m faith indispensable for revelation -> reception vs occurrence

2023 Q5(b) 10m can religious beliefs be justified -> name the STANDARD

2023 Q6(c) 15m rational and irrational aspects -> add the SUPRA-RATIONAL

2024 Q5(d) 10m role of reason in religion -> four functions + the limit

2024 Q7(b) 15m epistemic justifications of revelation -> six criteria, ranked

2025 Q5(e) 10m Aquinas' intellectual assent -> two storeys + the hinge

2025 Q6(c) 15m natural vs revealed theology -> inside the propositional model

ANSWER SPINE

10m: define the term asked -> internal relation -> one distinction -> one objection -> direct verdict

15m: frame the warrant problem -> the model in steps -> criteria of justification -> rival model or Indian comparison -> objection and reply

20m: map the three concepts -> strongest harmony and conflict models -> presuppositions -> competing-revelation and evidential objections -> Indian-Western comparison -> defended synthesis

SIX-STEP DISCIPLINE: define the disputed term | say whether the issue is source, reception, warrant or commitment | reconstruct one named position | add the strongest objection and reply | use one exact Indian comparison | end with a graded verdict AND the defeater that would change it.

QUALIFIED CONCLUSION: rational religion is neither proof without trust nor trust without criticism. Faith may go beyond coercive proof; it forfeits philosophical standing when it claims a right to go AGAINST reason, or a right to be exempt from correction.